

It will have a chairman and three members. Implementation of the time-bound delivery of service Act will be duty of the Commission. It will also be authorised to impose penalties on designated officers or any other officials involved in the process. The Bill passed by the Assembly will replace the Delhi (Right of Citizen to Time Bound Delivery of Services) Act, 2011.

It was found that the Act was inadequate to enforce stipulated timelines due to the absence of effective monitoring and enforcement mechanisms.

"They have been creating a ruckus over this for the last three days only to ensure that there is no discussion on the money being given to women," he said. "I will take them to court. I will file a defamation case," Sirsa added. Deputy Speaker Mohan Singh Bisht sought strict action and said the matter should be referred to the Privileges Committee.

Act, in respect of time available to redeem the secured assets.			
Sr. No.	Name of Borrower / Co-borrower	(1). Date of Demand Notice (2). Date of Possession (3). Amount in Demand Notice (Rs.)	
1.	1. Rajesh Vermana H.N. 32, (S1), Niti Khand-1, Indrapuram, Near Mother Dairy, GZD, Uttar Pradesh -201014 (Borrower); 2. Anjali Vermana Flat No S-1, Plot No 32, Niti Khand -1, Indrapuram, Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh- 201010 (Co-Borrower)	(1). 14-Jun-2025 (2). 7-Aug-2026 (3). Rs. 16,71,772/-	
Description of Property:-Flat No-D-1108, 11th Floor, Block-D, Antriksh Sanskriti, NH-24, Ghaziabad, Haryana - 201010			
2.	1. Nishat Akhter Flat No-134, Plot No-6, Sec-13, Dwarka, Del, Delhi - 110075 (Borrower); 2. Najmus Sheikh Rana Flat No-134, Plot No-6, Sec-13, Dwarka, New Delhi-110075 (Co-Borrower)	(1). 14-Jun-2025 (2). 7-Aug-2026 (3). Rs. 66,77,479/-	
Description of Property:-Flat No-C-1401, 14th Floor, Block-C, Antriksh Sanskriti, NH-24, Indrapuram, Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh - 201010			
3.	1. Shashi Bhushan Rai R-17/2, Second Floor, Ramesh Park Laxmi Nagar, Shakarpur New Delhi, Nirman Vihar Metro Station, Del,Delhi-110092 (Borrower); 2. Pushpa Rai R-17/2, Second Floor, Ramesh Park, Laxmi Nagar, Shakarpur, New Delhi Delhi- 110092 (Co-Borrower)	(1). 14-Jun-2025 (2). 7-Aug-2026 (3). Rs. 33,47,351/-	
Description of Property:-Unit No-D-1402, 14th Floor, Block-D, Antriksh Sanskriti, NH-24, Indrapuram, Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh - 201010			
4.	1. Shiv Singh Kandhari B-14, Shashi Ganga, Mayur Vihar Phase-I, Patparganj East Delhi, Od, Delhi- 110091 (Borrower); 2. Rajni Kandhari B-14, Shashi Ganga, Mayur Vihar Phase-I, Patparganj Delhi-110091 (Co-Borrower)	(1). 14-Jun-2025 (2). 7-Aug-2026 (3). Rs. 27,84,485/-	
Description of Property:-Unit No- E-601, 6th Floor, Tower-E, Antriksh Sanskriti Indrapuram, NH-24 Sector-63, Noida, Uttar Pradesh - 201303			
5.	1. Vandana Verma B 116, Siddharth Kunj, Plot No 17, Sector 7, Dwarka, Delhi- 110085 (Borrower); 2. Nikesh Sharan Street No. 21/3, C Samarth Colony, Third Floor, Raghuwara Patil Nagar, Pune, Maharashtra-413031 (Co-Borrower)	(1). 14-Jun-2025 (2). 07-Aug-2026 (3). Rs. 71,74,066/-	
Description of Property:-Unit No-C-1405, 14th Floor, Tower-C, Antriksh Sanskriti, NH-24, Indrapuram, Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh-201010			
6.	1. Brijendra Kumar Mishra L-350, Sector-12, Pratap Vihar, GZD, Uttar Pradesh-201001 (Borrower); 2. Shashi Prabha Mishra House No-L-350, Sector-12, Pratap Vihar, Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh-201009 (Co-Borrower)	(1). 20-Jun-2025 (2). 7-Aug-2026 (3). Rs. 37,40,861/-	
Description of Property:-Flat No G-906, 9th Floor, Block-G, Antriksh Sanskriti, NH-24, Indrapuram, Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh-201010			
7.	1. Ashu Pandey Flat No 5, UGF, Plot No 39 Avitech Appt, Shalimar Garden Ext-I Sahibabad, GZD, UP, 201005	(1). 11-Sep-2025 (2). 7-Aug-2026 (3). Rs. 6,066,652/-	
Description of Property:-Plot No -703, 7th Floor, Ebony Tower, Blc, Plot No -703 7th Floor Ebony Tower Blc, Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh - 201010			

Dated: 12-Aug-2026, Place: NOIDA
SD/-, Authorized Officer, Axis Bank Ltd.

The Pioneer

Classified

CHANGE OF NAME

I, hitherto known as M.K. Aagarwal, S/o, Dhansi Ram, R/o, E - 56 Shivaji Road, Adarsh Nagar, Delhi - 110033, have changed my name and shall hereafter be known as Mukesh Kumar.

I, No.4290062F Sep Pradip Kumar, R/o- Mo-Vishnu Nagar, Post-Anaith, Teh- Ara, Dist- Bhojpur, Bihar- 802302, have changed my Daughter's name from Prayanshi Pratap Singh to Priyanshi Pratap Singh, vide affidavit dated 11/08/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, Thankamani K, Mother of No.21004091X Nk Nithin E K, R/o- Etikkal, PO - Mayyanganam Kalichanadakka, Nleshwaram Kasargad, Kerala- 671314, have changed my name from Thankamani K to Thankamani K, vide affidavit dated 11/08/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, Bhariyani Hemangini, W/o- No.15446923K SEP/AA Vavecha Vasantbhai Pashabhai, R/o- Vill & PO- Ghodiyal, Teh- Vadgam, Dist- Banaskantha, Gujarat- 385421, have changed my name from Bhariyani Hemangini to Vavecha Hemangini Vasantbhai, vide affidavit dated 11/08/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, Shabana Salimbhai Arabi, W/o- No.14684994H Nk Randhiyavala Abdulkadar Manasurbhai, R/o- Mahmadiabag Society, Street No. 9, Vill- Vavdi, Teh & Dist- Rajkot, Gujarat- 360004, have changed my name from Shabana Salimbhai Arabi to Shabana Abdulkadar Randhiyavala, vide affidavit dated 11/08/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, Uday Prakash Falwariya, father of Arti Falwariya and son of Chetan Ram r/o D-10, Navbharat Apartment, A-4 block, Paschim Vihar, Delhi-110063 have changed my name as UDAY PRAKASH.

Traffic restricted on August 13 for I-Day full-dress rehearsal

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Traffic restrictions will be imposed in parts of Delhi on August 13 in view of the full-dress rehearsal for the Independence Day celebrations at the Red Fort, with several key roads closed and commercial vehicles and buses diverted, according to a traffic advisory.

The rehearsal for the Independence Day ceremony, to be held at the Red Fort on August 15, will be conducted on August 13. The restrictions have been put in place for security and traffic management around the Red Fort.

According to the advisory, roads around the Red Fort will remain closed to general traffic from 4 am to 10 am on August 13. Only vehicles car-

rying valid rehearsal labels will be permitted on these stretches.

The affected roads include Netaji Subhash Marg from Delhi Gate to Chatta Rail Chowk, Lothian Road from GPO Delhi to Chatta Rail Chowk, S P Mukherjee Marg from H C Sen Marg to Yamuna Bazar Chowk, Chandni Chowk Road from Fountain Chowk to Red Fort, Nishad Raj Marg from Ring Road to Netaji Subhash Marg, Esplanade Road and its link road to Netaji Subhash Marg, and Ring Road between Rajghat and ISBT.

The traffic police have advised vehicles without parking labels for the rehearsal to avoid India Gate C-Hexagon, Copernicus Marg, Mandi House, Sikandra Road, W-Point, A-Point Tilak Marg,

Mathura Road, BSZ Marg, Netaji Subhash Marg and J L Nehru Marg.

Commuters have also been advised to avoid Ring Road between Nizamuddin Khatta and ISBT Kashmere Gate, and the Outer Ring Road stretch between Nizamuddin Khatta and ISBT Kashmere Gate via the Salimgarh bypass during the restricted period. For north-south movement, commuters can use Aurobindo Marg, Safdarjung Road, Kamal Ataturk Marg, Kautilya Marg, S Marg, 11 Murti, Mother Teresa Crescent, Park Street, Mandir Marg, Panchkuian Road and Rani Jhansi Road, according to the advisory.

Another alternative route is available through Connaught Place, Minto Road, Bhaybhuti Marg, Ajmeri Gate, Shradhanand Marg, Lahori



Gate Chowk, Naya Bazar, Peeli Kothi and S P Mukherjee Marg up to the ODRS.

Motorists can also cross the Yamuna through Nizamuddin Bridge and take Pushta Road, GT Road and Yudhister Setu to reach ISBT and northern Delhi, the advisory read.

For east-west movement, the traffic police have sug-

gested routes through NH-24/NH-9, Nizamuddin Khatta, Barapulla Road and Ring Road. Vehicles from DND can take Barapulla Road or proceed via Ashram on Ring Road.

Other alternatives include Vikas Marg, IP Marg, DDU Marg and Minto Road before proceeding through

Connaught Place or Ajmeri Gate. Pushta Road, GT Road and Yudhister Setu can also be used to reach ISBT Kashmere Gate.

The DND-NH-24/NH-9-Yudhister Setu-Signature Bridge-Wazirabad Bridge route will remain open for reaching Ring Road.

However, the Old Iron Bridge and Geeta Colony Bridge towards Shanti Van will remain closed.

The movement of goods vehicles will be restricted between Nizamuddin Khatta and Wazirabad Bridge from midnight on August 12 until 11 am on August 13. Interstate buses will not be allowed between Maharana Pratap ISBT and Sarai Kale Khan ISBT during the same period.

Local city buses, including DTC buses, will not operate

on Ring Road between ISBT Kashmere Gate and the NH-24/NH-9 or NH 'T' point at Nizamuddin Khatta from midnight to 11 am and will take alternative routes.

Several roads will also remain closed to inter-city and DTC buses during this period, including Lothian Road, Netaji Subhash Marg, S P Mukherjee Marg, Ring Road between Nizamuddin Khatta and the northern loop of ISBT Kashmere Gate, and stretches around C-Hexagon, Sher Shah Road, Dr Zakir Hussain Road, Pandara Road, Shahjahan Road, Akbar Road, Rajpath, Ashoka Road, KG Marg, Copernicus Marg, Tilak Marg, Purana Quila Road, Sikandra Road, Bhagwan Dass Road and BSZ Marg, it read.

Restrictions will also apply

on Ashoka Road between Windsor Place and C-Hexagon, KG Marg between Ferozeshah Road and C-Hexagon, Vikas Marg beyond the loop towards Delhi Secretariat, and Mathura Road between Ashram Chowk and W Point.

Buses normally terminating at Red Fort, Jama Masjid and Delhi Main Railway Station will be curtailed at designated points. Buses approaching from south and west Delhi will terminate opposite Ramliila Ground on J L N Marg, while those coming from north, north-west and east Delhi will be curtailed at Mori Gate and Tis Hazari. Buses approaching from north Delhi via Ring Road will terminate at Boulevard Road opposite Maharaja Agrasen Park.

Woman killed after BMW hits her near Delhi Cantt, driver held

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A 48-year-old woman who worked as cleaning staff at the Delhi Cantonment Board was killed after a BMW car struck her near Delhi Cantt on Tuesday afternoon. The driver, identified as Deepak, 38, a professional driver who was returning from the airport alone in the vehicle, was apprehended by police after a case was registered at Delhi Cantt police station.

The deceased has been identified as Jaiwanti, a resident of East Mehram Nagar. She was on her way home when the car hit her. Bystanders shifted her immediately to DDU Hospital, where doctors declared her brought dead. Police received the PCR call at around 12 pm, rushed to the spot, and initiated an inquiry. The offending vehicle is a BMW.

According to police, the accident occurred at around 12 noon when Jaiwanti was crossing the road at a zebra crossing to go home for lunch.



The impact was severe, and the woman died on the spot.

An official said that a case has been registered and legal action has been initiated. The driver of the BMW allegedly involved in the accident was identified as Deepak (38), a resident of Pratap Nagar in Mandoli.

"We have apprehended the driver, and further investigation is in progress," he said.

After the accident, local villagers gathered and blocked the road in protest, disrupting traffic movement in the area. A heavy police force, includ-



ing paramilitary, was deployed to maintain law and order.

Police said that a PCR call reported that a car had hit a woman, after which they immediately reached the spot and found that the victim had already been shifted to DDU Hospital, where she was declared dead.

"During initial inquiry, the deceased was identified as Jaiwanti, a resident of East Mehram Nagar. It was revealed that while she was on the road, she was suddenly hit by the car," said the

officer. Police said that Deepak has been working as a driver for the last six months and was returning from the airport alone when the accident occurred.

The victim's daughter-in-law said that her mother-in-law was returning home when the car hit her and fled the spot.

"She was returning home when the car hit her. We rushed to the spot after receiving the information and found her lying on the road. My husband immediately took her to the hospital and

informed the police. We want justice for her," she said.

She further said that her husband had died around five years ago, and she had been earning for the family since then.

Jaiwanti's daughter alleged that the accused driver fled the spot after hitting her mother.

"The driver fled after hitting my mother. We wanted to meet him and ask him why he was driving so fast and why he did not slow down while passing through the area. If he had been driving carefully and at a controlled speed, perhaps this tragedy could have been avoided," she said.

The victim's son said she was returning home for lunch when the accident took place and alleged that the stretch had witnessed several accidents in the past.

"Several incidents have taken place in this area earlier as well. Many of us have complained to authorities about the need for a speed breaker or traffic signals because vehicles often pass through this

stretch at high speed," he said.

"We have been told that the accused driver has been arrested, but he fled from the spot after hitting my mother. He could have at least taken her to a nearby hospital or called for medical assistance.

"Had my mother received timely treatment, her life might have been saved. Instead, she was left bleeding on the road. We want strict action against the driver and justice for my mother," he said.

Following the accident and subsequent protest by villagers, traffic movement was affected near the Terminal-3 (T-3) of IGI Airport and adjoining areas.

"Due to a fatal road accident at Mehram Nagar, opposite Police Colony, the road stretch between NSG Red Light and T-3 is presently closed due to obstruction by local villagers," Delhi Traffic Police said in a post on X.

The traffic police had advised commuters to take alternative routes.

CM Rekha slams previous AAP Government over CAG findings

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Tuesday slammed the previous AAP Government in Delhi, citing findings from Comptroller and Auditor General (CAG) reports, and asserted that her administration is using "pesticides", referring to her government's reforms, to flush out "termites" affecting governance, development and execution of schemes and projects.

The Chief Minister read them out one by one: 45 tenders worth ₹530 crore processed through a single PAN card. Nearly ₹20,000 crore left unspent in a single budget year. Utilisation certificates for schemes worth ₹19,973 crore pending. Not a single rupee spent on 32 schemes despite budget allocations of over ₹1,517 crore.

Replying to a debate in the Assembly regarding two CAG reports on the finances and performance of the former Delhi Government, the chief minister alleged that it was seeped in "scams" and headed by a chief minister (Arvind Kejriwal), who she claimed had no departmental oversight yet made all decisions without signing files.

The reports, she said, are the report card of the previous AAP Government, pre-



pared not by any political party but by the constitutional audit authority, and they expose a pattern of funds allocated, schemes announced, advertisements published, and money left unspent or improperly accounted for.

The CAG report has been sent to the Public Accounts Committee of the House. The chief minister said 19 CAG reports have been tabled in the Assembly during the present government's one-and-a-half-year tenure.

On the single PAN card tender irregularity, the Chief Minister questioned how 45 tenders involving ₹530 crore could have been processed through one PAN card and who was monitoring the process at each level.

On unspent funds, she said the budget for 2024-25 was ₹80,798 crore but actual expenditure was only around ₹61,000 crore, leaving nearly

₹20,000 crore unspent. She said capital expenditure on roads, flyovers, schools, and development works was not the previous Government's priority. On utilisation certificates, the Chief Minister said 1,734 certificates related to schemes worth ₹19,973 crore were pending while only 482 had been submitted.

A utilisation certificate specifies when, where, and how funds were spent and whether prescribed procedures were followed. Their non-submission, she said, directly undermines monitoring of actual fund usage.

She cited specific examples of unused central funds: ₹150 crore from the Centre for Ayushman centres and cards was not spent and returned. ₹40 crore for the School of Specialised Excellence saw zero expenditure. ₹40 crore under the National Food Security Act was also returned.

Police ban kite flying near I-Day venues over security concerns

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Police has prohibited kite flying and the use of other aerial objects at or around places in central Delhi where Independence Day-related programmes or public gatherings are being organised, citing security concerns.

The order, issued by Central District Deputy Commissioner of Police Rohit Rajbir Singh under Section 163 of the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita (BNSS), came into force with immediate effect and will remain in force till August 16, both days inclusive, unless



withdrawn earlier.

According to the order, kite flying from rooftops, public places and other elevated locations could pose a risk to pedestrians, motorists and other members of the public and may result in accidents and injuries.

It also said increased kite-flying activity during Independence Day celebra-

tions could cause obstruction and inconvenience to the public. The order further prohibits activities likely to cause obstruction, danger, annoyance or inconvenience to the public or disturb peace and tranquillity during the celebrations.

All persons, establishments, institutions and organisers in the central district have been directed to comply with police instructions related to Independence Day security arrangements.

Any person violating the order will be liable for action under Section 223 of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS), the order said.

Delhi discoms urge kite flyers to avoid metal-coated manja

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Power discoms have issued advisories for kite flyers ahead of Independence Day and Rakshabandhan celebrations in Delhi, urging them to maintain caution and refrain from using metal-coated manja (kite string) that can pose danger to life.

Metal-coated manja, popularly known as Chinese manja, is a potent conductor of electricity which after coming in contact with over-

head power lines can cause electric shocks, electrocution, equipment damage and widespread power disruptions.

BSES discoms said in an advisory that kite flyers should stay away from electrical installation and added that metal-coated manja poses severe risks of power-line tripping and electrocution.

The tripping of a single 33/66 kV overhead line can disrupt power supply to over 10,000 residents, while the tripping of a single 11 kV line can affect over 2,500 resi-



dents. Several kite-flying-related trippings are reported every year, it said in a statement. BSES operations and maintenance teams are on high alert for kite-flying-related contingencies ahead

of Independence Day.

"With kite-flying activity expected to increase ahead of Independence Day, BSES urges residents to use only cotton or other natural-fibre thread free from metallic or glass components and to fly kites away from power lines and electrical installations," said the BSES advisory.

"The kite-flying tradition on festivals can turn dangerous, even fatal, when metal-coated manja is used," it said. The discoms have also appealed to elders and parents to stop

their children from entering prohibited or barricaded areas around electrical installations to retrieve kites. Tata Power Delhi Distribution Limited (TPDDL) discom has also appealed for safe kite flying near power lines ahead of Independence Day.

Flying kites close to power infrastructure can lead to electricity-related accidents, power disruptions, and risks to public safety. The metal-coated thread used in flying kites can cause electric lines to trip, it said in a statement.

From jail, Sukesh writes Jacqueline a birthday letter, gifts her film studio in LA, women's football club in UK

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

On Jacqueline Fernandez's birthday on August 11, a letter dated the same day arrived bearing the name of Sukesh Chandrashekhar, the alleged conman currently in judicial custody in a ₹200 crore extortion and money laundering case, in which Fernandez herself is a named accused.

The letter, a copy made public, promised her two birthday gifts: a film studio in Los Angeles named JF Studios and a freehold football

stadium in East Midlands, United Kingdom, along with an all-women's Premier football club called JF-FC.

The letter addressed Fernandez as "My Jackie," "My Bomma," and "My Botta Bomma," and ran across several paragraphs of romantic declaration before arriving at the gifts. On the studio, Chandrashekhar wrote that it was a dream she had always wanted, now made a reality, a place where creativity and excellence come together under her initials, comparable, he said, to the

Taj Mahal as a monument of love. On the football club, he wrote that he had recently seen women showing off their football boyfriends and was instead giving her a football team and stadium in her name. The letter concluded with the line: "All these difficult days are over. They happened because of me, now they will end by me."

The context in which these lines were written is not incidental. A Delhi court in May 2026 ordered charges to be framed against Chandrashekhar, Fernandez,



and others in the ₹200 crore extortion and money laundering case, with all accused



directed to appear in court.

Fernandez subsequently withdrew her Supreme Court

plea challenging the ED's prosecution complaint and trial court charges in the money laundering case in June 2026.

The money laundering investigation originates from allegations that Chandrashekhar cheated the wives of former Ranbaxy promoters Shivinder Singh and Malvinder Singh of nearly ₹200 crore.

Fernandez has been accused of receiving gifts from Chandrashekhar that were bought with extortion money, while she has main-

tained she was an innocent victim of his schemes.

The birthday letter, with its promises of a Los Angeles studio and a British football club gifted in the name of a woman facing trial in a money laundering case, carries its own complications. Whether JF Studios in Los Angeles or the East Midlands stadium and JF-FC actually exist as legal entities or represent aspirational declarations from a man in judicial custody is not established by the letter itself.

What the letter does estab-

lish is that Chandrashekhar's communication with Fernandez, or at least his communication directed toward her, continues from custody, and that his style of expression remains what it has been throughout the case: extravagant, romantic, and pitched at a register designed to overwhelm rather than inform.

The case against both continues in a Delhi court. Fernandez's withdrawal of her Supreme Court plea means the trial will proceed at the session's court level.

IN FOCUS



A mahout stands on an elephant as it splashes water while bathing in a water body at Pobitora Wildlife Sanctuary on the eve of World Elephant Day in Morigaon district of Assam

Abhishek Porel arrested over marriage promise complaint

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Kolkata

The Calcutta High Court on Tuesday adjourned till September 14 hearing of a petition by a woman accusing Bengal cricketer Abhishek Porel of sexual relations with her on the promise of marriage, following a prayer by the West Bengal Government for taking steps post his arrest.

Porel was arrested on Monday night in connection with the complaint by the medical student. A report was placed before the court of Justice Saugata Bhattacharyya, and an adjournment was sought by the State to enable the police authorities to take forward the investigation.

Another accused in the case, a friend of Porel, is yet to be apprehended.

Adjourning the hearing, Justice Bhattacharyya directed that the matter be listed for hearing again on September 14.

Porel, who has played for Delhi Capitals in the IPL, was arrested by the police in Hooghly district following a



Abhishek Porel

complaint by the medical student, alleging he had sexual relations with her on the promise of marriage, an official said.

The district court at Chinsurah remanded Porel to three-day police custody, denying his bail plea.

The high court had directed the police to arrest the cricketer in connection with the case, and ordered the seizure of his electronic devices to prevent the dissemination of photographs of the complainant.

President Murmu assents to Vande Mataram Bill

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

President Droupadi Murmu on Tuesday gave assent to the Vande Mataram Bill, granting the national song the same legal protection as the national anthem, Jana Gana Mana. The Bill has now become a law.

Parliament passed the Prevention of Insults to National Honour (Amendment) Bill, 2026, last month, amending the Prevention of Insults to National Honour Act, 1971. The legislation seeks to give Vande Mataram the same statutory protection as the national anthem.

With the President's assent, the bill has become a law. Now, such offences are punishable with imprisonment up to three years, a fine, or both.

Earlier, the Prevention of Insults to National Honour Act prohibited intentionally preventing the singing of the national anthem (Jana Gana Mana) or causing disturbance to any assembly engaged in such singing.



These offences were punishable by up to three years' imprisonment, a fine, or both, while a second and every subsequent conviction attracted a minimum of one year's imprisonment. The erstwhile law did not accord the same protection for the national song.

"Presently, there is no specific legal provision to prevent insults to the singing of 'Vande Mataram', which is honoured as the national song. Therefore, to prohibit any person from intentionally preventing the singing of the national song or causing disturbance to

any assembly engaged in such singing, it is proposed to amend Section 3 of the said Act to include the national song also within its ambit, to make such acts punishable," the Bill had said.

The president of the Constituent Assembly, Dr Rajendra Prasad, on January 24, 1950, stated that the song 'Vande Mataram' composed by Bankim Chandra Chatterjee, which played a historic role in the Indian freedom struggle, shall be honoured equally with the national anthem 'Jana Gana Mana' and shall have equal

status with it, the Bill further said.

For the first time at the Independence Day function, Vande Mataram will be sung from the ramparts of the Red Fort this year.

Earlier this year, the Union Home Ministry directed that all six stanzas of 'Vande Mataram' shall be sung first when the national song and the national anthem are played together.

In an order dated January 28, the home ministry gave the first set of protocols for singing the national song, directing that six stanzas of it, having a duration of 3 minutes and 10 seconds, shall be sung at official functions such as the arrival of the president, unfurling of the national flag, and speeches of governors.

"When the national song and the national anthem are sung or played, the national song will be sung or played first," the order read. The assembly where the national song is sung shall stand in attention, it said.

GDA welcomes Kanwar devotees with flowers



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Ghaziabad

The Meerut Road reverberated with chants of "Har Har Mahadev" and "Bam Bam Bhole" as the Ghaziabad Development Authority (GDA) organised a grand welcome for Kanwar devotees on Monday. A floral shower was conducted on thousands of Shiva devotees passing through Meerut Road, opposite Manan Dham, from 1:00 pm to 3:30 pm.

The programme witnessed the participation of Muradnagar MLA Ajit Pal Tyagi, Sadar MLA Sanjeev Sharma, Police Commissioner Ravindra J Gaur, Municipal Commissioner Vikramaditya Singh Malik, GDA Vice-Chairman Nand Kishore Kalal, Chief Development Officer Kumar Saurabh and Regional Passport Officer Anuj Swaroop, along with other senior officials and public representatives.

Capital steps up security ahead of Independence Day

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Police has put the Capital on high alert in the run up to the Independence Day and put up posters of 19 most-wanted terrorists across the city. The terrorists are linked to the Indian Mujahideen, Al-Qaeda, and several Khalistani groups.

This is part of the usual security steps taken before August 15 to raise public awareness and ask for help in finding people seen as threats. Officials say this is a required safety step taken every year before big national events. The posters, which show identification details and mugshots, have been put up in markets, railway stations, bus terminals, metro stations, and other crowded places.

Police are offering rewards for credible information to helps locate these suspects and promise to keep infor-



Representative image

ISTOCK

mants' identities confidential. People are asked to call the police control room at 112 or the Special Cell right away if they recognise anyone or have useful information.

Those from Indian Mujahideen list includes Riyaz Bhatkal and Shabandri Mohammad Iqbal (also called Iqbal Bhatkal). Al-Qaeda suspects named are Mohammad

Sharjeel Akhtar, Abu Sufiyan, and Syed Mohammad Arshiyar.

For the Khalistani groups, the posters show Ranjit Singh (Neeta) and Paramjit Singh Pamma from the Khalistan Zindabad Force, Arshdeep Singh (Arsh Dala) from the Khalistan Tiger Force, and Harvinder Singh Sandhu (Rinda), Wadhawa Singh

Babbar, and Gurmeet Singh Bagga from Babbar Khalsa International (BKI). The remaining 19 are other operatives.

The Red Fort, where the main Independence Day event happens, has been put under a heavy security blanket. About 15,000 to 20,000 Delhi Police and paramilitary staff will be on duty for August 15. Over 1,000 CCTV cameras with AI video analytics have been set up at the Red Fort and other key spots for real-time monitoring, crowd control, and quick detection of suspicious activity. The security plan also includes facial recognition, anti-drone systems, snipers, and bans on kite and drone flying.

This year, there will also be random fingerprint checks using the Abhigyan app, which has a database of over one crore criminal records, and more surveillance at transport hubs and Government buildings.

AI pilot fails drug test after altitude scare

Reuters reported that the civil aviation ministry had summoned Wilson in connection with the flight's altitude loss, while Air India and the ministry had not publicly commented on the reported confirmatory result at the time of publication.

The drug-test finding is only one strand of an investigation that is also examining possible technical problems aboard the aircraft.

Sources previously indicated that the flight may have experienced an autopilot disconnect, hydraulic-system failures and other technical anomalies around the time of the altitude loss.

There have also been reports of a flight-control stall warning and indicator switches briefly going off. The AAIB will have to establish the precise sequence of events and determine whether the reported technical issues, turbulence and loss of altitude were connected.

The incident was initially attributed by the Government and airline to severe turbulence. Subsequent reports of possible aircraft-system problems have widened the scope of the investigation. Airbus and France's Bureau of Enquiry and Analysis for Civil Aviation Safety (BEA) are expected to assist the AAIB investigation.

Soren cancels JPSC exams amidst protests

The CM said, "I wish to share a few thoughts with you all — and perhaps bring a touch of amusement to the proceedings. I want to address my colleagues in the Opposition. They harbour great expectations of us. While the people of the State have hopes — and we are working to fulfill them — the Opposition's expectations and aspirations are so vast that I cannot even fathom how many lifetimes it would take to satisfy them."

He stated that the Opposition is playing politics in the name of students and attempting to mislead them. The CM affirmed that the Government is serious about the students' future and is taking necessary steps to improve the examination system. He noted that the Government has already decided to cancel several examinations and order inquiries into them. He further remarked that these individuals mislead people by wearing saffron robes and are now conspiring while posing as students.

Meanwhile, a day after their march to the Assembly and police action, different groups of agitating students announced on Tuesday that they will continue with their protests and hunger strike till their demands are met. JPSC-JSSC Reforms Manch representative Piyush

Kumar said that even after the lathi charge and police action on students they have decided to continue with the protests till the Government accepts all their demands.

Notably, the State Government has accepted many of the demands of the students except CBI probe in 14th JPSC PT exams and scrapping of the JSSC-CGL exam. But the students are adamant on all their demands to be accepted by the Government.

Adani case ends without trial in US

The court reserved judgment on Count One (Foreign Corrupt Practices Act violations) and Count Five (obstruction of justice) as they relate to non-appearing defendants, pending further compliance by the Government with Rule 48(a).

The indictment, unsealed in November 2024, alleged Adani Group executives paid roughly \$265 million in bribes to Indian Government officials to secure solar-power contracts projected to generate more than \$2 billion in profits, while misleading investors who helped raise nearly \$4 billion in US financing, and that other defendants destroyed evidence and lied to federal investigators. The Adani Group has consistently denied the allegations, calling them baseless.

"Truth has prevailed," Gautam Adani said in response to the ruling, adding that he respected the judicial process and thanked those who had stood by the group through the proceedings, while reaffirming its commitment to "nation-building" and "long-term value creation."

The order followed the Justice Department's decision to seek dismissal after an extensive review of the case. In its submissions before the court, the US Government said continuing the prosecution no longer served the interests of justice, citing significant jurisdictional and evidentiary challenges, the predominantly Indian nature of the alleged conduct, the fact that Indian authorities had examined the matter, the absence of identified investor losses and broader public-interest considerations. US District Judge Nicholas Garaufis granted the Justice Department's Rule 48(a) motion to dismiss Counts Two, Three and Four of the indictment against Gautam Adani, Sagar Adani and former Adani Green CEO Vneet Jaain.

The court found that the DOJ had met the legal requirements for dismissal on one ground: its argument that alleged statements about Adani Green's anti-bribery policies and corporate compliance could amount to "inactionable puffery" — broad statements that investors could not reasonably rely on — creating legal risks for the prosecution.

In his sworn declaration, Gautam Adani categorically denied the existence of any promise, offer, quid pro quo or undisclosed agreement relating to the DOJ's decision. After reviewing the

FROM PAGE - 1

Government's submissions and the sworn declarations, the court accepted the motion and permanently dismissed the case.

The dismissal means the criminal proceedings concluded before trial. No witnesses were examined, no evidence was tested in court and no judicial findings were made on the underlying criminal allegations.

CM slams AAP MLA over viral video

"Your behaviour is shameful. You should at least dress properly when women come to you to get their papers signed," the CM said. "Tell them to get the signboard removed in such a situation. I saw their reel. Delhi's people are questioning you. You should be ashamed. I have seen the recordings. This is not how a public representative should behave," she added.

Referring to the video during the Monsoon Session of the Delhi Assembly, the CM criticised the MLA over his attire and said public representatives should maintain decorum, particularly when interacting with women constituents. The CM also accused Jha of making obscene gestures during the Assembly proceedings and demanded action against him. "The House is the supreme forum for democratic decorum and dignity. The uncivil behavior of the Aam Aadmi Party and their MLA will not be tolerated under any circumstances. A complaint will be lodged at the appropriate level in this regard," she said while speaking to reporters.

Jha denied the CM's allegation and challenged her to produce video evidence of him making any such gestures. "Let them show it, bring out the video, what did I say? Their people discuss so many things here, but the CM does not say anything about that. When the history of the future is written and such instances of bias are discussed, there will be big question marks over them. No one made any gesture..." he said.

Govt offers talks on student stir with caveat

Sources also said the Monsoon Session of Parliament will conclude on Friday and the chances of taking up the Bill for discussion are bleak. But if there is consensus, the Government can make a statement on sending it to a JPC.

Parliament has barely functioned since July 20, when a police crackdown against student protesters during their march to the Parliament, which brought central Delhi to a standstill. Several students and cops were injured as the protesters, led

by the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP), demanded the resignation of the then Union education minister, Dharmendra Pradhan over exam paper leaks.

Pradhan resigned on July 30, but the Congress and the Opposition stepped up their protests over the alleged police excesses on students. Videos and images later surfaced showing protesters with pellet injuries. Since then, the Opposition has maintained that the deadlock in Parliament would continue till Amit Shah made a statement over the police action on students in the Capital.

Leader of the Opposition Rahul Gandhi has particularly urged Shah to tell the Parliament who ordered the "firing against students" on July 20, saying that he was "not interested in fantasy conversations".

"The question was never that Amit Shah is going to come and give a speech in Parliament. The question was always that Amit Shah has to make it clear who authorised the shooting in Delhi," Rahul said at a press conference on Monday.

Rahul has also demanded an apology from Prime Minister Narendra Modi to the affected students and called for accountability over the donation theft in Ram Mandir in Ayodhya. The Congress MP has termed these three demands as "non-negotiables" to break the Parliament logjam.

Sources said the Government is also willing to debate on Rahul's demand for a discussion on the alleged embezzlement of donations at the Ram Temple. However, any discussion will take place after a debate on the other issues.

Another bone of contention between the Government and the opposition has been the proposed amendments to the FCRA Bill.

However, the opposition itself seems to be divided on the FCRA bill itself. The sticking point is the provision that the bill proposes the creation of a designated authority to oversee foreign contributions and assets of organisations whose FCRA registration is cancelled.

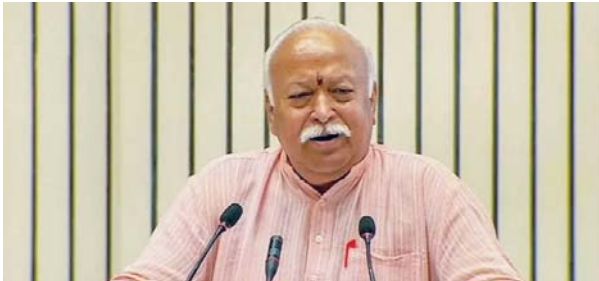
The Opposition and some outfits have argued that it would increase Government control over civil society and disrupt nonprofit work.

While Congress has demanded the withdrawal of the FCRA Bill, other parties have taken different positions. Sources said the Trinamool Congress (TMC) initially wanted the Bill to be referred to a JPC. However, it later demanded that it be withdrawn. The DMK has taken a middle position, communicating that the Bill either be withdrawn or sent to a JPC. Naveen Patnaik's BJD, meanwhile, has sought that the legislation be referred to a JPC.

Delhi unveils four tourism circuits

"Delhi's greatest strength lies in its unity in diversity. People from almost every State of the country live in Delhi and keep their cultures, traditions and festivals alive here. From Gujarat's *garba* and

Conflicts won't exist if sense of belonging grows: Bhagwat



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Nagpur

RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat on Tuesday said universal consciousness binds humanity, and if people realise this common connection and shape their behaviour accordingly, then the obstacles and crises won't exist in the world.

Bhagwat performed puja at the famous Ganesh Tekdi temple in Nagpur, and inaugurated the temple's sanctum.

Addressing a gathering on the temple's premises, the Sangh chief said universal consciousness pervades all.

"Lord Ganesh is a source of energy and represents the true meaning of organisation. Everybody is subtly aware of this sense of belonging and feels connected.

What is true unity? We all are expressions of the same energy," Bhagwat said.

If this universal consciousness is understood, the person's behaviour with himself, others and the world changes, he said.

"In common languages, we identify this feeling as a sense of belonging. If this feeling is consciously strengthened and one shapes his or her behaviour, then obstacles in our world won't exist.

"All the impediments and crises we see in the world today exist because we have forgotten the sense of belonging. And there is only one real remedy: Our personal, collective, national and international conduct should be based on that sense of belonging. Then obstacles will cease to exist," Bhagwat added.

India-China border situation will reflect on bilateral ties, says MEA

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

India on Tuesday said the situation along its border with China would have a direct bearing on the state of the broader bilateral relationship, stressing that maintaining peace and tranquillity along the Line of Actual Control (LAC) remains a matter of “utmost importance”.

The Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) also rejected China’s objections to India’s recent move to assign standard names to 27 places and geographical features in Arunachal Pradesh. India reiterated that Arunachal Pradesh is an “inalienable and integral” part of the country and said no action by China could alter that reality.

Addressing a regular media briefing, MEA spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said India has consistently conveyed to Beijing that issues concerning the border areas are regarded as particularly serious. “In matters relating to the border areas between India and China, we have always emphasised in discussions with the Chinese side that we consider these issues as most serious,” Jaiswal said.

“The maintenance of peace and tranquillity in these areas



MEA spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal

PTI

is of the utmost importance. We have also stated that the state of the border affairs will reflect on the state of our larger bilateral ties,” he added. Jaiswal said the position was reiterated during a meeting of the Working Mechanism for Consultation and Coordination on India-China Border Affairs (WMCC) held last week.

According to the MEA spokesperson, the two sides held “frank discussions” and reviewed the situation along the LAC during the meeting.

“The Indian side again underlined that maintaining peace and tranquillity in the border areas is essential for the overall development of bilateral relations,” Jaiswal said. He added that both sides agreed to continue using existing diplomatic and military channels, including the WMCC, local commander-level meetings and other

established mechanisms, to address outstanding issues and prevent misunderstandings and miscalculations along the LAC.

Responding to China’s criticism of India’s naming of 27 places in Arunachal Pradesh, Jaiswal firmly rejected Beijing’s position.

India has repeatedly maintained that Arunachal Pradesh is an integral and inalienable part of the country and that assigning standard names to places within Indian territory does not alter their status.

The latest exchange comes as India and China continue efforts to stabilise relations following years of tensions along the border. Relations between the two countries came under severe strain after the deadly Galwan Valley clashes in 2020, followed by a prolonged military standoff along the LAC in

eastern Ladakh. Over the past two years, however, New Delhi and Beijing have taken a series of steps aimed at rebuilding bilateral ties.

In October 2024, the two sides reached an agreement on disengagement at Depsang and Demchok, the last two major friction points in eastern Ladakh. The development paved the way for a renewed diplomatic engagement between the two countries. Soon after the agreement, Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Chinese President Xi Jinping met in Kazan and discussed measures to improve bilateral relations. In August last year, Modi travelled to Tianjin, China, to attend the annual Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) summit, where he held extensive talks with Xi on the sidelines of the meeting. During those discussions, Modi said India remained committed to advancing relations with China on the basis of mutual trust, mutual respect and mutual sensitivity.

Despite the recent efforts to improve ties, India has continued to emphasise that peace and tranquillity along the border are essential for sustained progress in the broader relationship.

Govt blocks 3,718 misleading apps

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

The Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) has stepped up its efforts against cybercrime, blocking 3,718 mobile apps, including fake loan apps, up to June 30, 2026. The ministry has also recovered or prevented losses of over ₹11,158 crore in financial frauds, according to Minister of State for Home Affairs Bandi Sanjay Kumar, who shared this information with the Lok Sabha in a written reply on Monday.

The Indian Cyber Crime Coordination Centre (I4C), part of the ministry, leads efforts to fight all types of cybercrime. One important tool is the National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal (NCRP) at cybercrime.gov.in, which lets people report incidents online, especially those involving women and children. The Sahyog Portal also helps by making it faster to send notices to IT companies under Section 79(3)(b) of the Information Technology Act, 2000. This system helps quickly remove or block access to illegal content, data, or links. The 3,718 apps were blocked under Section 69A and Section 79(3)(b) of the IT Act, showing how many misleading and fake apps are in the digital marketplace. One major achievement is the Citizen Financial



Cyber Fraud Reporting and Management System (CFCFRMS), started in 2021 by I4C. This system lets people report financial fraud right away so authorities can act before money is lost.

By June 30, 2026, the system had handled over 32.80 lakh complaints and helped save more than ₹11,158 crore for victims. The Suspect Registry, which tracks cybercriminal identifiers, was launched on September 10, 2024, with help from banks and financial institutions. By June 2026, banks had shared over 30.48 lakh suspect data points.

As a result, 32.08 lakh mule accounts were flagged, stopping transactions worth ₹25,698 crore. At the same time, the Government blocked more than 15.75 lakh SIM cards and 5.77 lakh IMEI numbers reported by police. To make handling complaints faster and more consistent, the ministry has

created a Standard Operating Procedure for the NCRP-CFCFRMS system. This SOP sets clear steps for processing complaints, working with banks, resolving grievances, removing lien markings, and returning stolen funds. Two important modules, the Money Restoration Module for quickly returning money to victims and the Grievance Redressal Module for dealing with frozen accounts and lien markings, started working in April 2026. Besides enforcement, the Government has also launched a large public awareness campaign.

The campaign includes a nationwide caller-tune, SMS alerts, ads on TV and radio, cinema hall promotions, school programs, digital displays at railway stations and airports, celebrity endorsements, and messages linked to the IPL. The I4C’s social media handles on X (@CyberDost), Facebook

(CyberDostI4C), Instagram (CyberDostI4C) and Telegram (cyberdosti4c)—regu), Facebook (CyberDostI4C), Instagram (CyberDostI4C), and Telegram (cyberdosti4c) regularly share advisories.

A handbook for adolescents and students has been published. Cyber Safety and Security Awareness weeks are held with state and Union Territory Governments, and MyGov helps with publicity across different platforms. Officials say that using technology, working together, protecting the financial system, and raising public awareness are all making a real difference.

Recovery of thousands of crores demonstrates that proactive intervention can significantly disrupt cybercriminal networks. As digital transactions continue to expand, the ministry maintains that sustained vigilance, rapid response mechanisms and public cooperation remain essential.

The figures presented in Parliament underscore both the magnitude of the challenge and the tangible progress achieved through I4C’s coordinated framework.

Citizens are urged to report any suspicious activity immediately through the National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal so that the system can act before irreversible losses occur.

Tarun Vijay’s book *Saffron Surge* released in Kolkata



SAUGAR SENGUPTA
■ Kolkata

Kolkata officially witnessed the proverbial saffron surge with the release of ‘Saffron Surge: Making of a Brave, New Bharat’, by Suresh (Bhaiyyaji) Joshi, member of Akhil Bharatiya Karyia Karini and former general secretary of the RSS.

The book authored by eminent writer and thinker and former Rajya Sabha MP, Tarun Vijay, documents a masterful chronicle of the torment suffered by the Hindus and their sustained war through the ages against the “aggression” from “Kasim to the Congress” — right till their civilisational reawakening. The book, which had already been released in Delhi earlier, travels to Kolkata, a City of Joy, nay a city of avid readers, on a day when one of the bravest sons, Kshudiram Bose, was martyred at the hands of the British 118 years ago.

The book carries a foreword by RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat who calls it a “running commentary with analysis and suggestions” that would be of great help in restoring Bharat to its former “glory, self-esteem and rightful place as a Vishwa Guru.”

The book that carries endorsements from likes of RSS ideologue Ratan Sharda, author Amish Tripathi has a

prologue written by RSS general secretary Dattatreya Hosabale, who calls it a “romantic contemporary history” of India’s ideological shift.

The ideological shift that the author said became most eminent through two equally great historical events: the first was the recreation of the Ram Temple at Ayodhya and the second and equally important was the saffron surge in Bengal through the coming of the BJP in power in the State by ending the “prolonged oppressive rule” “*Wam panthis* (Left) *Dam panthis* (the corrupt) and the patrons of Ghaznavis.” Bengal had finally defeated and liberated itself by defeating the mentality of Aurangzeb and Jinnahs, he iterated, urging the people to read the book written in a new historiographical context. “I would appeal to the people to read the book painstakingly written... throwing light into the oppressive past and reawakening of a new Hindu civilisation,” the author said.

The programme was attended by, among others, Bengal Finance Minister Dr Swapan Dasgupta, former Tripura Governor Tathagato Roy, State Information and Culture Minister Purnima Chakrabarty and the great-granddaughter of Dr Shyama Prasad Mukherjee, the founder of Bharatiya Jana Sangha.

CBI arrests absconder in 2021 post-poll violence murder case

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi/Kolkata

On Tuesday, the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) arrested Gopal Das, also known as Bishal Paul, in Rabindranagar, Madhyamgram, North 24 Parganas district, West Bengal.

He was wanted in connection with a murder case linked to the violence that broke out after the 2021 West Bengal Assembly elections. Gopal Das had been missing since the first information report was filed in 2021 and had not appeared for investigation or trial.

Earlier, the CBI offered a cash reward of ₹50,000 for information that would help arrest him. Officials said they found him using both human

intelligence and technical methods. The CBI took over the case on August 25, 2021, following a Calcutta High Court order from August 19, 2021. The case was originally registered at Narkeldanga police station as FIR No. 124/2021 and involved the alleged murder of Avijit Sarkar on May 2, 2021 at Sitalatala Lane in Kolkata. The victim was killed during the violence that followed the Assembly election results.

The CBI found that several people were involved in the case. After completing its investigation, the agency filed a chargesheet in 2021 and more in 2025, naming 38 people in total. Those named include Gopal Das (also known as Bishal Paul), Paresh



Pal, who was a Trinamool Congress MLA at the time, and two Trinamool Congress councillors, Swapan

Samaddar and Papiya Ghosh. The accused face charges under different sections of the Indian Penal Code.

Bhopal’s Western Bypass design to change after MLA objection

UMESH NIGAM ■ Bhopal

The proposed design of Bhopal’s Western Bypass is set to be changed following objections raised by Huzur MLA Rameshwar Sharma, with officials now working on modifications aimed at reducing the acquisition of government land and avoiding a substantial compensation burden.

The proposed bypass design had been finalised a few days ago, following inspections by officials and public representatives. However, during the inspection, it emerged that the existing alignment of the bypass would affect around 125 acres of Government land. Officials are now examining whether a minor modification

in the proposed alignment can help save not only valuable Government land but also a compensation amount estimated at nearly ₹20 crore.

MLA Rameshwar Sharma had raised objections regarding the design, stating that changes could help provide a more convenient and smooth route for the public. Following his objection, agencies associated with the project have started work on redesigning the Western Bypass.

Officials have also begun efforts to address a technical issue identified before construction work begins. The administration is examining the proposed changes with the objective of preventing unnecessary expenditure

from the Government treasury while also resolving issues related to private land acquisition.

According to the plan, the Western Bypass will provide an alternative route for vehicles travelling from Jabalpur and Betul towards Indore, reducing the need for such vehicles to enter Bhopal city. The proposed four-lane bypass will be around 31.61 km long and will begin from the Misrod-Ratanpur road before passing through areas including Kolar, Ratibad and Phanda Kalan and connecting towards the Bhopal-Dewas road.

The estimated cost of the project is ₹3,225.51 crore. The proposed bypass will pass through a total of 23 villages in Bhopal district.



Huzur MLA Rameshwar Sharma

The land acquisition process for the project has already begun. Officials have indicated that the land acquisition process will be completed under the prescribed

provisions of the Land Acquisition Act, including the process under Sections 19 and 21, after which compensation will be paid to affected landowners. Officials are

now working on the revised design and alignment.

The administration has directed the concerned department and agencies to complete the paperwork and alignment modification process on time so that the land acquisition process can be completed and construction of the Western Bypass can begin by September or October. The Western Bypass is expected to reduce the movement of heavy vehicles through Bhopal city and ease traffic congestion.

The proposed alignment and design changes are therefore being examined with the aim of balancing the project’s connectivity objectives with the need to minimise land acquisition and Government expenditure.

High-level panel on demography change visits Rohingya, Kashmiri Pandit clusters in Jammu

MOHIT KANDHARI ■ Jammu

A high-level panel examining demographic changes on Tuesday visited one of the biggest clusters in the Narwal area of Jammu, housing several hundred families of Rohingya immigrants, for an on-the-spot assessment of the situation and impact of demographic changes due to the settlement of illegal immigrants from Myanmar and Bangladesh.

The four-member central panel, which arrived here in Jammu on Monday, also visited Jagti township, home to displaced Kashmiri Pandit migrant families near Nagrota, to gather views and inputs from different sections of the population.

The team comprising Census Commissioner Mritunjay Kumar along with Durga Shankar Mishra (retired IAS officer), Balaji Srivastava (retired IPS officer) and

Shamika Ravi later met several delegations, including representatives of the Gorkha community and refugees from Pakistan-occupied Jammu and Kashmir (PoJK).

Earlier on Monday, the high-level committee held consultations with senior government and police officials, including Chief Secretary Atal Dulloo and Director General of Police (DGP) Nalin Prabhat. The Committee members got a detailed brief on the settlement of illegal immigrants, including Rohingyas from Myanmar and suspected Bangladeshis in different parts of the Jammu region, including the years when the process of settlement started, the present status of the immigrants and other issues concerning them.

In May, the Centre had constituted a high-level panel headed by Justice (Retd) Prabhakar Naolekar to study demographic changes in dif-

ferent parts of the country, arising from illegal immigration and other reasons, and to suggest measures to deal with these changes.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi had announced the “High-powered Demography Mission” on August 15 last year. The Union Cabinet gave its approval to the proposal on September 11, 2025.

According to a Home Department report tabled in the Jammu and Kashmir Assembly on February 2, 2018, “a total number of 6523 Rohingyas were found camping across 39 different locations spread across five districts of Jammu and Kashmir”. According to the Home Department report, “6461 Rohingyas were staying in the Jammu division and 62 in the Kashmir division.

However, local activists and politicians, spearheading a campaign in support of their deportation, often contest



these figures, claiming a large number of these illegal immigrants are scattered and staying at different locations.

The UT administration launched a special verification drive in the first week of March 2021, and over 250 Rohingyas were found to be staying illegally in Jammu. They were later shifted to Hiranagar detention centre in Kathua district. In December 2024, the UT administration acted firmly against the landlords who had rented out and accommodated a large number of illegal immigrants from Myanmar (Rohingya

refugees) on their vacant plots.

While the majority of Rohingyas are mainly confined to the outskirts of Jammu City and Samba district, a few families have also managed to reach Doda, Kishtwar, Ramban, Rajouri and Poonch districts because of the support arranged by some organisations and individuals. The four-member panel, during their visit to the Jagti township, received first-hand feedback from various members of the displaced migrant community.

Relief and Rehabilitation

Commissioner (Migrants) Dr Arvind Karwani said the panel met the residents and interacted with them, listening very carefully to their sentiments and suggestions.

He said community representatives also raised the issue of their return and rehabilitation, putting forward several suggestions.

“All the speakers presented their views before the committee, which heard them patiently and took note of their concerns. I hope these issues and suggestions will be reflected in the committee’s report,” Karwani said.

A delegation of Panun Kashmir, led by its Chairman Dr. Ajay Chungoo, placed before it a detailed Memorandum for consideration, investigation and permanent record. Panun Kashmir submitted that the destruction and forced expulsion of the indigenous Kashmiri Hindu community from the

Kashmir Valley and the demographic assault upon Jammu cannot be examined as unrelated phenomena.

Panun Kashmir reiterated that the events of 1989–90 constituted genocide and not merely “migration”. The targeted killings, threats, terrorisation, religious persecution, forced expulsion and destruction of the community’s territorial and institutional presence must, in its submission, be examined as interconnected elements of an indoctrinated Jihadi campaign.

Panun Kashmir urged the Committee to examine whether the genocide of Kashmiri Hindus, demographic transformation in the Kashmir Valley, abnormal settlement and encroachment in Jammu, and the alteration of the demographic character of Jammu City constitute interconnected dimensions of a larger Jihadi demographic and territorial project. The

Committee is scheduled to visit States and UTs affected by demographic changes, including West Bengal, Assam, North East, etc for a detailed study of the situation. It has a term of one year, which is further extendable by six months. It will submit its report to the Union Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA). The Committee has been mandated to conduct a comprehensive assessment of the demographic changes occurring across India due to illegal immigration and other abnormal reasons. It will analyse the patterns of abnormal population changes at the level of religious and social communities and will present a well-planned and time-bound solution to address the issue. It will scientifically assess the demographic changes, analyse their causes, and recommend appropriate policy, legislative, and administrative measures.

■ States Focus ■



VANDE MATARAM AT RED FORT A HISTORIC MOMENT, SAYS SHINDE

Maharashtra Deputy Chief Minister Eknath Shinde on Tuesday said the singing of ‘Vande Mataram’ from the Red Fort would be a historic and proud moment for the country. He was reacting to the Union Home Ministry’s announcement that for the first time at the Independence Day function, Vande Mataram will be sung from the ramparts of the Red Fort.

“Vande Mataram is not merely a song or slogan, but an inspiring sentiment deeply connected with the history of India’s freedom struggle and the sacrifices of countless freedom fighters,” Shinde said, speaking to reporters after attending the ‘BRICS Friendship Cities Conclave 2026’ held in Mumbai. (PTI)



CM VIJAY PARTICIPATES IN DRUG FREE TAMIL NADU CAMPAIGN

Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay, who led a major State-level mass anti-drug pledge and campaign at a city college on Tuesday, passionately appealed to people, especially students, to take concerted steps to eliminate the drug menace in the State.

He administered a pledge on the occasion, focusing on personal responsibility, family protection, rehabilitation support, and state growth. The pledge commits individuals to avoid drug use, guide others away from addiction, support rehabilitation efforts, and actively aid Government in eliminating illegal substances in Tamil Nadu. A large number of people undertook the e-pledge through the Drug-Free Tamil Nadu portal, an official said. (PTI)

BJP seeks privilege motion against Ranchi admin

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Ranchi

The BJP on Tuesday urged Jharkhand Assembly Speaker Rabintra Nath Mahato to allow a privilege motion against the Ranchi district administration for allegedly preventing its MLAs from participating in the House proceedings a day ago.

Leader of Opposition in the Assembly, Babul Marandi, alleged that saffron party legislators could not participate in the House proceedings on Monday, as they were detained during a CM residence gherao programme.

He demanded that a motion for “breach of privilege” be moved against the Ranchi district administration for allegedly preventing BJP MLAs from attending the Assembly on August 10.

“We requested the Assembly Speaker to allow a privilege motion against the Ranchi district administration for preventing us from participating in important house proceedings, including debate on the first supplementary Budget and voting, on Monday,” Marandi said.

“We were detained by the Ranchi Police while trying to meet Jharkhand Chief Minister Hemant Soren over student issues on Monday,” he said.

The police had detained BJP leaders, including the party’s State unit president Aditya Sahu and Marandi, on Monday when they were protesting outside the CM’s residence over alleged irregularities in Jharkhand recruitment examinations.

Meanwhile, BJP MLA Raj Singh, in a letter to the Speaker, alleged that the



Ranchi district administration stopped him and several other MLAs from participating in the proceedings of the monsoon session on August 10.

“I was deprived of the opportunity to engage in the crucial discussion regarding the First Supplementary Demands for Grants and, specifically, from casting my vote during the day’s proceedings.

“I was accompanied by several Members of the Jharkhand Legislative Assembly, including the Leader of the Opposition, the Chief Whip (Opposition), and the Whip (Opposition),” the letter stated.

He said the MLAs were on their way to meet the CM to

Naqvi slams Opposition for Parliament logjam

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

BJP leader Mukhtar Abbas Naqvi on Tuesday said the ongoing stalemate in Parliament reflects the ruling party’s “request for discussion” and the Congress-led Opposition’s “rigidness for disruption”.

Slamming the opposition, the former Union minister said on one hand there is parliamentary decency, while on the other, it is feudal anarchy.

Lashing out at the Congress and some other Opposition parties, Naqvi said the rejection of the Government’s request for a debate amounts to nothing more than a “destructive design by the democratically-defeated dynasty to derail discussion”.

Taking a dig at Leader of Opposition Rahul Gandhi, Naqvi said his so-called hard work is proving to be “polit-



ically corrupt rather than politically correct”.

The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) leader said the hypocrisy of those who loudly championed the cause of students at Jantar Mantar in the name of “Chhatron Ki Goonj” is now “hunting for faults” in the Jharkhand protest.

“Those who screamed over the use of tear gas at Jantar Mantar have now remained silent regarding its use in



Jharkhand; such double standards amount to a betrayal of student interests by these political chieftains,” Naqvi told reporters.

The logjam in Parliament is showing no sign of abating, despite the Government on Monday offering a discussion on “student and youth agitations” across states and a reply by Union Home Minister Amit Shah, including

West Bengal Govt seeks inputs from businessmen for new industrial policy

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

The West Bengal Government on Tuesday held a nearly three-hour meeting with leading industrialists and representatives of business chambers as it moved towards finalising a new industrial policy.

The meeting at state secretariat Nabanna was attended by Chief Secretary Manoj Agarwal, Commerce and Industries Minister Tapas Roy and Labour and Transport Minister Arjun Singh. Finance Minister Swapan Dasgupta and Tourism Minister Shankar Ghosh also joined the deliberations briefly.

The consultation assumes significance as the BJP-led Government of Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari seeks to position West Bengal as an investment destination and restore industrial activity and employment in a State where land acquisition has long remained a politically sensitive issue.

The Government has been

working on a new industrial policy as well as a new incentive policy, with the stated objective of attracting investment and creating jobs.

Speaking to reporters after the meeting, Roy said the Government sought the views of the industry before finalising the policy.

“We listened carefully to everyone’s views and noted them. All these important suggestions will be incorporated into the proposed industrial policy,” he said.

Roy said such consultation was a positive initiative that had not been undertaken earlier in the State in this manner.

The meeting also brought the politically fraught issue of land for industry back into focus, with participants discussing the challenges involved in land acquisition.

Roy sought to reassure the industry that the Government would proceed with caution and transparency in this regard.

He said the Government would not take any step that



hurt the interests of industry or breached the trust of the people, adding that all decisions would be taken with a “transparent and positive approach”.

The BJP Government has made industrial revival and investment a key plank of its economic agenda, contrasting its approach with the previous TMC administration, which had moved away from several industrial incentives and maintained that public resources should instead be directed towards socio-economically disadvantaged sections.

The State Government had

earlier indicated that it was considering a fresh package of industrial incentives, including measures to make investments more attractive.

The political messaging around the new industrial policy is also significant. The Adhikari Government, which came to power this year, ending the TMC’s 15-year-long rule in West Bengal, is seeking to combine a more investor-friendly policy framework with a narrative that the State can once again emerge as a major industrial hub. Arjun Singh, meanwhile, pointed to the Centre’s interest in sectors

with a large employment footprint in West Bengal.

Referring to his recent discussions with Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman, Singh said she had a clear understanding of the state’s economic situation and had shown particular interest in two areas: the development of tea garden workers and protection of the textile sector and weavers.

“Nirmalaji has always been deeply connected with the situation in West Bengal. She has visited the State several times in connection with BJP’s campaign and to oversee the overall situation. Apart from financial matters, she also has a clear understanding of the State,” Singh said.

He said the Centre’s specific interest in tea garden workers and the textile and handloom sectors could prove beneficial for workers dependent on these industries.

The emphasis on tea and textiles also carries political and economic significance for the BJP Government, given

Sparks fly in TN Assembly over shifting alliances

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chennai

The Tamil Nadu Assembly on Tuesday witnessed heated exchanges between former chief minister O Panneerselvam and the treasury benches over alliance shifts, and the debate turned personal with the members trading barbs over changing political allegiances.

Initiating a discussion, Panneerselvam (who had joined the DMK before the Assembly polls) alleged that the TVK Government had failed to honour its key electoral promises, particularly the enhanced monthly financial grant for women and the distribution of six free LPG cylinders annually.

“The public voted for a change, but they have been left greatly disappointed. These poll manifesto promises ought to have been announced as flagship schemes, but the Government has failed to do so,” Panneerselvam, formerly AIADMK leader, remarked, asserting that public sentiment had turned against the administration.

Refuting the charges, Leader of the House KA Sengottaiyan reminded that the Government had a five-year mandate to fulfil its commitments.

The debate quickly turned personal as members traded barbs over changing political allegiances.

“As you yourself once noted, it is impossible to create history in just three months. If you managed to accomplish such a feat

during your tenure, please enlighten us,” Sengottaiyan countered. He added that it was strange to label the Budget “a disappointment” when the general public was actively appreciating the Government’s performance.

Taking a swipe at the Opposition party leader’s recent political realignment, Sengottaiyan remarked, “Just because you have shifted alliance, it does not mean you should sing paeans for your new leader.”

Responding to the jibe, Panneerselvam pointed out that Sengottaiyan himself had switched political camp (from the AIADMK to Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay-led TVK) in the past.

The sharp verbal duel soon turned to “photos and loyalties” when School Education Minister A Rajmohan drew the House’s attention to sartorial choices, noting, “Look at Minister Sengottaiyan - he still carries the photograph of (late Chief Minister) J. Jayalalitha in his shirt pocket. But look at Panneerselvam; he has not only changed his place, but also the photo closest to his heart.”

Public Works and Sports Minister Aadhav Arjuna echoed the sentiment, praising Sengottaiyan for retaining the late leader’s image despite changing parties.

Hitting back, Panneerselvam stated that leaders like Periyar, Anna, M. Karunanidhi, M. G. Ramachandran, and J. Jayalalitha remained in his heart.



O Panneerselvam, KA Sengottaiyan

Congress panel to probe BJP Govt scams: Hooda

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chandigarh

Haryana Congress will form a committee to prepare a report on the alleged corruption and scams during the BJP Government in the State, Leader of Opposition Bhupinder Singh Hooda said on Tuesday, a day after the Congress Legislature Party meeting was held here under his chairmanship.

The committee will be headed by MLA Ashok Arora and have senior party leader Raghuvir Singh Kadian as a special invitee. He said other decisions were also taken at the Congress Legislature Party (CLP) meeting on Monday evening.

The Congress has also decided to bring an adjournment motion on the IDFC “bank scam”, while attention notices on ‘deteriorating’ law and order will also be given, he said.

The former Haryana chief minister, who was flanked by MLAs including Kuldeep Vats,



Geeta Bhukkal, Vikas Saharan and Jassi Petwar, lashed out at the BJP Government in the State on various issues.

With Gujarat set to host the 2030 Commonwealth Games, Hooda said the CLP unanimously passed a resolution backing the demand of the Congress MPs that Haryana should co-host the games.

“Our players have brought laurels for the country in various championships, including the Olympics, and even recently won a number of medals in the Glasgow

Attacking the BJP Government, Hooda asked, “Did they build even one stadium? We created sports infrastructure and appointed 18 DSPs (posts given to sportspersons who won medals in prestigious events).”

Hooda also targeted the Saini Government over the recently signed agreement between Haryana and Rajasthan over the Yamuna Water Project, saying that the BJP Government has forgotten about the Sutlej-Yamuna Link (SYL) Canal dispute, a long-standing water-sharing conflict between Punjab and Haryana over the Ravi-Beas river waters.

“First, the Haryana Government should get SYL waters for the State. Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini is touring (poll-bound) Punjab these days, but he does not ask them to give SYL water for our State,” he said.

Further attacking Saini on his frequent visits to Punjab in recent months, Hooda said, “Haryana needs a full-time chief minister, not part-time.”

Climate change driving extreme rainfall in Himalayas, human-related factors adding to risk, says Govt

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Climate change is increasing the intensity and frequency of extreme rainfall events in the Himalayan region, while human-related (anthropogenic) factors are adding to the overall disaster risk, the Centre informed Lok Sabha on Tuesday.

The response came to a question on whether climate change and unscientific construction activities were contributing to the rise in cloud-bursts incidents and other disasters in Himachal Pradesh.

Minister of State for Home Affairs Nityanand Rai said assessments by weather experts, scientific institutions and State authorities indicate that climate change has increased the intensity and frequency of extreme rainfall events in the Himalayan region.



As per a Multi-Sectoral Central Team (MSCT) study, “anthropogenic factors have also contributed to the increased risk in the region”, Rai said.

The Centre had constituted the MSCT in view of the increasing frequency and intensity of cloudbursts, flash floods, landslides and extreme rainfall event in Himachal Pradesh, the minister said.

The team comprises experts from the National

The MSCT has been tasked with scientific assessment of the causes of increasing extreme weather events in the State, including studying geographical and ground conditions of worst-affected areas and examining data received from various agencies.

It will also recommend long-term measures to minimise the impact of such disasters, Rai said.

The Government said accelerated snowmelt is one of the factors contributing to high runoff in high-altitude areas.

Faster melting of snow can release large amounts of water into already vulnerable mountain terrains, increasing the flow of water downstream.

The response also cited “moraine instability” as a contributor to off-season slope failures and high runoff.

Maharashtra revises delayed land compensation

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

The Maharashtra Cabinet on Tuesday approved the revision of the interest rate payable in cases of delayed disbursal of land acquisition compensation, and also gave its nod for stamp duty concessions for renewable energy projects.

The Cabinet approved amendments to Section 72 of the Right to Fair Compensation and Transparency in Land Acquisition, Rehabilitation and Resettlement Act, 2013, to revise the interest rate payable when compensation is delayed, an official statement said.

Under the revised provision, the interest rate will be one percentage point higher than the rate at which the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) lends to commercial banks.

The Government said the change was necessary as there was a gap between the existing interest rate on

delayed compensation and prevailing bank lending rates.

In a decision aimed at promoting renewable energy projects, the Cabinet approved complete waiver of stamp duty on internal land transfer transactions between companies forming a group or special purpose vehicles (SPVs) set up for such projects.

The Government stated that the parent company would continue to pay the stamp duty when it initially purchases the land, but the stamp duty payable on its subsequent transfer to a group company or SPV will be waived.

The decision aims to reduce additional financial burden on companies, helping renewable energy projects commence at the earliest. The provision will be incorporated into the state's renewable energy and energy storage policy (2025-26 to 2035-36).

The Cabinet also approved a 25 per cent concession in



land transfer fees for land purchased for renewable energy projects.

Apart from this, the Cabinet approved the creation of four posts in the state agriculture department in accordance with the revised organisational structure of its field offices.

The posts include director of agriculture (agricultural engineering, asset management and AgriStack), joint director of agriculture (statistics), joint director of agriculture (information and tech-

nology) and additional director, AgriStack (Revenue). Two of the posts of Joint Director will be filled on deputation.

The Cabinet also okayed a proposal to enable the Shri Nilkantheshwar Shetkari Cooperative Sugar Factory at Killari in Ausa tehsil of Latur district to obtain a loan of ₹18.09 crore from the National Cooperative Development Corporation (NCDC) for capital expenditure and working capital.

The Government has also

approved changes to the rules and guidelines governing the establishment of private skill universities on a self-financed basis.

It has stated that a single law — the Maharashtra Private Skill Universities (Establishment and Regulation) Act 2024 — will apply to such universities, instead of separate legislation for each university.

The Government resolution dated February 5, 2021 governing their functioning and regulation will be withdrawn once new guidelines come into force, it said, adding that institutions seeking to establish a private skill university will have to submit a detailed project report along with a ₹1 crore application fee.

The land requirement for such universities will be 25 acres in rural areas, 15 acres at tehsil or district headquarters and 10 acres in urban areas, excluding Mumbai city, Mumbai suburban and Thane.

Lokayukta conducts simultaneous raids at Karnataka Govt offices

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bengaluru

The Karnataka Lokayukta on Tuesday conducted simultaneous inspections of Treasuries and offices in Bengaluru amid complaints of corruption and irregularities in the processing and distribution of bills.

The inspections, which began at 4.15 pm, were undertaken after the Lokayukta took cognisance on its own of complaints concerning seven Treasuries in Bengaluru Urban district, five Treasuries in Bengaluru Rural district and offices of the KGID Department.

According to the Lokayukta office, complaints were received that officials were disregarding the First In, First Out (FIFO) system and the Round Robin method prescribed in the Treasury-2 software for transparent and equitable distribution of bills among



staff. "Although the FIFO and Round Robin systems are in operation in the Treasury-2 software, the procedures are being disregarded in the Treasuries and bills are being handled arbitrarily according to convenience, resulting in corruption," the Lokayukta office said.

It also said complaints had been received that Detailed Contingent (DC)

bills were being withheld at the Front Office in the name of scrutiny, besides several other irregularities in the provision of day-to-day services. The Lokayukta constituted 13 teams comprising 11 judicial officers, 39 police officers, the Lokayukta Secretary and two Personal Secretaries to the Upalokayuktas to conduct the inspections.

4 more girls of Kolkata school admitted to RG Kar hospital with complaints of fever, dizziness

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Kolkata

Four more students of Kolkata's Park Institution for Girls were admitted to the paediatric department of RG Kar hospital on Tuesday, a day after 24 students of the same school were hospitalised with complaints of fever, abdominal pain and dizziness.

All the students reside in the school's hostel near Deshbandhu Park.

Twenty-four students were taken to RG Kar Medical College and Hospital on Monday evening, when they reportedly fell ill after returning to the hostel, officials said.

Of those admitted on Monday, 21 students are likely to be discharged on Tuesday, while three were being kept under observation as they continue to have fever, hospital sources said.

The four students admitted on Tuesday have reported similar symptoms, including



fever, vomiting, headache, abdominal pain and dizziness. Doctors at the paediatric department are awaiting blood test reports to ascertain whether the fever is linked to an infection, the sources said.

A team led by West Bengal Health Department Joint Director (Public Health) Debashis Roy visited the hospital on Tuesday morning and met the students undergoing treatment.

A team from the National Institute for Research in

Bacterial Infections (ICMR-NIRBI) also visited the hospital. "After seeing the patients and speaking to the doctors, it appears that in most cases, panic attack could be the reason for the illness. There is nothing to worry about," Roy told reporters.

He said all necessary blood tests had been conducted and the Government was awaiting the reports before arriving at any conclusion.

Asked whether contaminated food or water could have caused the illness, Roy

said it was a possibility, but advised against drawing any conclusion before the test reports were available.

"If we say something abruptly, it could turn out to be incorrect," he said.

Roy said the health condition of all the students was stable. Food poisoning was initially suspected to be one of the causes, after the students complained of falling ill after having food at the hostel. However, the sources said the symptoms observed in the students were not typical of those associated with food poisoning.

Doctors had also indicated that several students appeared to have experienced panic or fear.

Health officials and doctors are examining the circumstances under which so many students fell ill at the same time.

The incident had also prompted the state's Health Minister Sharadwat Mukhopadhyay to visit RG Kar hospital on Monday night.

Despite AAP criticism over Video, Harbhajan shares another clip, Party slams ex-cricketer

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chandigarh

Despite facing criticism from AAP leaders over sharing a video of two "intoxicated" men, BJP MP Harbhajan Singh on Tuesday shared another clip claiming it was from Punjab, asking the AAP Government to focus on tackling the drug menace instead of pulling each other down.

In the latest video, a compilation of separate clips, a few men could be seen standing motionless, with Singh targeting the AAP Government over the drug scourge.

"Are these also pictures from Rajasthan? The issue is Punjab's drug problem. Your paid troll won't be able to hide this issue. Work will have to be done on this. Running away from responsibilities will not solve the problem," the Rajya Sabha MP said in the post.

He added, "This is not about targeting any particular individual. For anyone in



Punjab and across the entire country who consumes narcotic substances, whatever efforts are made to free them from addiction should be carried out. Instead of pulling each other down, the Punjab Government should work on how to make Punjab drug-free."

The former cricketer on Monday night shared a video clip of two apparently intoxicated men with the caption that Punjab's youth deserved better but was called out for it by AAP leaders and Punjab Police who said it was from

Rajasthan and he was peddling BJP's lies. The purported video showed two men standing in a weird motionless state on a road. It was widely shared on social media and several users said the men were under the influence of "zombie drug".

Sharing the video on X, on Monday night, Singh wrote "very sad to see the situation of Punjab".

"Punjab and its youth deserve better. This issue needs honesty, accountability, and urgent action - not denial," said Singh on X.

"What have the Governments done to Punjab and its Punjabi youth? Where have they brought Punjab to? The Punjab that was once known for its high spirits, courage and bravery, today that same Punjab's youth has been engulfed by drugs. There is still time... Save my Punjab," said Singh who quit AAP and joined the BJP in April.

Singh came under attack from Kejriwal and Punjab ministers for sharing the purported video.

Kejriwal said, "Many BJP people spread this lie together yesterday. Did the order come from the PMO? Does the PMO spread lies in the country?" Slamming Singh for the video clip, Finance Minister Harpal Singh Cheema accused the former cricketer of "peddling BJP's lies" and demanded an apology from him.

Cheema said when Singh was in AAP, he never raised an issue concerning Punjab's youths in Parliament and always remained "mum".

Telangana CM tells officials to procure new Metro coaches

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Hyderabad

Telangana Chief Minister A Revanth Reddy on Tuesday directed officials to purchase new coaches for Hyderabad Metro Rail Ltd in view of passenger rush and to expedite metro works in the Old City.

Reddy, who held a meeting with HMRL officials, said additional coaches need to be added to the metro trains in view of the rise in metro ridership and instructed them to take steps to acquire new coaches.

He told the officials to complete road expansion from Mahatma Gandhi Bus Station (MGBS) to Chandrayangutta and to start the process of tenders for metro works in the 7.5 km corridor in Phase-2. He suggested consulting the Delhi Metro officials for assistance on the appropriate technology to be used in the



7.5 km corridor from MGBS to Chandrayangutta.

During the meeting, the CM also reviewed the preliminary arrangements for the 'Invest Telangana Global Summit' scheduled for December.

He stressed the need to ensure that the summit is organised on a par with international standards, specifically to woo global investments into Telangana. He told the officials to submit a detailed report on the investments attracted and the progress made following the summit held last year.

Nagaland Guv stresses need for stronger enforcement against illicit liquor, drugs

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kohima

Nagaland Governor Nand Kishore Yadav on Tuesday stressed the need to strengthen enforcement mechanisms and institutional capacity to effectively tackle trafficking of illicit liquor and drugs.

Speaking at a review meeting with the Department of Excise and Prohibition at Lok Bhavan here, the governor emphasised that the department must address operational and manpower constraints while continuing to contribute to public health and effective governance.

According to a Lok Bhavan statement, during the meeting, the department highlighted several challenges affecting enforcement, including porous



Nagaland Governor Nand Kishore Yadav

borders, shortage of manpower, discontinuation of inter-district check-gates, outdated firearms and limited operational mobility. The department noted that its personnel-to-population ratio stands at 1:6,000, compared to 1:2,000 in Mizoram.

Reviewing its enforcement record from April 2021 to March 2026, the department reported cases registered under the Nagaland

Liquor Total Prohibition (NLTTP) Act and drug-related cases.

Seizures during the period included Indian-made foreign liquor (IMFL), country liquor, poppy straw, opium, heroin, cough syrup and other drugs in the form of capsules and tablets.

The department also highlighted recent seizures, destruction of seized drugs and liquor, and drug awareness campaigns.



A herd of wild elephants, including calves, near a water body at the Bandipur Tiger Reserve in Chamaraajanagar, Karnataka on Monday

PTI

We must protect our farmers, abide by court verdicts: Karnataka CM on Cauvery water release order

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bengaluru

Commenting on the CWRC direction to Karnataka to release 12,000 cusecs of Cauvery water to Tamil Nadu, Chief Minister DK Shivakumar said on Tuesday that he has the duty to protect the state's farmers and abide by court orders, and the Government will decide on it after assessing the situation.

Stating that he will discuss the matter with Irrigation Minister Ramalinga Reddy and concerned officials, he called on farmers and the public to have "patience," assuring them the Government is there to protect the state's interest.

The Cauvery Water



Regulation Committee (CWRC), which met in New Delhi on Tuesday, directed Karnataka to release 12,000 cusecs (cubic feet per second) of water from August 12 for the next 15 days.

"I know that 12,000 cusecs orders have come. I'm also monitoring our inflow. Considering our situation, I have the duty to protect our farmers. We must protect our farmers and also abide by

the court orders. Keeping both these aspects in mind, I will discuss with the irrigation minister and officials," Shivakumar said.

Speaking to reporters here, he said, "Crops should also be protected. Whether it is Cauvery or Tungabhadra, I have asked authorities to decide on releasing water to crops after holding local meetings with farmers and other stakeholders and considering the water situation at dams".

To a question on maintaining law and order amid potential farmer protests following the water release order, the CM called on everyone to have patience, stating the Government is here to protect the state's interest.

NASA invites ISRO to join moon base mission

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

In a major move to deepen bilateral space collaboration, NASA has invited the Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO) to join its ambitious programme to build humanity's first lunar outpost near the Moon's South Pole.

The project named Moon Base mission is aimed at setting up a permanent habitat for astronauts to live, work, and explore through a series of crewed and uncrewed missions. According to the US space agency, the aim of the project is to unlock new scientific discoveries, and prepare for future deep space exploration. India and the US explored expanding



their space cooperation at a meeting of their Civil Space Joint Working Group (CSJWG) held in Bengaluru last week.

"The NASA invited ISRO to join its Moon Base programme, building on the two countries' partnership under the Artemis Accords," according to a joint press statement.

The two sides also agreed

to advance discussions for cooperation on open scientific data sharing under the accords, it said.

The meeting advanced civil and commercial space cooperation under the US-India Transforming the Relationship Utilising Strategic Technology (TRUST) initiative. The TRUST was unveiled in February last year to promote application of critical and emerging technologies in areas like defence, artificial intelligence, semiconductors, quantum, biotechnology, energy, and space.

Both sides discussed expanding cooperation following the successful launch of the joint NASA-ISRO Synthetic Aperture Radar (NISAR) mission last year, as well as pursuing future science and

human space flight technology collaborations," the joint statement said. It said both sides reaffirmed their commitment to advancing the United Nations Committee on the Peaceful Uses of Outer Space (COPUOS) guidelines on the long-term sustainability of outer space activities, as well as reviewed ongoing multilateral efforts for ensuring the Committee's effectiveness.

The ninth meeting of the CSJWG was hosted by India on August 5 and 6 at ISRO's headquarters in Bengaluru.

ISRO chairman V Narayanan and US Ambassador Sergio Gora addressed the opening segment of the meeting and highlighted the significance of further strengthening the bilateral space cooperation.



Editor's
TAKE

Today's youth: The torchbearers of tomorrow

On this International Youth Day, India's and the world's young have already shown they know the way. The rest of us would do well to follow them

Every year on August 12, the world pauses to mark International Youth Day, and this year's UN theme, "Different Contexts, Common Aspirations," could not be more apt. From the Swedish schoolgirl's solitary protest to the dusty protest grounds of Jantar Mantar, young people keep proving that age is no barrier to conscience, and conscience, once lit, becomes a torch that others follow.

Consider Malala Yousafzai. Shot by the Taliban at fifteen for daring to demand an education, she turned near-death into a global campaign, becoming, at seventeen, the youngest Nobel Peace Prize laureate in history. More than a decade on, she still travels the world to education forums, insisting that a girl's right to a classroom is non-negotiable, whatever her country or circumstance.

Then you have another torch bearer, Greta Thunberg, who at fifteen sat alone outside the Swedish parliament with a hand-painted sign, and within a year had inspired millions of students worldwide to walk out of classrooms under the banner of Fridays for Future, forcing climate change onto the agenda of governments that had long treated it as tomorrow's problem.

India needs no borrowed examples. This July, a satirical social media page named the Cockroach Janta Party, its name a defiant rejoinder to a jibe dismissing the country's youth as parasites, grew within weeks into a nationwide movement against examination paper leaks that had shaken millions of students' faith in fairness. It ended with the resignation of India's Union Education Minister, a rare instance of a leaderless youth movement altering the calculus of the world's largest democracy.

These are not aberrations. With nearly two-thirds of Indians under thirty-five, and roughly one in five of the world's under-25 population living here, India's youth are not a demographic statistic waiting to be harvested. They are increasingly the authors of the national conversation, and a growing presence well beyond it too, building start-ups, staffing research labs, and filling classrooms and boardrooms.

Yet the environment they must navigate is unforgiving: a job market reshaped overnight by automation and AI, examinations that too often reward rote memory over reasoning, a climate crisis they did not create but must inherit, and a digital world that monetises their anxiety as readily as their attention. Mental health strain among the young, in India and abroad, is no longer a private matter but a public one. Coping with this is not about grim endurance. It is what Malala, Greta and the Cockroach Janta Party all understood instinctively: organise instead of despairing, question loudly but build carefully, and treat setbacks as data, not verdicts. Institutions, schools, employers, governments, owe young people the same seriousness they demand of them. Torchbearers do not merely carry light; they choose where to walk.

Nepal's quest for economic statecraft

As Balen Shah begins engaging India, China and others, the larger test will be whether this diplomatic space can be translated into strategic economic opportunities – particularly through deeper India-Nepal value-chain integration and access to global markets



NAVITA SRIKANTH

A compliment is certainly due to newly elected Prime Minister Balendra Shah for taking time to find his feet before engaging Nepal's key partners. He has demonstrated resilience and composure amid relentless social-media berating over what many described as his "strategic silence." Perhaps, in the process, PM Shah stole all the gossip!

Setting aside the pun, all eyes are now on Monday, August 10, when Prime Minister Shah is expected to meet the Indian and Chinese envoys, followed by the US Chargé d'affaires on Tuesday, as reported by The Kathmandu Post.

This appears to be a carefully sequenced set of engagements with Nepal's two vital neighbours. India remains strategically vital to Nepal for trade, commerce, connectivity and extensive people-to-people linkages. Nepal's historic linkages with China likewise extend beyond contemporary geopolitics, including important economic, cultural and people-to-people exchanges with the Tibet Autonomous Region, particularly across Nepal's northern region.

Interestingly, The Kathmandu Post has reported that Prime Minister Shah did not receive requests for meetings with US Assistant Secretary of State for South and Central Asian Affairs Samir Paul Kapur and President Donald Trump's Special Envoy for South and Central Asia Sergio Gorr, and subsequently did not grant an audience to US Under Secretary of State for Public Diplomacy Sarah B. Rogers. I do not have details of these requests or the circumstances surrounding the reported decisions. It would therefore be inappropriate to draw definitive conclusions about the Prime Minister's intent. But the reported sequence deserves more than passing diplomatic commentary. The issue is not whether Nepal should engage the United States. Of course it should. Nor is declining a meeting, by itself, evidence of hostility.

The larger question is whether the expectations, approach or conduct of some external actors adequately recognise Nepal's sovereign diplomatic space. Nepal is a sovereign state pursuing a delicate foreign policy between its two immediate neighbours, India and China, while maintaining relations with the United States and other international partners. Its leadership has every right to determine whom it meets, when it meets and at what level. Nepal may be a smaller state in economic and military terms, but its geopolitical significance far exceeds its size. Situated between two major Asian powers, it is strategically important not only to its neighbours but also to global powers.

That makes sensitivity and calibration essen-



THE LARGER QUESTION IS WHETHER THE EXPECTATIONS, APPROACH OR CONDUCT OF SOME EXTERNAL ACTORS ADEQUATELY RECOGNISE NEPAL'S SOVEREIGN DIPLOMATIC SPACE. NEPAL IS A SOVEREIGN STATE PURSUING A DELICATE FOREIGN POLICY BETWEEN ITS TWO IMMEDIATE NEIGHBOURS, INDIA AND CHINA, WHILE MAINTAINING RELATIONS WITH THE UNITED STATES AND OTHER INTERNATIONAL PARTNERS

The writer is a financial, geopolitical, security analyst and an India-Nepal relations observer

As Prime Minister Balendra Shah's engagement with India takes shape, one strategic question ought to be placed squarely on the table:

How can Nepal leverage India's network of Free Trade Agreements (FTAs) and Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreements (CEPAs) with third countries to expand Nepal's own exports, attract investment, strengthen manufacturing and integrate into regional and global value chains? This is precisely the kind of question Nepal's Chambers of Commerce should be asking and developing into a concrete economic strategy. To date, however, I have not seen a dedicated chamber-led study going sufficiently deep into this opportunity.

Nor is this opportunity merely for Nepal. India's Chambers of Commerce should equally examine how India's growing network of FTAs and CEPAs can give regional economic integration a strategic boost. India has built what could be described as a treasure trove of market-access arrangements. The question now is how these agreements can become more than instruments for bilateral trade and provide a platform for regional value-chain integration.

Nepal should therefore ask: Where can Nepal add value? Where can Indian investment create manufacturing capacity in Nepal? Which products can enter Indian and regional supply chains? Which sectors can jointly target FTA/CEPA markets? And what rules of origin, standards, connectivity and policy arrangements would make this commercially viable? This is where economic diplomacy must move beyond trade statistics and Memorandum of Understandings (MoUs) to strategic value-chain thinking. The opportunity could extend across hydropower and clean energy, agro-processing, tea and coffee, herbs and essential oils, textiles, tourism, IT and digital services, pharmaceuticals, light manufacturing and logistics.

For India, deeper value chain integration in above-mentioned areas with Nepal could strengthen the economic architecture of the neighbourhood while creating additional production and supply-chain capabilities for accessing third-country markets.

It is time to reframe the question from: "How much does Nepal export to India?" to: "How can India and Nepal together create value in Nepal, integrate that value into Indian supply chains, and leverage India's global market access?" That is the conversation I would like to see begin with Prime Minister Shah and Ambassador Srivastava, and, equally importantly, with the Chambers of Commerce on both sides. For Nepal, sovereignty is not simply the ability to choose whom to meet. It is also the ability to define what it seeks from those relationships. The next test of Nepal's young leadership is to convert sovereign agency into strategic economic opportunity.

PIC TALK

Security personnel with students hold tri-colour flags during 'Tiranga Yatra' rally under the 'Har Ghar Tiranga' campaign in Srinagar. PHOTO: PTI

Marriage a social, legal and cultural institution



AJIT KUMAR BISHNOI

2ND OPINION

Human beings have four basic necessities/urges. These are eating, sleeping, mating and defending. Marriage is peculiar to the human species. Animals don't practice it. There is another big difference between humans and animals. In case of humans, marriage is mostly chosen to meet the need for mating. In case of animals, it is might is right, which is: the most powerful has the choice of partners. Humans have chosen marriage as a social, legal and cultural institution.

There are two types of marriages. One is arranged by mostly parents of boy and girl. It has a distinct benefit of not being entirely love at sight type of marriage. Parents make a considered choice; they are likely to be objective. The married partners are also likely to be more adjusting, because they don't have unrealistic expecta-



tions. This adjustment part may be lacking in love at first sight type of marriage, though not necessarily so. The later is likely to be more due to bodily attractions than an objective assessment of another. Faulty personal nature also comes in the way of success of such marriages. All marriages, whether arranged or otherwise should not disregard the need for companionship critically required by human beings, because souls are parts of God and are incomplete in themselves.

Only devotees of God, especially 'sannyasis' (celibates) are able to manage to avoid marriage successfully; they have company of God. Others must have human company, which a family provides nicely. It assures complementary and supplementary support throughout the

life, first from spouse and later from children.

In spite of many advantages of marriage, they do breakdown due to multiple reasons, main is infidelity. However, lack of adjustment is not far behind. Divorces result and go upto 40% in a country like the USA. Now many try to avoid this happening and prefer the live-in relationship. It has reached a high percentage of 10 again in the USA. Unfortunately, such a relationship has many basic flaws. The worst part is failing to secure company in old age, when one is likely to be quite lonely.

It is no wonder that God does not approve of it. The relationship must be according to 'dharma' (established rules and laws), as instructed in the Bhagavad-Gita verse #7.11. One must take life-long responsibilities, God, Himself, gets married in His incarnations to set a high standard of behaviour. For most of us human beings, the marriage must be a sacred duty.

Lastly, I must warn readers that mating is an urge, that is all. It pleases but does not satisfy, as no sense enjoyments ever do. People even lose their health, if this mating urge is carried beyond 50 years age, when good health is at a premium. Satisfaction is only available with God – the Source. Seeking it anywhere else is a major case of failure of all such relationships. It is time to seek satisfaction where it is, that is with God, especially in a marriage.

The writer is a spiritual teacher and a columnist

DIGITAL EXPERIENCE

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CJP ROOTS FOR RURAL EDUCATION TO LAUNCH A NATION-WIDE CAMPAIGN

Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) founder Abhijeet Dipke on Monday announced a nationwide campaign aimed at improving government schools in rural India through community participation and citizen-led audits. The initiative will be launched on 15 August, with the organisation urging parents, citizens and village leaders to work together to address what it described as the prolonged neglect of rural educational infrastructure.

The coming 15th August is 80th Independence Day. But, if anything has been neglected or ignored the most in the last 80 years, it is the government schools in our villages. The challenges faced by rural students, many children continue to walk long distances to attend school, only to find that essential facilities such as clean drinking water and functional toilets are unavailable.

Parents have been encouraged to record videos documenting missing or inadequate facilities. The CJP said it would soon release a printable audit form allowing citizens to list the amenities available at each school and identify shortcomings. The CJP, the initiative seeks to ensure that children of farmers and wage labourers studying in village schools receive facilities comparable to those available to students in urban areas. The CJP began as an online satirical platform before expanding its activities into street-level campaigns. Its 36-day protest at Jantar Mantar in Delhi against alleged examination irregularities ended on 25 July following the resignation of then Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan.

BHAGWAN THADANI | MUMBAI

Please send your letter to the info@dailypioneer.com. In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Safed Sagar tells the true story of Kargil

The serial Safed Sagar deserves special appreciation for presenting the Kargil War through a largely authentic and comprehensible depiction of the Indian Air Force's role. It has effectively decoded complex Air Force terminology, operational strategies and aviation concepts that might otherwise have remained difficult for the general public to understand. The portrayal of the Golden Arrows pilots, their command-and-control challenges, coordination, tactical decisions and courageous employment of MiG-21s and Mirage aircraft, including their weapon modifications, brings the realities of aerial warfare vividly before the audience.

The producer, writer, director, actors, technical experts, serving and retired Air Force personnel and everyone involved in research and production deserve applause for transforming a complex military operation into an engaging visual narrative without losing its historical essence. Such productions can help students remember important events more effectively while complementing their textbooks. India should encourage more fact-based films and series rooted in verified historical events, enabling younger generations to understand and remember the nation's military heritage through compelling storytelling.

RS NARULA | PATIALA

Secure the lives of elephants

As many as 528 elephants died of unnatural causes between 2019 and 2024, and a rough estimate puts the number of wild elephant deaths between 2009 and 2024 at 1653.

Electrocution, train collisions, poisoning and poaching are the leading causes in that order. Ironically, states with fewer elephants like Jharkhand, Chhattisgarh and Odisha have reported more casualties than states like Karnataka and Kerala which boast more elephants.

In general, decentralisation of conflict governance, timely compensation to farmers affected by marauding elephants and enhanced community participation in elephant conservation are crucial for their survival.

Proper track signals, loco pilot sensitisation, periodic review and maintenance of elephant corridors, overpasses and underpasses, solar powered fences and elephant proof trenches are equally important. More and more elephant corridors and enhanced budgetary provisions cannot be overstated.

Securing the elephants in a non – exploitative and sustainable environment is the take – home message on August 12, the "World Elephant Day".

GANPATHI BHATI | AKOLA

MSME Bill: A step in right direction

The Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises Development (Amendment) Bill, 2026 addresses a persistent problem confronting India's small businesses: getting paid on time.

Every delayed payment forces an entrepreneur to borrow more, postpone expansion or reduce production. Parliament has cleared the Bill after the Rajya Sabha passed it on August 3 and the Lok Sabha followed on August 7. It amends the MSME Development Act, 2006, with changes covering delayed payments, registration, dispute resolution, penalties and the classification of enterprises. If mediation fails, the matter must be referred to arbitration within 30 days of its termination, and the arbitral award must ordinarily be made within 90 days after pleadings are completed. The Bill also enables the Centre to establish mechanisms for online mediation and arbitration. Importantly, when a buyer challenges an award, the existing framework requires a 75 per cent deposit.

The amendment goes further: if the court case remains pending beyond six months, at least 50 per cent of the awarded amount must be released to the MSME supplier from the deposit. Faster dispute resolution and interim access to money could change the bargaining balance between small suppliers and much larger purchasers. contractual certainty and timely payments.

YASH PAL RALHAN | JALANDHAR

Beyond the bars: Rethinking zoos in the age of climate change

Climate change is forcing us to rethink not only how we protect wildlife, but also where that protection should take place. The case for conventional display-oriented zoos deserves fresh scrutiny. The future of conservation may lie in healthier ecosystems, wildlife corridors and climate-resilient rescue and rehabilitation centres



SATENDRA SINGH

Picture a lifetime spent inside a few hundred square metres, behind railings or concrete walls, watched by strangers who will never know your name. No court sentenced you to this — it is daily life for countless wild animals in the world's zoos. Humanity's fascination with wild creatures is centuries old. Under the Mughals and the British, hunting was proof of royal power and courage, a pursuit that drove tigers, lions and rhinoceroses toward extinction, for sport. We like to think we have moved on — today's language is one of biodiversity, not trophies. But has our relationship with wild animals changed, or only its outward form? The rifle has become the camera, the hunting ground the enclosure; nobody dies, yet the transaction persists — a wild creature's freedom traded for being watched. That is the question at the heart of the zoo debate: does our appetite to observe wildlife justify keeping it captive?

Today's zoos bear little resemblance to the royal menageries of the past. Many have improved animal welfare and contributed to breeding programmes for endangered species — credit they deserve. But that cannot undo a biological fact. Tigers range across vast forests, elephants travel with their herds over enormous distances, birds cross continents. These are not preferences but necessities, and no enclosure, however spacious, can replicate that complexity. Captive animals often develop repetitive behaviours — pacing, swaying, head-bobbing — that scientists recognise as chronic stress. Devoted keepers can soften, not erase, captivity.

Zoos have long defended themselves as engines of public awareness — an argument that carried more weight once. Today, anyone with a phone or television can watch wildlife documentaries, livestreams, satellite-tracked migrations and virtual reality, all without an animal losing its freedom. Nor does the conservation record hold up. Several zoos have bred critically endangered species and run recovery programmes, and that matters — but such cases remain a small fraction of animals held captive; most exhibits exist to entertain, not to save species on the brink. Are we conserving wildlife, or entertaining ourselves under a conservation label? None of this impugns the dedication of zoo vets, biologists and handlers; the real question is whether the display zoo still fits twenty-first-century ethics, where conservation increasingly protects ecosystems, not individual specimens behind glass. And there is now a sharper edge to this debate: a warming planet is changing the ground zoos stand on. Zoos as Climate Traps Climate change is no longer a distant abstraction. Heatwaves, floods, droughts, cyclones and wildfires are growing more frequent and intense, threatening biodiversity everywhere. Animals in captivity face an often-overlooked version of this danger.

Wild species have spent millennia learning to cope with a changing environment — seeking shade or turning nocturnal in extreme heat, moving to cooler or higher ground, travelling toward water during drought, fleeing from fire or flood. Mobility is nature's most reliable survival tool, and captive animals have none of it: their world ends at the enclosure fence. Whatever the hazard, they cannot relocate; their survival rests on human intervention. Climate change is turning many enclosures into "climate traps" — places where extreme weather arrives, but movement, the one tool nature gave animals to survive it, is unavailable. Heatwaves illustrate this well. Most zoos sit in or near cities, already hotter due to the urban heat-island effect, and enclosures of concrete and metal heat up faster still; misting systems and air-conditioned shelters help but cannot reproduce a real forest's microclimate.

Cold snaps pose the opposite risk for tropical species dependent on uninterrupted power, where a prolonged outage can be fatal. Floods submerge enclosures and contaminate water; wildfires add smoke and panic to the danger; cyclones flatten cages and uproot trees; earthquakes can breach barriers — forcing agonising choices between evacuating people, saving animals and containing escapees. Shifting weather patterns are expanding disease-carrying mosquito and tick populations, and densely housed captive animals are vulnerable to outbreaks.



ZOOS HAVE LONG DEFENDED THEMSELVES AS ENGINES OF PUBLIC AWARENESS — AN ARGUMENT THAT CARRIED MORE WEIGHT ONCE. TODAY, ANYONE WITH A PHONE OR TELEVISION CAN WATCH WILDLIFE DOCUMENTARIES, LIVESTREAMS, SATELLITE-TRACKED MIGRATIONS AND VIRTUAL REALITY, ALL WITHOUT AN ANIMAL LOSING ITS FREEDOM. NOR DOES THE CONSERVATION RECORD HOLD UP

The writer is former Executive Director, National Institute of Disaster Management, Government of India

Zoos were once imagined as havens insulated from the wild's dangers; climate change has exposed how fragile that idea was. Keeping thousands of animals safe demands more cooling, water security and disaster planning — raising the question of whether the conventional zoo model can survive. What wildlife may need is not a better enclosure but healthier forests, wetlands and corridors where animals can adapt naturally.

If climate change teaches anything, it is that survival depends on freedom to move. From Cages to Conservation The zoo debate cannot be settled by asking whether zoos are "good" or "bad." The real question is whether the display-oriented zoo still makes sense in an age of climate change, mass extinction and growing concern for animal welfare. Institutions evolve with society's priorities — zoos must too. We are living through the fastest loss of biodiversity in recorded history, as forests, wetlands and grasslands shrink. Wild animals need large, connected habitats, not enclosures — so conservation must shift from protecting captive specimens to protecting the ecosystems they depend on. That does not mean captive facilities should disappear.

Specialised centres will be needed to treat injured wildlife, rehabilitate orphaned animals, care for trafficking victims and run managed breeding programmes for critically endangered species. But their purpose should be conservation and welfare, not entertainment. The most sensible path is to convert existing zoos into Climate-Resilient Wildlife Rescue, Rehabilitation and Conservation Centres — combining emergency veterinary care, rehabilitation for disaster and conflict-affected animals, safe housing for seized wildlife, endangered-species breeding, and research toward reintroduction into the wild.

As disasters displace and injure growing numbers of animals, every country needs rescue infrastructure — and existing zoos, with trained staff and facilities, are well placed to become part of national disaster-management and conservation systems, given a change in mission. Equally important are investments beyond zoo walls: restoring habitats, protecting wildlife corridors, expanding protected areas and reviving wetlands through native afforestation. Protecting nature will outperform recreating it artificially.

Education needs to evolve too — from encouraging people to view captive animals toward teaching them to protect wild ones. Documentaries, national-park camera networks, virtual reality, satellite tracking and digital interpretation centres can teach millions without a single animal leaving its habitat. Few countries are as well placed to lead this shift as India, given its biodiversity and conservation record — from Project Tiger to the recovery of crocodiles and vultures. The task is to fuse wildlife conservation with climate adaptation and disaster resilience; a nationwide network of climate-resilient rescue centres would be a sound investment in both biodiversity and public safety.

What is at stake is not our love of wild animals — that will never fade — but how we choose to express it. We once expressed it through the rifle, then the cage. The twenty-first century demands something better: thriving forests instead of more zoos, wildlife corridors instead of larger cages, living ecosystems instead of exhibits. The true measure of our commitment will not be how many species we hold captive, but how many roam free in ecosystems that are thriving. In the age of climate change, it is time to trade captivity for coexistence — because no cage, however well built, can equal a habitat left whole.

Freedom from fraud: How Haryana built cyber shield



AJAY SINGHAL

As India marks its 79th Independence Day, freedom today carries a meaning our founding generation could not have imagined: the freedom to transact, to be heard, to be governed, and to be protected all through a screen.

Seventy-nine years ago, independence gave us freedom from colonial rule and slavery; freedom meant the right to life, equality, the vote, to speak, to own property free from arbitrary seizure. Today, technology has expanded that freedom further; access to the internet is now widely seen as bound up with our fundamental rights.

An equally intimate freedom has entered our lives: the freedom to access services without standing in long queues, without a harsh, impersonal interface standing between citizen and state. This is the quiet revolution technology has authored in the life of the ordinary citizen, whose day now runs on a digital screen more than most of us pause to notice.

Policing, too, has not remained untouched. Over three decades in the Indian Police Service, I have witnessed policing reinvented itself five times to keep pace with technology and the society it serves. Before 1995, policing relied on older, more intrusive methods; today we are far more accountable. Windows 95 and the arrival of the internet in 1998 brought mobile telephony and mobile-based crime into public life. From 2009, touch-screen smartphones and app-based mapping reshaped both crime and policing. After 2021 came drones and early Artificial Intelligence (AI) tools. Today, everyone is talking about AI, and various departments across the country are investing heavily in it; by 2030, policing may well be drone- and robot-assisted. Policing and New Criminal Laws has not stood apart from this transformation; it has become one of its most active adopters. FIRs are now filed online, court records move through the Interoperable Criminal Justice System, and forensic reports, once locked away for months, are increasingly digitised for faster trial outcomes. Under PM Narendra Modi's supervision of the Pragati Portal, Haryana Police's IT initiatives have carried this reform forward with the rollout of e-Zero FIR from 25 June 2026, letting citizens register serious offences instantly, without the old anxieties of jurisdiction or delay. Tools that once belonged only to banks and telecom firms are now instruments of criminal justice reform.

It is fitting, then, that this year Haryana became the leading state in the country in cybercrime control. This distinction says as much about how far our digital lives have travelled as about how far our policing has had to travel with them. Of the 14,731 cybercrime cases Haryana Police received till 22 July 2026, restoration orders were issued to victims in 38 per cent of cases, against a national average of just 8 per cent. That single statistic is, in many ways, this Independence Day's quiet story: a state using the same technology that enables fraud also to enable justice.

Convenience carries its shadow, and nowhere is this more visible than in the surge of cyber fraud riding the very infrastructure built for ease. Digital arrest fraud alone accounted for as many as 1,23,000 reported cases nationally in 2024, with losses of Rs 1,935 crore — nearly triple what was lost in 2022. Across the country in all forms of digital fraud, more than Rs 54,000 crore was reported lost between April 2021 and November 2025. In Haryana, the first quarter of 2026 alone saw digital arrest scams cost citizens Rs 10.78 crore, with customers of HDFC Bank, Bank of Baroda and SBI among the worst hit. In one Gurugram case, a victim was kept on video call for ten consecutive days while Rs 79 lakh moved silently across forty mule accounts. These are not isolated incidents, but the work of organised, often international networks and investigations have traced links to Cambodia, Myanmar, Pakistan, Vietnam and China, with scam centres coercing trafficked youth into what can only be called cyber slavery.

Building the shield

The change of minister can't stop railway accidents, paper leaks, riots, etc. Terrorism was fought with guns and bullets. Similarly, Cybercrime can only be completely cured by switching off the internet, and that is not possible for any nation to do. If technology created this vulnerability, Haryana Police's response has been to fight fire with fire, building a shield out of the same digital architecture, rather than chasing the fire after it spreads. The Money Restoration Module has already released Rs 2.51 crore back to victims, treating financial recovery not as an afterthought but as a core policing function. Cybercrime rarely respects state boundaries, which is why inter-state coordination is central to the response: of 9,437 assistance requests received from other states, Haryana Police disposed of 9,156, a 97 per cent response rate few states can match. Alongside this, 15,853 fraud-linked URLs were taken down between 1 January and 22 July 2026, choking the scam infrastructure at its source. For senior citizens specifically, Haryana has gone further, becoming the first state in India to introduce dual-OTP authentication for their fund transfers. For transfers of Rs 1 lakh or more, a second OTP now goes to both the account holder and a trusted family member, so funds move only when both codes are entered — a simple, transformative check already stalling large fraudulent transfers before completion. Enrolment is currently voluntary for those above 60, with mandatory enrolment for those above 75 under consideration.

There is something worth reflecting on this Independence Day: the same UPI code on a vendor's cart, the same portal that files a grievance, and the same phone that once made an elderly citizen a target can now also be the instrument of their protection. Technology has not simply changed how we live — it has changed what freedom itself must now guarantee. The freedom to transact must come with freedom from fraud; the freedom to be governed digitally must come with the freedom to trust that governance. This commitment is part of Haryana Vision 2047, personally monitored by Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini. Haryana Police has set up a dedicated wing to address them, and is building an Integrated Command Centre and a State Cyber Crime Coordination Centre (S4C) to tackle cybercrime and its evolving effects. As India completes 79 years of independence, the task is no longer only to connect every citizen to technology, but to ensure that no citizen's safety and trust is left unprotected within it. This Independence Day, we pledge to ensure a new Fundamental Right for the citizens of India: access to the safe and secure internet.

The writer is Director General of Police, Haryana



SHEFALI GUPTA

tion. Yet, in practice, this translated into the empowerment of dominant sub-castes-Yadavs and Jatavs-while the vast majority of marginalised groups remained locked out of real economic mobility. When Yogi Adityanath assumed office in 2017, the conventional wisdom in Lucknow's drawing rooms was that the BJP was an upper-caste party incapable of breaching this Mandal fortress.

Nearly eight years later, that fortress lies in ruins. Yogi has not only breached it but has rewritten the very rules of social justice in India's most populous state, shifting the discourse from the politics of symbolic identity to the politics of measurable access.

The defining feature of Yogi's approach to marginalised communities is his rejection of tokenism in favour of ruthless, data-driven delivery. Consider educational welfare. Historically, scholarship distribution in UP was a byword for bureaucratic apathy and middlemen corrup-

tion; funds meant for Dalit and OBC students routinely vanished into the pockets of intermediaries. The Yogi government aggressively digitised this pipeline, leveraging Direct Benefit Transfer (DBT). The results are starkly visible in the ledger. The recent state budget allocated ₹3,402 crore specifically for backward class welfare, with over ₹3,060 crore earmarked for OBC scholarships alone.

By cutting out the broker, the state ensured that funds reached the intended beneficiaries. To date, over ₹3,350 crore has been distributed directly into the bank accounts of nearly 28 lakh students-comprising 13.5 lakh OBCs and 6.7 lakh SC students. A Kurmi student in a remote village or a Pasi girl in a semi-urban town now receives her educational dues without greasing palms. This is social justice translated into actual bank balance.

Furthermore, the government's universal welfare schemes functioned as the most aggressive anti-poverty drive in UP's history. Schemes like the PM Awas Yojana, free ration distribution, Ayushman Bharat and the Jal Jeevan Mission were implemented at an unprecedented scale. Because SCs and OBCs constitute the overwhelming majority of the state's poorest demographic, they naturally



emerged as the primary beneficiaries. Selection was officially based on economic deprivation rather than caste, yet the outcome was intrinsically social. A pucca house, a cooking gas cylinder, and a tap water connection did more for the material dignity of a marginalised family than decades of political rhetoric.

However, Yogi's most profound, yet understated, contribution lies in structural expansion. The administration did not tamper with constitutional reservation quotas-a bogey often raised by opposition parties to incite fear. Reservation percentages remained intact (SC: 21%, ST: 2%, OBC: 27%). Instead, Yogi expanded the pie. The unprecedented establishment of gov-

ernment medical colleges, engineering institutions, and universities across UP meant that a 21 per cent SC or 27 per cent OBC reservation was no longer confined to a stagnant pool of seats. By multiplying the number of government medical and technical seats, the administration ensured that the absolute numbers of SC and OBC students entering elite professions surged. This is real empowerment: not a guarantee on a piece of paper, but an actual seat in a classroom.

Politically, this structural empowerment was mirrored by a tectonic shift in representation. Yogi engineered a micro-caste strategy, recognizing the deep-seated resentment brewing among non-dominant OBCs and non-Jatav Dalits who felt sidelined by the SP and BSP's monolithic caste monopolies. Communities like the Nishads, Rajbhars, Mauryas, Kushwahas, and Lodhs were brought into the cabinet and given organisational heft. This was a structural dismantling of the "caste headman" model. By elevating leaders from these smaller, historically ignored communities, the BJP decentralized political power, making the backward-class umbrella genuinely representative rather than a facade for one or two dominant groups. Crucially, the much-

debated law and order crackdown has had a deeply social justice-oriented impact. In rural UP, the marginalised were historically at the mercy of local strongmen-often from dominant castes-who usurped their land and throttled their access to justice. The state's aggressive dismantling of these criminal networks provided the poorest with the space to exercise their constitutional rights without fear. A Dalit entrepreneur filing a police complaint without facing coercion from a local mafia is a profound, under-appreciated marker of social empowerment. Critics rightly point out that deep structural inequities-landlessness, caste atrocities, and educational disparities-persist. Welfare delivery, however efficient, is not a substitute for land reforms. Yet, to dismiss Yogi's achievements as mere electoral arithmetic is to miss the woods for the trees. Structural reforms take generations, but the foundation laid over the past eight years is undeniable.

By pivoting from identity to access-access to education, to housing, to safety, and to political representation-Yogi Adityanath has not just secured a vote bank; he has orchestrated a silent, tangible revolution for UP's marginalised. He has proven that the true metric of social justice is not the volume of caste rhetoric, but the quiet hum of a DBT notification on a poor student's mobile phone.

The writer is BJP State Executive Committee Member (Jharkhand), Founder, Om Aarohanam, Member, DISHA (Government of India), & Member, Environment Committee

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Order Order

Court to hear defamation case against Rahul on September 19



A notice issued to Leader of Opposition in Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi in a defamation suit linked to his remarks over the 2020 Hathras rape case has been served, the complainant's lawyer said on Tuesday. The notice was issued by Additional District Judge of the MP/MLA Court No 5, Vijay Kumar Dwivedi, after hearing a revision petition on July 15.

On Tuesday's hearing, the court was informed that the notice was duly served and was received by Gandhi, the complainant's counsel Munna Singh Pundhir said.

The court has fixed the next date of hearing on September 19. Pundhir, who represents Ravi, Ram Kumar alias Ramu and Lav Kush – three men acquitted of rape charges in the Boolgarhi case – said that an Additional Civil Judge (Senior Division) of the MP/MLA Court had dismissed the complaint against Gandhi on May 13. Challenging the order, the complainants filed a revision petition, which the Additional District Judge admitted for hearing on July 15. A Dalit girl from Boolgarhi village in Hathras was allegedly gangraped in September 2020. She died days later during treatment at a hospital in Delhi. (PTI)

Three-day police custody for Arjun Ayanki in Kerala



A Kerala court on Tuesday granted custody of history-sheets Arjun Ayanki to the police for three days.

Ayanki was arrested on Sunday in connection with a case related to allegedly challenging State Home Minister Ramesh Chennithala on social media.

He was recently booked for allegedly challenging Chennithala and defaming Chief Minister VD Sathesaran on social media platforms.

Ayanki was remanded to three-day police custody by a court in Thalassery here. It also directed the police to produce him in court on Friday before 11.30 am.

Seeking his custody, the prosecution told the court that the mobile phone allegedly used to commit the offence had not yet been found.

The defence lawyers, on the other hand, claimed that the police were trying to create fake evidence against Ayanki.

They also told the court that the exact details of the seized mobile phone were not recorded in the custody application and the IMEI number of the device was not included in the remand report. (PTI)

Delhi High Court directs status quo on Sujan Singh Park, Ambassador Hotel

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi High Court has stayed a district court's decision upholding the Centre's bid to take over a portion of Sujan Singh Park here and directed the parties to maintain status quo with respect to the premises, including The Ambassador Hotel.

Justice Neena Bansal Krishna observed that the dispute arose from a 1945 perpetual lease between the Centre and Sir Sobha Singh and Sons Private Limited, and that the real-estate company's possession of the premises has been protected since 1960 despite pending litigation.

The judge's interim order came on an appeal filed by Sir Sobha Singh and Sons against the district court's June 9 decision, which overturned a civil court's 2009 ruling holding that the Government's attempt to "re-enter" the premises in 1960 after the determination of the perpetual lease was illegal.



"Substantial investments were made and the entire Sujan Singh Park Complex/suit property was developed. The possession of the plaintiff has remained protected since the year 1960, pending adjudication of the disputes in accordance with law....

"It also cannot be overlooked that the property has been constructed and has remained in use for several decades since the 1960s. The impact of the impugned judgment would not only affect the rights of the appellant, but may also affect numerous persons residing



Uddhav argues ECI action in Sena split unlawful

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A split in a legislature party can never, by itself, amount to a split in the political party and the Election Commission's decision to recognise the Eknath Shinde-led unit as "real Shiv Sena" and grant it the bow-and-arrow symbol was unlawful, the Uddhav Thackeray faction told the Supreme Court on Tuesday.

The assertions were made by senior advocate Kapil Sibal, appearing for the Shiv Sena (UBT), before a bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana on the third day of final hearing.

The bench was hearing two pleas filed in 2024 by the Uddhav faction against the poll panel's order allotting the 'bow and arrow' symbol to the Maharashtra Deputy Chief Minister Eknath Shinde-led unit.

The pleas have also challenged the February 17, 2023 order of the EC recognising the Shinde faction as the original Shiv Sena.

Assailing the poll panel's decision, Sibal said, "The assumption that the split in the legislative party means the split in the political party is unlawful and liable to be set aside."

Referring to a paragraph of the erstwhile Tenth Schedule of the Constitution, he said it also had a



similar requirement that the split had to occur in the original political party.

"Only thereafter could one-third of the legislators constitute a separate group. This issue was considered in a judgement," he added.

The court had rejected the argument that legislators wear two hats, one as members of the original political party and another as members of the legislature party, and that the formation of a separate group by one-third of the leg-

islators would itself be sufficient to infer a split in the original political party, he said.

"The court held that there were two distinct requirements: first, a split in the original political party; and second, a group comprising one-third of the legislators separating from the legislature party. It expressly rejected the proposition that a split in the original political party need not be separately established merely because there was a split in the legislature party," it said.

Delhi HC refuses bail to wrestler Sushil Kumar

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi High Court has refused to grant bail to Olympian Sushil Kumar in the alleged murder case of former junior national wrestling champion Sagar Dhankar.

Justice Purushendra Kumar dismissed the celebrated wrestler's bail application on August 6, citing concerns over influencing witnesses raised by the Supreme Court when it cancelled his earlier bail, his conduct prior to arrest, the gravity of the offence and his capacity to influence the ongoing trial's outcome.

The judge emphasised that while bail is ordinarily the rule and jail the exception, the offence in the present case was a "premeditated and gruesome assault result-



ing in death", which is corroborated by recovery of a firearm, video evidence and a large body of material yet to be tested at trial.

Seeking relief, the counsel for the accused alleged that the deceased's father, whose complaint led to the earlier cancellation of bail, has not supported the prosecution's case in the trial.

It was therefore contended that the "change in circumstances", along with the fact that Kumar had been in custody for over five years and only formal and official witnesses were left to be examined, entitled him to regular bail.

Delhi Police and Dhankar's father opposed the bail application.

Look at nature of suppression before terminating employee: SC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Tuesday said an employee's termination order for not disclosing criminal antecedents should not be mechanical and the employer must apply its mind before arriving at a decision on the nature of suppression, type of offence and nature of employment.

A bench of justices Sanjay Karol and AG Masih said termination is therefore not an automatic consequence of the disclosure of criminal antecedents; rather, the specific case of the employee must be considered, and the employer must apply its mind before arriving at a decision.

Restoring the job of Shatrughan Yadav, who was terminated from Fertilisers and Chemicals Travancore Ltd for not disclosing a non-cognizable offence case against him, the bench said an enquiry must be made by the employer before proceeding to terminate someone's services on the ground of suppression of information regarding criminal antecedents.

"The order of termination must not be mechanical but must have regard to the form of suppression, the outcome of the criminal case, the nature of the employment and of the offence, and any special circumstances.

"Termination is therefore



not an automatic consequence of the disclosure of criminal antecedents; rather, the specific case of the employee must be considered, and the employer must

apply its mind before arriving at a decision," it said.

The bench said the inquiry to be undertaken by the employer must be two-pronged — whether there

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Tuesday sought response from the Centre on a plea by Netaji Subhas Chandra Bose's daughter seeking directions for return of his "ashes" from Tokyo's Renkoji temple.

A bench of Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana issued notice to the Centre seeking its response on the plea filed by Anita B Pfaff, daughter of Netaji Bose.

Senior advocate Abhishek Singhvi, appearing for the petitioner, said she has "consistently and publicly sought repatriation of her father's mortal remains to India for final rites with dignity and



finality". There have been many theories surrounding Netaji's disappearance in August 1945. Some reports have suggested that his remains are preserved at the Renkoji temple in Tokyo.

In March this year, the apex court had refused to entertain a plea filed by the grand nephew of Netaji Bose seeking directions to bring



back to India the ashes believed to be those of Bose from Tokyo's Renkoji temple.

After the top court had shown its disinclination to entertain the plea, the counsel appearing for petitioner Ashish Ray had sought permission to withdraw it.

The bench had permitted him to withdraw the petition.

Contractual status can't deny regular benefits to special teachers: Allahabad High Court

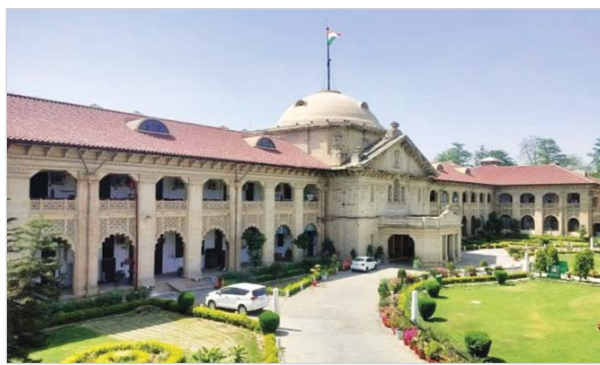
PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Lucknow

The Allahabad High Court's Lucknow Bench on Tuesday directed the state Government to extend pay parity and consequential service benefits to Special Teachers/Resource Teachers, on contract for several years in Government schools.

The court held that the contractual status of the teachers, who were roped in to educate children with special needs, could not be used to deny them benefits available to corresponding regular teachers.

The authorities have been given four months from the date of production of a certified copy of the order to implement the directions.

Justice Irshad Ali allowed a writ petition filed by the petitioners, Vipin Mishra and 23 others, who had been appointed as Itinerant Teachers and Resource Teachers through district-level selection committees and the Sarva Shiksha Abhiyan.



Though their appointments were described as contractual and their initial remuneration was fixed at ₹6,000 per month, the petitioners claimed that they performed duties identical to those of regular special teachers.

The petitioners worked across Government schools, imparting education to children with special needs and undertaking their assessment, rehabilitation, counselling and continuous monitoring, they contended.

They possess qualifications prescribed by the Rehabilitation Council of

India and worked for several years through successive renewals of their contractual arrangements, the petition said.

The dispute arose because, despite performing specialised educational duties for years, the petitioners were paid only a fixed honorarium while regular teachers performing comparable functions received regular pay scales and service benefits.

The petitioners contended that the denial of parity amounted to discrimination under Articles 14 and 16 of the Constitution. They also relied on Clause 12.3 of the

Integrated Education for Disabled Children (IEDC) Scheme, which specifically provided that special teachers should receive the same pay scales as teachers in the corresponding category.

Considering the contention, the bench held that the state could not selectively implement the scheme by taking advantage of its benefits while ignoring teachers' service conditions.

The court also observed that the petitioners were not engaged on a casual or sporadic basis, and they worked uninterrupted for years.

It held that merely describing their appointments as contractual could not defeat constitutional guarantees when they possessed the requisite qualifications and discharged substantially similar duties as corresponding special teachers.

The court also rejected the state's argument that some petitioners had subsequently accepted fresh appointments and their earlier claims had therefore become infructuous.

INTERVIEW

Bridging learning and employability

“Employability and deeper academic learning are in fact inseparable.” In conversation with *The Pioneer*, Ananya Mukherjee, Vice-Chancellor of Shiv Nadar University, Delhi-NCR, unpacks the real challenges facing Indian higher education today. She breaks down why colleges urgently need to ditch the fake divide between hard skills and traditional schooling to survive the AI era

Indian higher education is undergoing rapid transformation. What, in your view, should define a world-class Indian university today?
There are many factors, but let me focus on two that I believe are the most important. World-class universities can only thrive if the larger ecosystem is conducive to them and if they are valued by society at large. The second factor is collaboration. Universities must collaborate, and collaborations must be incentivised and recognised, both in teaching and research.

Artificial intelligence is transforming almost every profession. How should universities redesign their teaching and curricula for the AI era?

There is no single way in which teaching and curricula can be redesigned for the AI era. We need to do in-depth work to explore what changes are required in different domains of knowl-

edge. But, in general, teaching in the AI era should become more experiential, more interactive and require more teamwork. These skills need to be prioritised.

Parents and students today are increasingly focused on career outcomes. How can universities balance employability with deeper

academic learning, creativity and critical thinking?
Actually, employability and deeper academic learning are not incompatible with each other. They are, in fact, inseparable. However, we have created artificial distinctions between ‘skills’ and ‘education’, and ‘hard’ and ‘soft’ skills. The coming of AI shows that these distinctions need to be overcome — a university graduate must have command over a basket of skills and a deep understanding of fundamentals. How exactly this combination is to be delivered in India is our challenge, as these goals have to be approached at a huge scale and with enormous speed. Each university or college alone cannot

do it. We have had several mission-mode approaches for AI. These can be designed with greater depth for the different disciplines and for multidisciplinary programmes; execution manuals can also be developed. AI diffusion can then be initiated across the country in a systematic, non-threatening way that stokes the impulses for innovation and curiosity rather than fear.

India wants to become a global innovation and research powerhouse. What needs to change in our higher-education ecosystem to significantly strengthen university-led research?

First of all, research needs resources. I am not going to

minimise the need for resources. However, resources alone will not move the needle in a sector as large as India’s. A combination of research culture, research training and resources is required. Another extremely critical component is PhD training. There are some excellent global models of PhD training. We can draw upon these models, combine their best elements with the best practices in India and establish new benchmarks in doctoral training.

How important is collaboration between universities and industry in preparing students for emerging sectors such as AI, semiconductors, advanced manufacturing, biotechnology and clean technology?

In the case of these emerging industries, industry-academic collaboration is non-negotiable. I have two observations here. First off, these collaborations must be fully structured, rigorously designed and conducive to deep learning. Second, students need to learn about the social and political dimensions of these emerging technologies as well.

For example, over 500 million people do not have access to electricity, and another 2 billion rely on polluting fuels for cooking. Clean technology can be life-changing for such popu-



A UNIVERSITY GRADUATE MUST HAVE COMMAND OVER A BASKET OF SKILLS AND A DEEP UNDERSTANDING OF FUNDAMENTALS.

lations. However, technology alone cannot deliver the societal or human impact. So, it is important that universities teach about technology within its social, political and human contexts.

What qualities and skills do you believe will distinguish successful graduates over the next decade, particularly when technology itself is constantly changing?

Four things: resilience, decision-making ability, systems thinking, and the ability to learn continuously. Some may call these ‘capabilities’ rather than skills. However we see it, it is critical that all educational institutions develop these capacities in their graduates. This will also require a new approach to assessment structures. Examination-based approaches may not be able to assess these capabilities.

Global exposure defines careers



DIVYANSH CHAUDHARI
Founder, TerraTern – Global Talent Mobility Platform

Not long ago, a successful career followed a familiar path. A degree from a reputed institution, strong academic performance and a stable first job were often enough to build long-term professional success. Today, that equation has fundamentally changed.

Artificial Intelligence is reshaping how work gets done, businesses are increasingly operating across borders, and professionals are collaborating with global teams regardless of where they are located. In this evolving landscape, qualifications may help professionals open the first door, but they are rarely enough to distinguish them over the course of their careers. What increasingly separates high-performing professionals is their ability to adapt quickly, collaborate across cultures and thrive in unfamiliar environments. That is precisely where global exposure becomes a defining career advantage.

Whether through international education, cross-border projects, multicultural workplaces or overseas employment, individuals are exposed to new ways of thinking, communicating and solving problems. These experiences build qualities that

organisations increasingly value: adaptability, cultural intelligence, confidence, communication and independent decision-making.

Global careers no longer require permanent relocation. Remote work, digital collaboration platforms and international hiring have enabled professionals to contribute to organisations across continents without necessarily leaving their home country. As organisations become more global, professionals who can communicate effectively across cultures naturally become more valuable.

Artificial Intelligence is undoubtedly transforming the workplace, but its greatest impact may not be replacing people, it is redefining the skills that matter most. As AI automates repetitive and routine tasks, distinctly human capabilities become increasingly valuable. Working across cultures requires empathy, listening, negotiation and adaptability qualities that technology alone cannot replicate.

Global exposure today is less about physical location and more about active participation in a connected world. Degrees will continue to open doors. It is adaptability, cross-cultural competence and a global mindset that will determine how many more doors open thereafter.

Gen Z: Choosing creative degrees

SANJAY GUPTA
Founding Vice-Chancellor of World University of Design, Sonipat

For decades, the career choices of Indian students seemed almost predetermined. Engineering, medicine, law and commerce dominated conversations around higher education, while creative disciplines were often viewed as niche, risky or suitable only for the exceptionally talented. That landscape is changing rapidly. Today’s students, Generation Z, are entering adulthood at a time when technology, artificial intelligence, digital media and the creator economy are fundamentally reshaping the world of work.

Creative education aligns well with these aspirations. Unlike traditional education, which often focuses on established knowledge and fixed answers, creative disciplines encourage students to question assumptions, solve open-ended problems and learn through experimentation. They prepare students not only for today’s jobs but also for careers that evolve with technology and society.

The definition of a “creative career” has expanded significantly. It now spans design, architecture, animation, game development, filmmaking, digital media, UX, product innovation, creative writing, performing arts, advertising, branding, fashion, creative entrepreneurship and many other emerging fields.

The definition of a “creative career” has expanded dramatically. It no longer refers only to painters, musicians or fashion designers. Today’s creative economy spans design, architecture, animation, game development, filmmaking, photography, visual communication, digital media, user experience (UX), product innovation, creative writing, performing arts, advertising, branding, exhibition design, luxury business, fashion management, creative entrepreneurship and many

more emerging fields. Today, these professions sit at the intersection of creativity, technology and business. The degrees available today are in far more diverse areas than many parents realise. Design education has diversified into Product Design, Transportation Design, Interior Design, Communication Design, UX & Interaction Design, Animation, Game Design, Digital Product Design and Service Design. Architecture now extends beyond buildings to encompass sustainable cities, urban experiences and human-



BEFORE MAKING A DECISION, EVERY ASPIRING STUDENT SHOULD ASK FIVE IMPORTANT QUESTIONS:

1. Does this programme match my aptitude and interests, not just my marks?
2. Will I graduate with a strong portfolio as well as a degree?
3. Does the curriculum integrate AI, emerging technologies and interdisciplinary learning?
4. Will I learn through studio practice, live projects, internships and industry exposure?
5. Will this programme prepare me for the careers of tomorrow, not just the jobs of today?

centred environments. Fashion education includes not only design but also communication, retail, merchandising, technology and business. Film and communication design programmes prepare students for careers across cinema, OTT platforms, advertising, digital storytelling and immersive content. Performing arts increasingly connect with arts management, digital production and cultural entrepreneurship.

Ironically, the rise of Artificial Intelligence has strengthened the case for creative education. As India’s creative economy expands, the distinction between “creative” and “non-creative” careers is steadily disappearing. Today, engineers need design thinking, business leaders need storytelling, healthcare relies on human-centred design, and technology companies employ designers, filmmakers, researchers and artists alongside software engineers. Choosing the right creative programme is about more than selecting a degree. Students should consider how they will learn, what they will create and who they will become by the end of the programme. Creative education is no longer about preparing students for a single profession. It is about preparing them for a lifetime of innovation, learning and reinvention.

Reclaiming readers: Bringing books back to living rooms

ARCHANA SHARMA AWASTHI AND YUVRAJ MALIK
Archana Sharma Awasthi is Additional Secretary, Department of School Education and Literacy, Ministry of Education, Government of India. Yuvraj Malik is Director, National Book Trust, India

There are many little ways to enrich a child’s world. Joy of reading is the best of them.” India’s education discourse has, for long, centred on access — access to schools, to textbooks, to digital infrastructure. These are critical, but as we stand at the threshold of a new phase in Indian education, an equally urgent question that confronts us is:



Are we raising a generation that reads?

It is this question — deceptively simple, consequential in its implications — that gave birth to the Rashtriya e-Pustakalaya (ReP) or the National Digital Library. The platform was conceived not merely as a digital archive, but as a living effort to enrich India’s reading culture from within the home, the school and the community. Today, ReP hosts over 7,000+ carefully curated books across 23 languages, developed in partnership with hundreds of publishers and aligned with the vision of the National Education Policy 2020.

Removing barriers, not replacing habits

For many children across India — particularly in rural, semi-urban, and underserved regions — access to books beyond the prescribed textbook remains a genuine constraint. The nearest bookshop may be many kilometres away. The school library may be stocked with titles that are dated, or it may not be available beyond school hours. For these children, the imagination is willing but the material



is not there. Rashtriya e-Pustakalaya addresses this gap: a child, regardless of geography or income, can now reach into a library of thousands through the device already in their home. For anytime, anywhere reading. It also gives an opportunity to access books in languages beyond Hindi and English. But it is equally important to be clear about what this initiative is not. As a society, we must ask ourselves a simple but searching question: can we

reclaim a fraction of passive screen consumption and return it to productive reading? The answer, we believe, is yes — if we make the books available, make them inviting, and make reading feel like a choice rather than a chore. Working with educators: The next phase As Rashtriya e-Pustakalaya enters its next phase, the centrality of educators cannot be overstated. Teachers, librarians, and school leaders are not simply facilitators of learning — they are culture builders. The reading habits a child forms in school often persist for life. The books a librarian recommends can change the direction of a young person’s thinking. Meaningful integration of ReP into school life will require deliberate effort across several dimensions:

- Revitalising library classes as active learning spaces, not supervised study halls
- Encouraging guided reading and storytelling sessions where teachers share their own favourite books
- Creating peer-led book discussions and reading circles that give students ownership of the habit
- Embedding reading into the daily rhythm of school life, so that it feels as natural as morning assembly
- Improving writing skills by understanding various methods of writing.

A living, evolving library
Unlike the traditional library — fixed in its shelves and constrained by its physical dimensions — Rashtriya e-Pustakalaya is designed to be dynamic. It is a treasure of books in your hands. It also gives readers the opportunity to express what other books should be added. The available books are also about the rich heritage and culture of Bharat, which the young generation should know about.

A collective responsibility
Ultimately, the success of Rashtriya e-Pustakalaya will not be determined by the number of downloads or registered users, important as those signals are. It will be determined by whether reading becomes a habit once again — in homes, in schools, in the quiet corners of Bharat’s extraordinary diversity of communities. It’s when a child in a remote area has eyes twinkling when she reads a book she has only heard about. **A national call to read**
The platform also keeps hosting activities like the current ‘Rashtriya Kavya Utsav’ and a call for citizens to contribute to storytelling. A lot more fun and engaging activities will be a continuous part of the Rashtriya e-Pustakalaya. India has always been a civilisation of stories. From the oral traditions that preceded the written word to the great literary canons of Hindi, Sanskrit, Tamil, Bengali, Marathi and a dozen other tongues. This land has never been short of narrative. What is at risk today is not the stories themselves, but the habit of seeking them out — the willingness to sit still, to follow a sentence, to give a book the time it asks for.

Iranian-backed Houthi rebels renew attacks on Yemen

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Dubai

Iranian-backed Houthi rebels renewed their attacks Tuesday on Government-controlled areas in Yemen as ongoing violence threatened to reignite the country's civil war and raised fears over new threats to shipping lanes.

Iran's foreign minister, meanwhile, underscored Tehran's stance against reopening the Strait of Hormuz until the US meets its conditions, in comments that came after US President Donald Trump said he was now demanding compensation from Iran "for all of the people that they have killed" in the past.

Houthis hit targets in central Yemen

Iranian-backed Houthi rebels in Yemen attacked the Government-



held port city of Mokha on the Red Sea coast and other areas of the country, deepening fears over threats to strategic shipping routes and a potential return to civil war.

Yemen's military said the rebels targeted both Mokha and the central province of Marib with missiles and drones but did not provide further details.

The Houthis struck Marib and the eastern province of Hadramout last week, killing dozens of Government troops and civilians. They hit Mokha with missiles and drones over the weekend and killed at least seven people, including three troops, according to the Yemeni military.

Mokha is a main port under Yemen's internationally recog-

nized Government and has been renovated to handle shipping to avoid the Houthi-held port of Hodeida.

The strikes came as part of a recent escalation by the Houthis against Government forces in Yemen and oil facilities in neighboring Saudi Arabia, which supports the internationally recognised Yemeni Government, and the kingdom's shipping in the Red Sea. With the Strait of Hormuz effectively shut down by Iran, there has been a renewed focus on the Red Sea and Bab el-Mandeb Strait at Yemen's southern tip, which is an alternate route for Saudi Arabia to ship its oil to open oceans. The Houthi attacks could reignite Yemen's civil war after a four-year hiatus following a 2022 truce, and open a new front in the Middle East war.

Iranian FM underline's Tehran's demands

Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi told reporters in Iran that the country had "astounded the whole world" in the war against the United States and Israel, proving "that it is a tough and invincible power."

Iran has refused to back down on its demands that the US end its blockade of Iranian ports and fulfill other conditions before Tehran will consider reopening the Strait of Hormuz.

The closure of the key waterway — through which roughly one-fifth of the world's traded oil supplies passed before the war — has kept energy prices a major focus of US politics ahead of November's midterm elections. Araghchi said on his Telegram channel that in a

call with German Foreign Minister Johann Wadepuhl late Monday, he had "emphasised that making the Strait of Hormuz secure requires an end to the United States' aggressive actions and unlawful interventions, including the naval blockade and other violations of US obligations."

Wadepuhl said on X that he had emphasised "the Strait of Hormuz needs to be opened unconditionally ensuring free and safe navigation for all." Trump said, directing his negotiators to include "compensation from Iran, for all of the people that they have killed and gravely wounded with their roadside bombs and many conflicts." That was after Iran demanded compensation for the devastation caused to the country by the US and Israeli bombardment over the past five months.

PML-N likely to form Govt in PoK



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Islamabad

Two former so-called prime ministers suffered defeats in their strongholds in the third phase of elections in Pakistan-occupied Kashmir (PoK), according to unofficial results released on Tuesday.

Pakistan People's Party's Faisal Mumtaz Rathore, who is currently serving as the region's premier, managed to retain his seat in the polls, marred by violence and allegations of rigging.

According to the unofficial results, PPP bagged two seats while Pakistan Muslim League Nawaz (PMLN) and Awami Dast-o-Bazu Party, backed by both Jamaat-e-Islami (JeI) and Pakistan Tehreek-e-Insaf (PTI), won one seat each.

The third phase of voting, which concluded on Monday, was held in four out of 11 constituencies. The voting on the remaining seven seats was postponed "due to concerns over the law-and-order situation".

The first and second phases of the polls in the region's so-called legislative assembly were held on July 27 and August 2, and were marred by violent protests and massive rigging allegations.

The region's election commission has said that the voting for the remaining seats is likely to be held on August 21. India maintains that the entire Union Territories of Jammu & Kashmir and Ladakh are integral and inalienable parts of it. New Delhi also asserts that Pakistan has been in "illegal and forcible occupation" of parts of these Union Territories.

Ex-Syrian President Assad sentenced to death in absentia for war crimes

GHAITH ALSAYED/SAMAR KASSABALI ■ Damascus

A Syrian court sentenced ousted Syrian President Bashar Assad along with his younger brother to death in absentia on Tuesday for crimes against humanity and war crimes during Syria's 14-year conflict that left about half a million people dead.

The sentences at the Fourth Criminal Court in Damascus are the first against Assad or members of his inner circle since the Assad family's five decades in power came to an end 20 months ago.

"Bashar Assad used State agencies to commit war crimes and crimes against humanity," said judge Fakhreddine al-Aryan during a court session that was aired live on state TV.

Also sentenced to death was Assad's maternal cousin Atef Najib, who was convicted of overseeing a crackdown in the southern province of Daraa that led to the uprising and later the civil war. Al-Aryan said Najib can appeal.

Under tight security, Najib stood inside a cage wearing a prisoner's uniform as the judge read the sentence. A crowd gathered outside the courthouse in central Damascus to hear the verdict.

"Today is the day of justice for all the wounded, martyrs, detainees and Syrians who were forced to leave their country," said attorney Adnan al-Masalmeh who represented families of Najib's victims. "Today marks a victory of right against injustice, a victory of the Syrian people against the ousted regime." Assad and his brother Maher fled to



Russia after the Government's fall in December 2024 and received political asylum. Syria's new rulers have asked Russia to hand the Assads over.

Najib, who was sanctioned by the US Department of the Treasury in April 2011, was later detained and is one of the highest-ranking security officials to be put on trial.

Najib is a former army brigadier general who was head of the Political Security Branch in Syria's southern Daraa province under Assad in 2011. During his tenure, more than a dozen teenagers who scrawled anti-Government graffiti on a school wall in Daraa were arrested and tortured. The case became a catalyst for mass protests against the repressive policies of Assad's security forces.

The protests were met by a brutal Government crackdown that spiraled into a 14-year civil war that ended with Assad's ouster in a lightning rebel offensive. Some of Najib's victims were present at the courthouse including two who were teenagers in 2011 and expressed their opinions to The Associated Press.

Russian strikes kill 10 in Ukraine

ILLIA NOVIKOV ■ Kyiv

Russia attacked Ukrainian cities with missiles, drones and glide bombs on Tuesday, killing at least 10 civilians, officials said, as President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said Moscow is getting new military help from North Korea for its more than 4-year-old invasion.

Zelenskyy said Russian forces used ballistic missiles supplied by North Korea in an overnight attack on the southeastern city of Zaporizhzhia, where officials said seven people were killed and 24 wounded. Three more people, including a 15-year-old boy, were killed by Russian drones and artillery in the central Dnipropetrovsk region, authorities said.

In addition to the ballistic missiles, North Korea is preparing to deploy more of its troops to Russia, Zelenskyy said. Russian President Vladimir Putin and North Korean leader Kim Jong Un signed a strategic partnership agreement in 2024, pledging mutual aid if either country faces aggression. Kim has sent



thousands of troops and huge supplies of weapons to support Putin's full-scale invasion of Ukraine.

Ukraine says Russia is scaling up its production of ballistic missiles, aiming to exploit Kyiv's critical shortage of Patriot air defense interceptors that can stop them, and claims Moscow is preparing to recruit more troops for a new push on the front line that stretches 1,250 kilometers (775 miles) along eastern and southern Ukraine. "Every step Russia takes — increasing ballistic missile production, bringing in North Korean equipment, preparing for mobilisation — all of this shows that Moscow is preparing not for peace, but for escalation," Zelenskyy said on social media.

UNITY SMALL FINANCE BANK LIMITED

5th Floor, Tower 1, Seawoods Grand Central, Sec-40, Seawoods, above Seawoods Darave Railway Station, Navi Mumbai – 400 706

DEMAND NOTICE

UNDER THE PROVISIONS OF THE SECURITISATION AND RECONSTRUCTION OF FINANCIAL ASSETS AND ENFORCEMENT OF SECURITY INTEREST ACT, 2002 ("the Act") AND THE SECURITY INTEREST (ENFORCEMENT) RULES, 2002 ("the Rules")

The undersigned being the authorized officer of Unity Small Finance Bank Limited under the Act and in exercise of powers conferred under Section 13 (12) of the Act read with the Rule 3, issued Demand Notice(s) under Section 13(2) of the Act, calling upon the following borrower(s) to repay the amount mentioned in the respective notice(s) within 60 days from the date of receipt of the said notice. The undersigned reasonably believes that borrower(s) is/are avoiding the service of the demand notice(s), therefore the service of notice is being effected by affixation and publication as per Rules. The contents of demand notice(s) are extracted herein below:

Sr. No.	Name of the Borrower(s)/ Co-Borrower (s)	Demand Notice Date & Amount	Description of secured assets (Immovable Property)
1	Loan A/C. No(S). : USFBDLLOAN0000050050833 1. Praveen Kumar Jain S/o. Shikhar Chand Jain	13.07.2026 Rs. 26,15,331.65/- (Rs. Twenty-Six Lakhs Fifteen Thousand Three Hundred Thirty One And Sixty-Five Paise Only) As On 06.07.2026 NPA Date : 08.06.2026	All That Piece And Parcel Of The Entire Ground Floor (Without Roof/Terrace Rights) Of Built-Up Freehold Property Bearing No 13, In Block-E, Pocket-1, Sector-16, Built On Land Area Measuring 48sq.mtrs. Rohni, Delhi-110083 are Bounded As Follows: Surrounded By Boundaries :- North : Plot No. 12, East : Service Lane 4.5 Mtrs, South : Plot No. 14, West : Road 9 Mtrs.
	2. Priya Jain S/o. Ashish Kumar Jain		
2	1. Anubhav Jain, S/o. Praveen Kumar Jain Add For Sr. No. 1 : 8/94, 60 Foota Road, Near Shiv Mandir, North-East Delhi, 110094. Add For Sr. No. 3 : D-48 Kh.No. 618/56, D-Block, West Yojti Nagar Extn, North-East Delhi, 110094. Also At : D-48, Gali No -6, Near Shiv Mandir, West Yojti Nagar, North-East Delhi 110094. Shit Mandir West Yojti Nagar, North-East Delhi, 110094. Add For Sr. No. 1, 2 & 3 : D-36 Plot No. 36 West Yojti Nagar Shahdara Delhi 110094.	17.07.2026 Rs. 38,32,581.00/- (Rupees Thirty-Eight Lakh Thirty-Two Thousand Five Hundred Eighty-One Only) As On 17.07.2026 NPA Date : 03.07.2024	All The Piece And Parcel Of Immovable Residential Built-Up Property Bearing No. D-36, (Plot No. 36, Block-D) Land Measuring Area 52 Sq. Yard, I.e. 43.47 Sq. Mtrs., Out Of Kharsa No. 50, Situated In The Area Of Village Sikdar Pur, In The Abadi Of West Yojti Nagar, Illaga Shahdara, Delhi. Consisting Of According To Site In Four Storey Building, With The Rights Of Upper Construction Up To The Last Storey, Fitted With Electricity And Water Tap Both Are In Running Conditions Surrounded By Boundaries :- North : Property Of Others, South : Property Of Others East : Road 40ft Wide, West: Property Of Others
3	Loan A/C. No(S). : USFBDLLOAN000005016130 1. M/s. Singhal Foam House Represented By Its Partners 2. Aman Aggarwal, S/o. Vijay Kumar 3. Veena Gupta Alias Veena W/o. Vijay Kumar Add For Sr. No. 1 : Ground Floor-A-31/130, Mata Mandir Marg, Gali No. 2, Mujpur, North-East Delhi, 110053. Add For Sr. No. 2 : D-48, Gali No -6, Near Shiv Mandir, West Yojti Nagar, North-East Delhi 110094. Add For Sr. No. 3 : D-48 Kh.No. 618/56, D-Block, West Yojti Nagar Extn, North-East Delhi, 110094. Also At : D-48, Gali No -6, Near Shiv Mandir, West Yojti Nagar, North-East Delhi 110094. Shit Mandir West Yojti Nagar, North-East Delhi, 110094. Add For Sr. No. 1, 2 & 3 : D-36 Plot No. 36 West Yojti Nagar Shahdara Delhi 110094.	23.07.2026 Rs. 97,06,536.39/- (Rupees Ninety-Seven Lakh Six Thousand Five Hundred Thirty-Six And Thirty-Nine Paise Only) As On 18.07.2026 NPA Date : 02.06.2026	All That Piece And Parcel Of Immovable Built Up Property, Area Measuring 75 Sqyds. I.e. 62.71 Sq.mtrs., Bearing Property No. B-267, Out Of Kharsa No.648, Consisting Of According To The Site With The Rights To Use And Construct Up To The Last Storey, Situated At Village Saboli, In The Abadi Of B-Block, Main Shukar Bazar Chowk, Ashok Nagar, Illaga Shahdara, Delhi-110093, Which Is Bounded As Under :- Surrounded By Boundaries :- North: Property Of Others/Gali 10 Ft. East : Property Of Others/Part Of Plot No.268., South : Road 20 Ft.wide., West : Property Of Others/Part Of Plot No.267.

The borrower(s) are hereby advised to comply with the demand notice(s) and to pay the demand amount mentioned therein and hereinabove within 60 days from the date of this publication together with applicable interest, additional interest, bounce charges, cost and expenses till the date of realization of payment. The borrower(s) may note that USFBL is a secured creditor and the loan facility availed by the Borrower(s) is a secured debt against the immovable property/properties being the secured asset(s) mortgaged by the borrower(s). In the event borrower(s) are failed to discharge their liabilities in full within the stipulated time, USFBL shall be entitled to exercise all the rights under Section 13(4) of the Act to take possession of the secured asset(s) including but not limited to transfer the same by way of sale or by invoking any other remedy available under the Act and the Rules thereunder and realize payment. USFBL is also empowered to ATTACH AND/OR SEAL the secured asset(s) before enforcing the right to sale or transfer. Subsequent to the Sale of the secured asset(s), USFBL also has a right to initiate separate legal proceedings to recover the balance dues, in case the value of the mortgaged properties is insufficient to cover the dues payable to the USFBL. This remedy is in addition and independent of all the other remedies available to USFBL under any other law. The attention of the borrower(s) is invited to Section 13(8) of the Act, in respect of time available, to redeem the secured assets and further to Section 13(13) of the Act, whereby the borrower(s) are restrained/prohibited from disposing of or dealing with the secured asset(s) or transferring by way of sale, lease or otherwise (other than in the ordinary course of business) any of the secured asset(s), without prior written consent of USFBL and non-compliance with the above is an offence punishable under Section 29 of the said Act. The copy of the demand notice is available with the undersigned and the borrower(s) may, if they so desire, can collect the same from the undersigned on any working day during normal office hours.

Place : Delhi
Date : 12.08.2026
Sd/-
Authorized Officer
Unity Small Finance Bank Limited

PUBLIC NOTICE

"Be it known to the general public that my client, Smt. Kusum Wati W/o Late Sh. Pitam Singh aged about 58 years R/o C-2/142, Gali No. 5 Harsh Vinar Delhi-110093, has disowned her son namely Ashish Kumar and his wife, Smt. Lalita Devi from all her moveable and immovable property and severed her relationship with her above named son and his wife as a result of sufferings and harassment due to unsocial, aggressive, and inhumane act & behavior of her above mentioned daughter-in-law and her son. If anybody keeps any relation or deals with them in any manner whatsoever, he/she would be doing solely at his/her own risk and consequences and my client shall not be responsible for the act of Ashish Kumar and his wife, Smt. Lalita Devi, Ashok Thagpal Advocate Chamber No. 477, (LGF) Civil Wing, Tis Hazari Court, Delhi-54

PUBLIC NOTICE

It is for general information that M/s RRM Services Address C-95 Karampura, New Delhi 110015 has got amendment on 20/07/2026 incoming partners are Sunil Kumar Agarwal, Jaipal Singh, Sakshi Tomar Parihar, Faaguni Kapoor. For RRM SERVICES Management

CONTINENTAL CHEMICALS LIMITED

CIN - L24123UP1984PLC014111

REGISTERED OFFICE: A-7, SECTOR-7, NOIDA-201301, U.P.

Tel : 91-120-2423316 Email: info@continentalsoft.com, nkc@continentalsoft.com web: www.continentalchemicalsltd.com

UNAUDITED FINANCIAL RESULTS FOR THE QUARTER ENDED 30th JUNE, 2026

Amount in lakh except EPS

PARTICULARS	3 Months Ended 30.06.2026	3 Month Ended 31.03.2026	3 Month Ended 30.06.2025	Year ended 31.03.2026
	(Unaudited)	(Audited)	(Unaudited)	(Audited)
1 Income from operations	42.67	43.88	40.76	167.80
2 Net Profit/ (Loss) for the period (before Tax, Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	12.75	13.51	16.27	58.76
3 Net Profit/ (Loss) for the period before Tax (after Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	12.75	13.51	16.27	58.76
4 Net Profit/ (Loss) for the period after tax (after Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	11.54	11.80	14.41	51.21
5 Total Comprehensive Income for the period (comprising Profit/ (Loss) for the period (after tax)	11.56	12.03	14.36	51.67
6 Equity Share Capital	224.90	224.90	224.90	224.90
7 Reserves (excluding Revaluation Reserve as shown in the Balance Sheet of previous year)	-	-	-	329.83
8 Earnings Per Share (of Rs. 10/-each)				
Basic :	0.51	0.53	0.64	2.28
Diluted :	0.51	0.53	0.64	2.28

Notes:

1 The above financial result are reviewed by audit committee and thereby have been taken on records by board of Director in their meeting held on 11.08.2026

2 Previous period figures have been re-grouped/reclassified whenever necessary to make them comparable with the current period figures.

3 These result have been prepared in accordance with the Companies (Indian Accounting Standards) Rule 2015 (Ind As) prescribed under Section 133 of the Companies Act 2013 and other recognised accounting practices and policies to the extent possible.

4 The company operates only in one segment

5 The above is an extract of the detailed format of Quarterly Financial Results filed with the Stock Exchange under Regulation 33 of the SEBI (Listing and Other Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015. The full format of the Quarterly Financial Results are available on the website of the Stock Exchange i.e. BSE Limited at www.bseindia.com and website of the listed entity i.e. Continental Chemicals Ltd at www.continentalchemicalsltd.com. The same can be accessed by scanning the QR code provided below.

Place : Noida
Date : 11.08.2026



For and on behalf of the Board of
Continental Chemicals Limited
Sd/-
(Naresh Kumar Chibba)
Managing Director
DIN: 00376963

For and on behalf of Board of Directors of
Oriental Nagpur Betul Highway Limited
Sd/-
Rajesh Yadav
Whole Time Director
Place: New Delhi
Date: August 11, 2026
DIN: 08397240

PROSPECT



BCCI Secretary Devajit Lon Saikia visits BCCI Centre of Excellence (CoE) in Bengaluru. PIONEER PHOTO

Saikat Chakraborty wins PRSI Best PR Manager of the Year Award



Saikat Chakraborty, Chief Manager (Corporate Communications), GAIL (India) Limited (third from left), has been conferred the prestigious Dr CVN-Public Relations Society of India (PRSI) 'Best PR Manager of the Year (2025-26)' Award. The award was presented by Dr G Vivek Venkataswamy, Minister for Labour, Employment, Training & Factories, and Mines & Geology, Government of Telangana, at a special ceremony held in Hyderabad. The event was attended by Dr Ajit Pathak, National President, PRSI, along with senior dignitaries of PRSI and the Dr CVN Reddy PR Foundation. Chakraborty was recognised for his exemplary contributions as Lead - Corporate Communications at GAIL Gas Limited, a wholly owned subsidiary of GAIL (India) Limited. Through a series of innovative public relations initiatives and strategic use of digital communication platforms, he played a pivotal role in transforming the communications function from a support service into a strategic business enabler, significantly strengthening the organisation's brand visibility and stakeholder engagement. (PNS)

STCL Sports launches cricket talent hunt

STCL Sports launched the Salute Tiranga Cricket League (STCL) website and nationwide open trial programme in New Delhi. The initiative aims to give young cricketers across India a structured platform with professional training and a pathway to professional cricket. Former BCCI Selection Committee Chairman and STCL League Commissioner Chetan Sharma, former Test cricketer Ashok Malhotra, Chairman Rajesh Jha, Vice Chairman Ravi Chikara and Director Mukesh Kumar Singh attended the event. Sharma said STCL will bring former Indian players together to mentor youth. STCL Chairman Rajesh Jha said the league aims to connect young cricketing talent with the right opportunities. (PNS)



Sadhguru launches new photo essay book *Disappearing Faces*

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Sadhguru's new photography book *Disappearing Faces*, featuring photographs of people he encountered during his journeys through the remote Himalayas of Nepal and Tibet, was launched on Monday at the India International Centre (IIC), New Delhi.

Published by Penguin India, *Disappearing Faces* offers an intimate visual record of the people Sadhguru encountered during his journeys through some of the most remote landscapes of the Himalayas. Carrying a camera along the way, Sadhguru began documenting faces shaped by a life lived close to nature and increasingly distant from the rhythms of modern life. The book was launched in



the presence of Union Minister Mansukh Mandaviya, followed by a conversation between Sadhguru and author and commentator Anand Ranganathan, exploring the stories and experiences behind the photographs. Speaking about the book during the conversation, Sadhguru said, "These faces represent an era that will soon disappear: faces etched

only by sensory perception of light and darkness, heat and cold, of springs and winters-above all, uncontaminated by information that is disconnected from our senses. Our senses lead to a certain sense of life where there is no Non-sense. These are the visages that represent life that seems rudimentary but is rich with strong experiences of the land, the winds, the waters

and the people. Over the last five decades, year after year, beyond the beauty and wondrous nature of the mountains, these faces have drawn me into the deep crevices of the Himalayas."

Sadhguru first journeyed to Manasarovar and Mount Kailash in 2006 and has since returned repeatedly, leading seekers on the Himalayan pilgrimage. After undertaking his first motorcycle journey to Kailash in 2025, Sadhguru is set to return once again this year on a motorcycle, continuing his unique engagement with the sacred landscape of the Himalayas.

The Himalayas have remained a significant part of Sadhguru's life over the years, alongside his efforts towards human wellbeing, raising human consciousness, and his commitment to ecological regeneration.

The officer who feared having a daughter made a film about it

ABHINAV KUMAR JHA
■ New Delhi

Ashwani Kumar is a Secretary in the IT Department of the Government of Assam and the Director of DITEC. He is also an IIT Madras alumnus and a career civil servant. Last Sunday, he was at PVR Chanakyapuri watching himself on screen, playing a police officer who initially opposes his wife's decision to continue a pregnancy when they learn the child will be a girl. The film is called *Devyani*. It is streaming on ZEE5. And it begins from a place that Kumar says is more complicated than simple prejudice.

"Many people want a daughter; they desire to have one. However, they are held back by fear, fear of a society where times are tough, where one doesn't know if a girl who steps out will return safely. Every day, she faces the risk of harassment, whether outside, within her extended family, or even in her own home," Kumar said at the screening. "I have observed this and personally felt that, and that is what I have tried to portray here."

The short film addresses



BJP MLA Pankaj Singh (left) and Ashwani Kumar, IAS, at the screening of short film *Devyani* at PVR Chanakyapuri on Sunday. PIONEER PHOTO

female foeticide through this specific lens. The police officer at the story's centre is not a villain. He is a man shaped by the same anxieties that Kumar described at the screening, the concerns about dowry, safety, and a society that continues to make the raising of daughters more difficult than it should be. An incident changes his perspective through the course of the film. He comes to support the pregnancy. He names the child *Devyani*.

The film stars Kumar alongside Archana Gautam, is directed by Ashish K Panda, and is written by Anwarullah Khan. It is produced by Aaroha Production. BJP MLA Pankaj Singh, who attended the

Sunday screening at PVR Chanakyapuri, appreciated Kumar's performance and commitment to the role.

What makes the film's premise quietly unusual is the portrait of a father whose resistance is rooted in fear rather than straightforward misogyny. The distinction matters. A man who does not want his daughter because he is terrified of what a world indifferent to her safety will do to her is a different kind of problem, and arguably a harder one to address through legislation or public campaigns alone.

CM Himanta inspects ongoing works at Guwahati Science City

TONY DAS
■ Guwahati

Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma visited Guwahati Science City at Sonapur and inspected the ongoing works at the centre. He also held a review meeting with the departmental authorities to assess the progress of the works planned for the next phase of development of the centre.

Talking to the media after the visit, Sarma said that the construction of Guwahati Science City is underway on more than 150 bighas of land. Informing that several new additions are currently being developed following its formal inauguration five months ago, he expressed hope that the Science City would be completed in its entirety by March 2027.

The Chief Minister announced that the State Government would provide an additional Rs 100 crore for undertaking various works aimed at making the Science City more attractive and engaging for visitors. These would include a digital panorama, a convention centre, a musical fountain,



Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma inspecting and reviewing the ongoing works of Zubeen Kshetra at Kamarkuchi, Sonapur. PIONEER PHOTO

parking facilities, and other related infrastructure. The project is being implemented jointly by the Ministry of Culture, Government of India, and the Department of Science and Technology, Government of Assam. The Chief Minister expressed hope that, upon completion of all the planned works, Guwahati Science City would emerge as one of the finest science cities in the country.

Urging people of all age groups, particularly school and college students, to visit the Science City, Sarma said that the State Government is also considering the introduction of a dedicated Assam State Transport Corporation (ASTC) bus service from

Guwahati to the Science City. He added that a decision in this regard would be taken very shortly.

During the visit, Minister for Science and Technology etc Keshab Mahanta, Minister Agriculture etc Pijush Hazarika, Minister for Food, Public Distribution and Consumer Affairs Kaushik Rai, along with senior government officials were present during Chief Minister's visit.

The Chief Minister also visited 'Zubeen Khetra' at Komarkuchi in Sonapur, where he inspected the premises of the memorial site of renowned singer and artiste Zubeen Garg and took stock of the ongoing construction works.

Nainaa's Kitchen to represent MP at Bharatiya Vyapar Mahotsav 206



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Panna

Panna-based leading food and wellness company Nainaa's Kitchen Pvt Ltd has been selected among only 9 Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises (MSMEs) from Madhya Pradesh to represent the state at Bharatiya Vyapar Mahotsav 2026, being held from 12 to 15 August 2026 at Bharat Mandapam, New Delhi.

The prestigious event is among the country's major business platforms and will bring together more than 2,000 exhibitors, over 200,000 business delegates and more than 5,000 international buyers.

The Mahotsav aims to create new business opportunities for Indian enterprises, promote exports and connect MSMEs with global markets. At this national platform, Nainaa's Kitchen Pvt Ltd will showcase its two distinctive brands. Under Nainaa's Kitchen, the company will present its innovation-led wellness food portfolio, including Amla Honey Spread Chocolate, its complete Honey Spread Range, and other value-added food products. Through Foresta Origins,

the company's premium gourmet and gifting brand inspired by the natural and forest heritage of Panna, visitors will experience products including Mahua Infused Honey, Chironji Saffron Honey Spread, Chickpea Leaves Pickle, along with its complete premium product collection. Speaking on the occasion, Rajkamal Sharma, Founder and Director of Nainaa's Kitchen Pvt Ltd, said that being selected among only nine MSMEs from Madhya Pradesh is a matter of immense pride for the company.

He said the opportunity goes beyond the company's own achievement and provides an important platform to showcase the natural heritage, local resources, innovation and entrepreneurial spirit of Panna and Madhya Pradesh at a national and international level.

He expressed his heartfelt gratitude to the MSME Department, Government of Madhya Pradesh, RAMP MSME, Madhya Pradesh Laghu Udyog Nigam Ltd. (MPLUN), District Trade & Industry Centre (DTIC), Panna, and CAIT Panna for their continued trust, guidance and support.

Assam minister Hazarika reviews fertiliser availability

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Guwahati

Assam Agriculture Minister Pijush Hazarika on Tuesday chaired two review meetings at the office conference room at Janata Bhawan to assess the availability and distribution of fertilisers in the state and review the progress of the National Mission on Edible Oils - Oil Palm (NMEO-OP) for the financial year 2026-27.

During the meeting on fertiliser availability, the Minister held detailed discussions with senior officials of the Agriculture Department on measures to ensure adequate and timely availability of fertilisers to farmers across the state. The meeting discussed the existing 12 rake points through which fertilisers are brought into Assam. Shri Hazarika emphasised the need to increase the number of rake points to facilitate faster and smoother transportation and distribution of fertilisers. He stated that the matter would be taken up with the concerned Central Ministry.

Representatives of all nine fertiliser companies operating in Assam were directed to ensure adequate availability of fertilisers and prevent short-

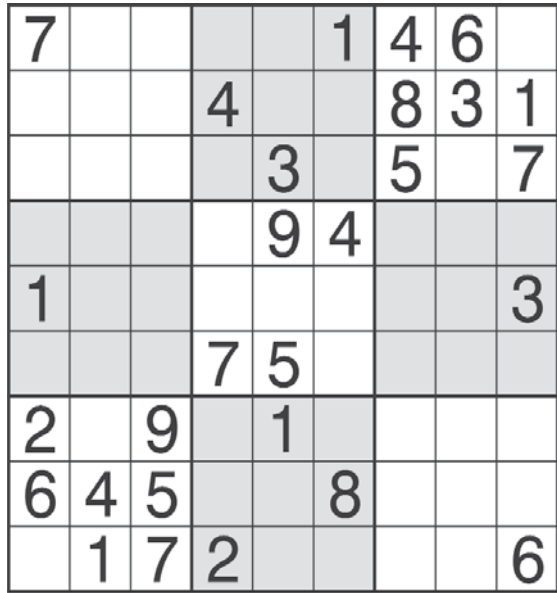


ages, particularly during the cropping season. The minister also stressed the need to ensure that farmers receive fertilisers at genuine prices. The meeting further discussed measures to check overcharging and black marketing of fertilisers. Hazarika directed the Agriculture Department to strengthen monitoring and take strict action against any malpractice affecting farmers.

The Department was also asked to examine feasible measures to give due preference to locally produced fertilisers, with a view to strengthening local production and improving availability within the state.

In the second meeting, the Minister reviewed the progress of the National Mission on Edible Oils - Oil Palm (NMEO-OP) for FY 2026-27.

DAILY SUDOKU



DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★

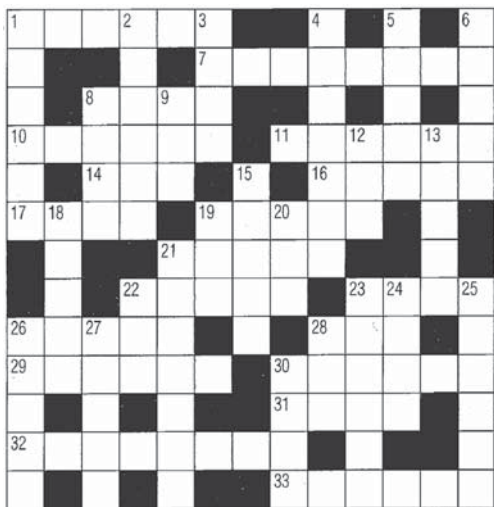
HOW TO SOLVE IT

Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9x9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3x3 box, using elimination and logical deduction—no maths involved.



SOLUTION (11.8.26)								
4	2	8	7	1	6	5	3	9
1	7	3	5	9	2	8	6	4
5	9	6	4	8	3	7	2	1
9	6	5	1	2	8	3	4	7
7	3	1	6	4	5	9	8	2
8	4	2	9	3	7	6	1	5
6	8	7	2	5	4	1	9	3
2	5	9	3	6	1	4	7	8
3	1	4	8	7	9	2	5	6

DOUBLE CROSSWORD
WEDNESDAY | AUGUST 12, 2026



ACROSS

- Many a girl shows spite (6)
- Due to bad luck, dice can't be played (8)
- Cliques as integral groups (4)
- State there's a holdup at Kew, we hear (6)
- Specially signed drawing (6)
- One part of a bottle of beer? (3)
- More than merely checked (5)
- Terribly sad about second-class swimmers (4)
- Going back to bed at some stage, remove the trousers (5)

DOWN

- Conspicuous vessel in the Mediterranean (6)
- Lofty ladies let loose (6)
- Right on the map (4)
- At work, he has his own lift (7)
- Holding this card is no credit to you (5)
- Put up with something holding up the music (5)
- Lubberly ways, to a seaman (4)
- The union game (3)
- Go down and turn up the gas (3)
- Name for a light-hearted girl? (5)
- Dogs used by Speke (5)

ACROSS

- Received with thanks by Mr Livingstone (5)
- What the hounds did, we hear (5)
- Gather some more apples (4)
- Find real chaos at the financial centre (5)
- For each childless person (3)
- Undertake to be the boss (6)
- Just the vehicle for a record track performance? (4-2)
- Some of the cheapest copies (4)
- Gently in the manner of a nurse (8)
- Grows fat like the rich (6)

DOWN

- Strange ways to a former champion (5)
- A sunny one can be a bit shady (3)
- The place for tired flowers? (3)
- Got mixed up in a fight! (7)
- A very feminine part for Ms Streisand (3)
- On earth, a strange creed could be regressive (6)
- They joined the RAF in Berkshire (4)
- Their news is documentary (6)
- Let's copy the Latvians? (5)
- Maturing makes a drink good (5)
- Character raised to appear unmoved (3)
- Hires a spy, shifty (4)

SOLUTION (11.8.26)		
ACROSS	DOWN	DOWN
1, Whist	19, D-Ivan	2, Hoiter
6, Peary	20, Tacked	3, S-we-den
10, Money	22, Sure	18, Paint
11, Scaff	24, Su-e	19, Desiree
12, Forth	25, Snapped	21, August
13, R-e-ver-ed	26, Tight	22, Sparse
15, Err	27, T-uto-r	23, Reined
17, I-ron	28, Frank	25, S-H-ack
18, Panama	29, Wen-ch-s	26, Town
	30, Stone	27, F-etid
	31, Wendy	13, Riffs
		14, V-O-ice

IndianOil Durand Cup: NorthEast United sail into quarterfinals

TONY DAS ■ Guwahati

NorthEast United FC marched into the quarter-finals with a perfect record in the group stages after comfortably defeating FC1 3-1 in their final Group F fixture of the 135th IndianOil Durand Cup at the Indira Gandhi Athletic Stadium on Tuesday, August 11, 2026.

Parthib Gogoi scored in each half, while Alaaeddine Ajaariae added NorthEast United's third goal. Mohmad Ilyas scored the consolation goal for FC1. The Highlanders completed their group-stage campaign with three wins from three matches to finish as Group F winners. FC1, meanwhile, ended their debut Durand Cup campaign with three points from three matches. All 43 matches of the 135th IndianOil Durand Cup will be broadcast LIVE on the Sony Sports Network and streamed live on SonyLIV.

NorthEast United FC head coach Juan Pedro Benali made 10 changes to his starting XI, with Spanish midfielder Antonio Moyano the only player retaining his place from the previous outing. Fellow Spaniards Etyan González Morales and Eneko Satrustegui Plano were also handed their first starts for the club. Meanwhile, FC1 head coach Khalid Qayoom made two changes to his lineup, bringing in midfielder Mousa Ahmed Quersehi and Ivorian defender Tetty Armando Yoko, both returning after suspensions in place of Kamran Hameed and Aafreen Bashir. FC1 were awarded a penalty inside the opening seven minutes after NorthEast United defender Robin Yadav handled the ball from a corner kick inside the penalty area. Mousa Ahmed Quersehi stepped up to take the spot-kick but was denied by NorthEast debutant K. Mohanraj, who produced a fine low diving save to his left to keep the scores level.

NorthEast United FC pun-



ished FC1 almost immediately, taking the lead just two minutes later through a well-worked move. Antonio Moyano picked out Jithin M.S., who had made a clever run between two defenders before delivering a low cross across the penalty area. Parthib Sunder Gogoi arrived unmarked at the back post and calmly slotted the ball into the net to give the Highlanders the lead.

FC1 enjoyed the majority of possession during the opening 25 minutes as NorthEast United FC opted against pressing high to regain the ball. The Jammu & Kashmir side also earned four corner kicks during this period, but their execution in the final third lacked the quality to test Mohanraj in the NorthEast goal.

With NorthEast United FC maintaining a disciplined mid-block and remaining compact in possession, FC1 struggled to build attacks through the centre of the pitch. The side from Jammu & Kashmir instead looked to exploit the spaces down the right flank and managed to create openings from wide

areas, but their lack of numbers inside the box meant they were unable to make the most of the crosses delivered by their wingers as the Highlanders took their one goal advantage into the half time break.

The home side doubled their advantage nine minutes after the restart, with Parthib Gogoi scoring his second of the day. Antonio Moyano delivered a dangerous free-kick into the area, and Eneko Satrustegui directed his header into a crowded area, where Parthib reacted quickly to bring the ball under control before producing a composed finish through a crowd of players and beyond the goalkeeper.

The Highlanders stepped up the intensity of their attacks, and moments later, substitute Lalrinzuala Lalbiaknia came close to adding another. Jithin M.S. delivered an inviting cross into the penalty area, but Lalrinzuala was unable to make the decisive connection and ball went out for a goal kick. Lalrinzuala remained at the heart of the Highlanders' attacking

moves, forcing a save from FC1 goalkeeper Aftab Ashraf at the end of a swift counter-attack after being played through by fellow substitute Alaaeddine Ajaariae. Ajaariae then missed a glorious opportunity moments later, failing to find the empty net after Ashraf was unable to gather a cross cleanly. The FC1 goalkeeper made amends in the next attack, producing another save to deny Ajaariae's left-footed effort.

FC1 were unable to withstand the sustained pressure from the Highlanders as they added a third goal. Parthib Sunder Gogoi threaded a precise through ball into the path of Alaaeddine Ajaariae, who calmly chipped the ball over the onrushing goalkeeper to find the back of the net. The goal was Ajaariae's sixth of the tournament.

FC1 stunned NorthEast United FC with a goal seemingly out of nowhere in the 71st minute, capitalising on a momentary lapse in concentration from the Highlanders' defence. Mousa Ahmed Quersehi threaded a through ball into the path of Mohmad Ilyas, who had timed his run perfectly to stay outside. Expecting an offside flag, the NorthEast defence switched off, allowing Ilyas to control the ball before calmly slotting it through the goalkeeper's legs to pull one back for his side.

NorthEast continued to find openings in the opposition half and with fresh legs introduced they continued to create chances while maintaining control in midfield to deny FC1 to mount any sort of comeback. Lalrinzuala and Ajaariae had chances to increase the scoreline but could not put the finishing touches.

NorthEast United saw out the remainder of the match with relative ease to secure the victory, confirm their place in the quarter-finals and extend their winning streak in the Durand Cup.

Paris medal miss fuels Maheshwari's Asian Games drive

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

■ New Delhi

Indian skeet shooter Maheshwari Chauhan, who missed out on a Paris Olympic medal by the narrowest of margins, is now looking to turn her lessons from the Games into success at next month's Asian Games in Japan.

Currently part of the Asian Games preparatory camp for trap and skeet shooters at the Karni Singh Shooting



Range here, Chauhan and Anantjeet Singh Naruka finished fourth in the mixed team skeet event in Paris,

missing out on the bronze medal by a single point.

Their fourth-place finish was still commendable, as they became the first Indian pair to reach the final of an Olympic skeet event.

The Rajasthan shooter, who is also a Khelo India athlete, said her Paris experience had boosted her confidence and given her a strong foundation to build on. "A debut Olympic Games can be a little strange but I did really enjoy myself and it's given me

a great base to build on and I think that's all I want to keep going ahead, learn from that experience," she told SAI Media on the sidelines of the camp.

"My actual expectation (from my debut Asian Games) is to really be very present and enjoy myself. I think I'm going to have the same approach to any competition. The titles keep changing and the process but the approach stays the same," said Chauhan.

PUNE MUNICIPAL CORPORATION
(PMC) PUNE 411 005.
Web:- <http://mahatenders.gov.in>
SUPERINTENDING ENGINEER BHAVAN DEPARTMENT

CORRIGENDUM
A corrigendum is being issued for the following tenders of the bhavan department of the pune municipal Corporation All the details regarding the tender terms, conditions etc. regarding the said work are available for viewing free of cost on www.mahatenders.gov.in in as mentioned in the tender document.

Sr. No.	Tender No.	Changes to the tender Of Date	
1	PMC/BHAVAN/19/2026-27	E-tender sale period-Tender acceptance period (final date & time)	From 25/07/2026 (after 2.30 PM) TO 08/08/2026 (upto 2.30 PM)
		Date of opening technical bid envelope	From 25/07/2026 (after 2.30 PM) to 08/08/2026 (up to 2.30 PM)
2	PMC/BHAVAN/20/2026-27	Instead of this, it should be read as follows:	
3	PMC/BHAVAN/21/2026-27	E-tender sale period-Tender acceptance period (final date & time)	From 25/07/2026 (after 2.30 PM) to 18/08/2026 (up to 2.30 PM)
4	PMC/BHAVAN/22/2026-27	Date of opening technical bid envelope	From 26/07/2026 (after 2.30 PM) to 18/08/2026 (up to 2.30 PM) From 19/08/2026 (after 3.00 PM)

All other content will remain as previously published.

Advt No. 3/548
Date:- 12/08/2026

Sd/-
SUPERINTENDING ENGINEER
BHAVAN DEPARTMENT
Pune Municipal Corporation
Pune 411005

NORTHERN RAILWAY
E-AUCTION NOTICE

The Sr. Divisional Commercial Manager/G, Northern Railway, Delhi Division, New Delhi invites e-Auction through IREPS (<https://ireps.gov.in/>) for allotment of Misc contracts of NFR at following Railway Stations:-

E-Catalogue No.	Type of Asset	Station	Date & Time for e-Auction
Advt-Aug-03-26	Unipole OOH	Cluster-A & C	Start: 21.08.2026 at 11:00 hrs.
Advt-Aug-03-26	Advertising on Station Premise (Digital)	Shakur Basti	Start: 21.08.2026 at 11:00 hrs.
Advt-Aug-03-26	Advertising on Station Premise (Non-Digital)	Shakur Basti	Start: 21.08.2026 at 11:00 hrs.
Advt-Aug-03-26	Rail Coach Restaurant	Chanakya Puri	Start: 21.08.2026 at 11:00 hrs.
Advt-Aug-04-26	Waiting Area(AC)	New Delhi, First Floor (Ajmeri Gate Side)	Start: 28.08.2026 at 11:00 hrs.
Advt-Aug-04-26	Advertising on Station Premise (Digital)	Hazrat Nizamuddin	Start: 28.08.2026 at 11:00 hrs.

Website particulars where complete details of E-Auction can be seen
No.: 7PUB/e-Auction/NIT-2026 Date: 11.08.2026

<https://ireps.gov.in/>
(E-Auction-Leasing)
2780/2026

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

SNEHA HOPES TO CARRY MOMENTUM INTO 12TH LEG OF WPGT

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

■ Bengaluru

Sneha Singh, who had to fight hard to end a long winless period last week, will be hoping to take that confidence into the 12th leg of the Women's Pro Golf Tour as she faces a strong field once again this week.



Sneha's major rivals this week will include Vani Kapoor, who lost the playoff a week ago, Vidhatri Urs, Order of Merit leader Ridhima Dilawari, Amandeep Drall, Durga Nittur, Heena Kang, Mannat Brar, Anvitha Narendar and Jasmine Shekar, among others. Also back this week is Saanvi Somu, who has been gaining a lot of experience on the Ladies Access Tour in Europe.

Sneha's big task will be to maintain consistency and ensure that this return to form is part of a bigger build-up. The field of 52 players has eight amateurs, including young Ayesha Gupta, who gave a good account of herself in leg 11. Almost all the top stars, who are regulars on the domestic Tour, will be in action, barring Tvesa Malik.

The prize purse once again is ₹17 lakh, with the cut coming in after two rounds. The Order of Merit leader is Ridhima, who has won three times this season and is the only multiple winner. She is followed by Jasmine Shekar, Vani Kapoor, Amandeep Drall and Vidhatri Urs on the Money List.

GOVERNMENT OF HARYANA TENDER NOTICE						
SR NO	NAME OF DEPARTMENT	NAME OF WORK NOTICE TENDER	OPENING DATE CLOSING DATE	AMOUNT / EMD (APPROX.) IN RUPEES	WEBSITE OF THE DEPARTMENT	NODAL OFFICER/CONTACT DETAILS/EMAIL
1	DIRECTORATE OF STATE TRANSPORT, HARYANA	PURCHASE OF 500 FULLY BUILT UP STANDARD NON-AC DIESEL BUSES MEETING LATEST BS-VI EMISSION NORMS.	07.08.2026 01.09.2026	174.50 CRORE	http://harttrans.gov.in	01722710371 jstchry@gmail.com
2	PWD B&R, PALWAL	SPECIAL REPAIR BY PROVIDING WDG./STG. OF VARIOUS 2 NOS. ROADS ON LINK ROAD TO KHOKIYAKA VIA PUTHLI (ID 3404) RD 0.00 TO 3.65 KM AND NUH PALWAL ROAD TO AKBARPUR NATOL VIA RIBBER (ID 3566) RD 0.00 TO 3.99 KM IN HATHIN CONSTITUENCY IN PROVINCIAL DIVISION, PWD BANDR BR., PALWAL UNDER WORK PROGRAMME 2026-27 IN PALWAL DISTT. (UNDER HEAD-5054-GROUP-5) (WITHOUT GST) + 3 WORKS	10.08.2026 19.08.2026	1535.21 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9466219169 pwd-eeepd-palwal@hry.nic.in
3	PWD B&R, YAMUNA NAGAR	RECONSTRUCTION OF GOVERNMENT VETERINARY DISPENSARY AT VILLAGE HARNOL IN YAMUNA NAGAR DISTRICT	10.08.2026 17.08.2026	25.36 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	01732237834 pwd-eeepd-yamunananagar@hry.nic.in
4	PWD B&R, GURUGRAM	DEVELOPMENT OF LANDSCAPING AND BEAUTIFICATION WORK OF DISTRICT HOSPITAL MANDIKHERA IN DISTRICT NUH.	06.08.2026 17.08.2026	20.71 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9717214202 zilesinghort@gmail.com
5	PWD B&R, PALWAL	SPECIAL REPAIR BY PROVIDING STG WITH CCP ON PALWAL ALAWALPUR MOHNA ROAD (ID 3570 AND 3602) RD 4.05 TO 5.95 KMR IN PRITHLA CONSTITUENCY IN PROVINCIAL DIVISION, PWD BANDR BR., PALWAL UNDER WORK PROGRAMME 2026-27 IN PALWAL DISTT. (UNDER HEAD-5054-GROUP-1) (WITHOUT GST).	10.08.2026 24.08.2026	525.50 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9466219169 pwd-eeepd-palwal@hry.nic.in
6	PWD B&R, HISAR	CONSTRUCTION OF SLIP ROADS INCLUDING THE CONSTRUCTION OF BOX TYPE BRIDGE ON LALSAMAND SUB BRANCH AT THE INTERSECTION OF HISARA&RAJGARH ROAD AND SOUTHERN BYPASS IN DISTRICT HISAR. + 2 WORKS	CLOSING DATE 17.08.2026	823.09 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9878384499 pwd-eeepd-1-hissar@hry.nic.in
7	PWD B&R, HISAR	CONSTRUCTION OF 100 BEDDED HOSPITAL AT TOHANA IN DISTT. FATEHABD (PDG. 100 KW SOLAR POWER PLANT AND 500 LPH 4.NOS. SOLAR WATER HEATING SYSTEM)	07.08.2026 17.08.2026	59.22 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	01662225651 pwd-eeed-hissar@hry.nic.in
8	PWD B&R, HISAR	PROVIDING 11 KV INDEPENDENT FEEDER CONNECTION FOR NEWLY CONSTRUCTED MINI SECTT. BUILDING AT CHARKHI DADR.	07.08.2026 14.08.2026	192.27 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	1662225651 pwd-eeed-hissar@hry.nic.in
9	PWD B&R, HISAR	CONSTRUCTION OF GOVT. COLLEGE FOR GIRLS, MANGALI, DISTRICT HISAR(PDG. 11 KV ELECTRIC SUBSTATION AND DG SET ONLY)	07.08.2026 14.08.2026	39.75 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	1662225651 pwd-eeed-hissar@hry.nic.in
10	PWD B&R, HISAR	CONSTRUCTION OF 50 BEDDED TO 100 BEDDED HOSPITAL AT NARNAUND IN DISTT. HISAR (PDG. EXTENSION OF EXISTING FEEDER OF CHC NARNAUND FOR NEWLY CONSTRUCTED HOSPITAL BUILDING AT NARNAUND IN DISTT. HANSI)	07.08.2026 13.08.2026	6.72 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	01662225651 pwd-eeed-hissar@hry.nic.in
11	PWD B&R, HISAR	CONSTRUCTION OF NEW MINI SECTT. AT CHARKHI DADR (PDG. CASSETTE AC AND VRV/VRF SYSTEM ONLY) + 1 WORKS	07.08.2026 13.08.2026	54.25 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	01662225651 pwd-eeed-hissar@hry.nic.in
12	PWD B&R, HISAR	UPGRADATION OF ELECTRIC SUB STATION INSTALLED IN MINI SECTT. SIRSA	07.08.2026 14.08.2026	57.14 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	01662225651 pwd-eeed-hissar@hry.nic.in
13	PWD B&R, JIND	CONSTRUCTION/RE-CONSTRUCTION OF BOUNDARY WALL OF JUDICIAL COMPLEX AT SAFIDON IN JIND DISTT.	CLOSING DATE 14.08.2026	21.76 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	8398098075 pwddeepdjind@gmail.com
14	KALPANA CHAWLA GOVT. MEDICAL COLLEGE,KARNAL	REGARDING E-TENDER FOR MEDICAL EQUIPMENT /INSTRUMENT (PORTABLE ILLUMINATION UNIT WITH HEAD BAND, FIBER OPTIC CABLE, NASAL BONE FRACTURE REDUCTION SET ETC.) AT KCGMC, KARNAL.	14.08.2026 24.08.2026	EMD 10000	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9992132741 director.kgchc-hry@gov.in
15	PANCHAYATI RAJ, SONIPAT	CONSTRUCTION OF BRICK PAVED RASTA FROM DHATURI MOR TO GAUSHALA ROAD VILL MURTHAL + 1 WORKS	05.08.2026 13.08.2026	63.98 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9416391006 prexeengzp.snp@gmail.com
16	PANCHAYATI RAJ ,KARNAL	CONST. OF HALL IN DADA KALA PHEER AT VILLAGE GAGSINA, BLOCK MUNAK, DISTT. KARNAL + 4 WORKS	08.08.2026 18.08.2026	77.20 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9896634422 prexeeng.krl@hry.nic.in
17	PANCHAYATI RAJ ,KARNAL	CONSTRUCTION OF GRAM SACHIVALAYA AT VILLAGE BALLAH, BLOCK MUNAK, DISTT. KARNAL + 11 WORKS	05.08.2026 15.08.2026	303.58 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9896634422 prexeeng.krl@hry.nic.in
18	DIRECTOR GENERAL, SUPPLIES & DISPOSALS PANCHKULA, HARYANA	PROCUREMENT OF WATER TANK	08.08.2026 07.09.2026		https://etenders.hry.nic.in dsndharyana.gov.in	0172-2570122 Supplies@hry.nic.in
19	IRRIGATION & WATER RESOURCES DEPARTMENT HARYANA, CHARKHI DADR	REPALCEMENT OF TILE TRACING AND PAINTING OF SWITCH ROOM AT PH MC-3 + 4 WORKS	06.08.2026 17.08.2026	6.07 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	8059375563 xenmgcckd11@gmail.com
20	IRRIGATION & WATER RESOURCES DEPARTMENT HARYANA, ROHTAK	REPAIR, WHITE WASHING AND WATER PROOFING OF QUATERS TYPE-3 NEW 1 TO 24 IN CANAL COLONY ROHTAK	CLOSING DATE 13.08.2026	12.25 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9812111077 xenwsdnrtk@gmail.com
21	PANCHAYATI RAJ ,KURUKSHETRA	ISHARGARH CONSTRUCTION OF HALL FOR GENERAL PUBLIC AND RENOVATION OF LAKHISHAH BANJARA BAWL VILLAGE ISHARGARH BLOCK PIPLI (KKR)	07.08.2026 13.08.2026	40.75 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	0986224357 prexeeng.krk@hry.nic.in
22	PUBLIC HEALTH ENGINEERING, MANDI DABWALI	MANDI DABWALI:- DNIT FOR PROVIDING AND SUPPLY OF 3 NOS. HYDRAULIC-OPERATED MANHOLE DE-SILTING GRAB BUCKET TYPE MACHINES AND ALL OTHER WORKS CONTINGENT THERETO. CH. HEAD:- MANDI DABWALI:- PROVIDING SEWERAGE SYSTEM IN NEWLY APPROVED COLONY AND CONSTRUCTION OF IPS AT UTTAM NAGAR AT DABWALI TOWN DISTT. SIRSA.	05.08.2026 17.08.2026	48 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	8730000001 ee.mandidabwali@gmail.com
23	FOREST DEPARTMENT, BHIWANI	TENDER FOR BAWANI KHERA BLOCK BIO DRAINAGE PROJECT RIDGE AND PIT'S PLANTATION & 3 OTHER WORKS	07.08.2026 13.08.2026	219 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	01664-242430 dfo.bhiwani@yahoo.com

FOR FURTHER INFORMATION KINDLY VISIT www.etenders.hry.nic.in

RO 48095-I-27-7

छत्तीसगढ़ राज्य सहकारी मत्स्य महासंघ मर्यादित
मुख्यालय का पता:- मछली पालन विभाग परिसर, तेलीबांधा थाने के पास, तेलीबांधा, रायपुर, पो.आ. रविग्राम पिन कोड- 492006, फोन 0771-4267693, Email: cgmatsyamahasangh@gmail.com
क्रमांक 367/ ममसं / त्क/ जल. / 2026-27 रायपुर, दिनांक 10-08-2026

मत्स्य पालन हेतु लीज पर जलाशय आबंटन बाबत् सक्षिप्त निविदा सूचना

सर्वसाधारण को सूचित किया जाता है कि छ.ग. राज्य सहकारी मत्स्य महासंघ मर्या., रायपुर के अधीनस्थ निम्नलिखित जलाशयों को अनुबंध निष्पादन की तिथि से दिनांक 15 जून 2036 तक (दस फिशिंग वर्ष) की समयवधि के लिए मत्स्य पालन,मत्स्याखेट एवं मत्स्य विक्रय कार्य हेतु लीज पर आबंटित किये जाने बाबत् निविदाएं निम्नलिखित तिथि से सक्षम पंजीकृत मत्स्य सहकारी समिति / पंजीकृत व्यवसायिक संस्था / कंपनी / फर्म / समूह / व्यक्ति से दिनांक 21 अगस्त 2026 अपराह्न 3.00 बजे तक मत्स्य महासंघ मुख्यालय में निश्चित प्रपत्र पर सील बंद लिफाफे में आमंत्रित की जाती है, तदुपरांत प्राप्त निविदाओं को अपराह्न 4.00 बजे उपस्थित निविदाकार अथवा उनके अधिकृत प्रतिनिधि के समक्ष खोली जावेगी।

क्र.	जलाशय का नाम	औसत जलक्षेत्र (हे.)	प्रारंभिक वार्षिक लीज राशि का ऑफसेट मूल्य (रु. लाख में)	अमानत राशि (रु. लाख में)	रिमांक
1.	तांदुला, जिला-बालोद	2,275.00	27.30	2.46	सुलीय आमंत्रण
2.	दरौ (हसदेव बैराज) जिला- कोरबा	1,333.75	3.70	0.34	षष्टम् आमंत्रण

इच्छुक निविदादाता निविदा के संबंध में विस्तृत विवरण, शर्तों आदि की जानकारी एवं कोरे निविदा प्रपत्र राशि रु. 3,000 /- (तीन हजार रु.) + GST नाम भुगतान कर मत्स्य महासंघ मुख्यालय से दिनांक 20 अगस्त 2026 तक कार्यालयीन समय में प्राप्त कर सकते हैं।

प्रबंध संचालक

KOVALAM INVESTMENT AND TRADING CO. LIMITED					
Regd. Office: Premises Oswal Woollen Mills Limited G.T. Road, Shepur, Ludhiana-141003 PB CIN:L65910PB1981PLC023058, Ph.: +91-161-5066605					
Website: www.owmhar.com /kovalam, Email:kovalam@owmhar.com					
Statement of Unaudited Financial Results for the Quarter Ended 30/06/2026					
Sr. No.	Particulars	(Rs In Lakhs, unless otherwise stated)			
		Quarter Ended		Year Ended	
		30.06.2026 (Unaudited)	31.03.2026 (Audited)	30.06.2025 (Unaudited)	31.03.2026 (Audited)
1	Total Income from operations (net)	207.74	0.76	142.18	251.45
2	Net profit/(Loss) for the period (before tax)	197.78	-41.10	135.76	185.94
3	Net profit/(Loss) for the period (after tax)	185.77	-62.63	135.12	134.52
4	Total Comprehensive Income/(Loss) for the period (Comprising Profit/(Loss) for the period (after tax) and other Comprehensive Income/(Loss) (after tax))	1,957.75	-1,414.44	2,575.73	-255.98
5	Equity equity share capital (Face value : Rs.10/- per share)	222.39	222.39	222.39	222.39
6	Reserves (excluding revaluation reserve as shown in the per audited balance sheet of previous year)				7,021.17
7	Earning per share (EPS) (Rs.) Basic and Diluted EPS	8.35	-2.82	6.08	6.05
Notes:					
1. The Unaudited financial results of the Company for the Quarter ended June 30, 2026 have been reviewed by the Audit Committee and subsequently approved by the Board of Directors in their meeting held on August 11, 2026. The financial results have been subjected to Limited Review by Statutory Auditors of the Company.					
2. The above is an extract of the detailed format of Unaudited Financial Results for the quarter ended June 30, 2026 filed with the Stock Exchange under Regulation 33 of the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015. The full format of the Unaudited Financial Results for the quarter ended June 30, 2026 are available on the Stock Exchange website (www.bseindia.com) and on Company's website (www.owmhar.com)					
3. The financial results are prepared in accordance with Indian Accounting Standards (IndAS) as prescribed under Section 133 of the Companies Act, 2013 and other recognised accounting practices and policies to the extent possible.					
For and on behalf of the Board of Directors of Kovalam Investments and Trading Co Limited					
		Sd/-			
		Navdeep Sharma			
		Non-Executive - Non Independent Director			
		DIN: 00454285			
Date: 11.08.2026 Place: Ludhiana					

Gurnoor could be X-factor in Bumrah’s absence: Maharooof

TAPAN MOHANTA
■ Kolkata

Former Sri Lanka allrounder Farveez Maharooof feels rookie pacer Gurnoor Brar could be the ‘X-Factor’ in absence of Jasprit Bumrah and says he would be tempted to hand the 26-year-old his Test debut in the two-match series against Sri Lanka, beginning in Galle on Saturday.

Under pressure following home series defeat to South Africa, fifth-placed India will be without pace spearhead Jasprit Bumrah when they resume Test action with a two-match tour of Sri Lanka. Mohammed Siraj is expected to lead the pace attack but there is a speculation

whether inexperienced Brar could make his Test debut replacing Prasidh Krishna who played in the last Test against Afghanistan.

“The ability to reverse-swing the ball, especially with the older ball, is something Bumrah brings, and that is going to be a massive miss for India,” Maharooof replied to a PTI query in a virtual media interaction organised by Sony Sports Network. That is where I think they could lack some wicket-taking ability. Mohammed Siraj is a good bowler, with all due respect to him, but when you compare the two fast bowlers, there is a bit of a difference.” But at the same

time, the former pace bowling all-rounder said he would be “tempted” to give a debut to Brar especially for the fact that the tall Punjab pacer’s raw pace, bounce and aggressive approach especially the way he gave body blows to several Test-squad batters during the warm-up match.

“I really like Gurnoor Brar. I think he can be the X-factor. He has the bounce, the pace and the fighting spirit. He can be nasty,” Maharooof said.

“If you watched the warm-up game, some of the deliveries he bowled to batters who are in the Test squad made them quite uneasy, and he even hit a couple of players on the body. “If I



were in the Indian think tank, I would be tempted to give Gurnoor a go. I know he has only played white-ball cricket for India, but he brings that X-factor. In short, burst spells, when you want to break a

batter’s rhythm, he can be a lethal weapon.” Tall Punjab pacer Brar was picked for the Test squad despite having only a handful of First-Class matches and limited IPL experience. The 26-year-old Brar

subsequently made his ODI debut against Afghanistan, and has picked up 11 wickets in six matches.

Brar also featured in India A’s tour to Sri Lanka last month, picking up a 10-wicket haul in the first match at Galle. Maharooof says India will miss the now retired Ravichandran Ashwin and the injured Washington Sundar, who is ruled out of the first Test as Sri Lankan pitches often produce bounce for spinners rather than just turn. While the duo of Ravindra Jadeja and Kuldeep Yadav will be the first choice spinners there is a debate over the third spinner.

India have young left-arm spinner Manav Suthar who

claimed seven wickets on his debut against Afghanistan, while there is also uncapped 31-year-old offspinner Saransh Jain who toured Sri Lanka with India A and claimed seven wickets and also made an unbeaten 70 batting at No. 7. But Maharooof feels Suthar with ability to generate bounce should have the edge even as that makes it all three left-arm spinners. “If you ask me, I would be tempted to go with the two left-arm spinners as well as Kuldeep Yadav. Kuldeep is a frontrunner to start in Galle, especially considering his record and the number of wickets he took in the last Test against Afghanistan. “I see three spin-

ners for India. Jadeja, Kuldeep Yadav and either Suthar or Jain. Ideally, you would like an off-spinner for variation, but I would not be surprised if Manav Suthar plays because his ability to get bounce off the surface could be very handy in Galle.” “Overall, looking at India’s bowling line-up, it is quite competitive, with two seamers and three spinners.”

India’s keeper-batter Rishabh Pant may be struggling at the moment but Maharooof feels he could be dangerous and take the match away with his technique. Pant got out for 2 and 28 in the warmup game that they won by six wickets in Colombo. (PTI)

Fewer bilateral series in future but hard to think cricket without ODIs: Rhodes

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Former South Africa cricketer Jonty Rhodes has said there could be fewer bilateral ODI series in the future, but said it is difficult to imagine cricket without the 50-over format. Rhodes believes fans will continue to turn up to support their teams regardless of the format, while acknowledging that the 50-over game could face challenges in the years ahead.

“When T20 cricket first started, people were saying it is going to put pressure on Test cricket and amazingly it has not. Some of the Test cricket looks like T20 at times, there is some aggressive batting and bowling,” Rhodes told the media during the jersey launch of European T20 Premier

League (ETPL) team Rotterdam Dockers here on Tuesday. Rotterdam Dockers, co-owned by Rhodes, will feature in the inaugural edition of the ETPL, to be held in Voorburg, the Netherlands, and Dublin from August 26 to September 20. “For me, it is always understanding that 50-overs cricket might be the one format where -- because we bring in such a fresh crowd and a different perspective into the game -- possibly 50-overs cricket might be in trouble in the years ahead.

“From a point of view, we’re really fortunate that what 50-overs cricket has is that you’ve got really passionate fans who will support their team no matter what format or version it is,” Rhodes said.

Rhodes continued, “At this



stage, I think there will be fewer and fewer bilateral series... but it is very difficult to think of cricket without the 50-over version.”

Rhodes said the growing number of T20 leagues around the world could prompt players to retire from international cricket earlier.

“We’ve seen a FIFA World Cup football and the passion that people have for playing for their country, it’s often

the case because they don’t get to play that often. So outside of a FIFA World Cup year, most of those international stars are playing for their clubs and their franchises and you might see more and more of that happening on a cricketing perspective,” he said. “To have three different formats within cricket competing with franchise cricket around the world, players will start making a

choice and that choice will be ending their international career slightly earlier,” Rhodes added.

Rhodes expressed confidence that South Africa can go the distance at next year’s ODI World Cup, which the country will co-host with Zimbabwe and Namibia.

“We as South Africans are looking forward to hosting it. It’s been a while and it’s great that it’s come around again. Good timing for us, the team is playing pretty well,” he said. “There’s a few things that we would like to settle and one of those is obviously winning an ICC limited-overs trophy,” Rhodes added.

Rhodes said fielding has evolved significantly since his playing days, with players themselves taking greater initiative to raise standards.

“It actually came from the

players themselves and that for me is a real revelation to see how the players practice these days. We see some great things happening on the field and the reason is because they put the hours into practice doing exactly that,” he said.

“The positional play, and what we saw 10 years ago, you could have three or four good fielders and you could hide four or five players. These days, you can’t even hide one.

“(In the Indian team) Virat Kohli insisted that you had to be fit and you had to be a good fielder and fairly robust in the field and athletic, and the fitness levels were important. We’ve seen the evolution in India of a team that had one or two great fielders to now a team that there’s nobody to hide,” he added.

Atiqa records two top-10 finishes in F1 of karting



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Kristianstad (Sweden)

Racing sensation Atiqa Mir added another feather to her cap by becoming the youngest Indian to collect a couple of impressive top-10 finishes in Round 4 of the FIA European Championship, a marquee event in the world of karting.

Atiqa, all of 11, showed tremendous speed and fight to achieve a ninth and 11th place in the heat races in the 12-14 age category. Atiqa, the first Indian to be backed by FI Academy, qualified P11, which was remarkably only 0.13 seconds off the fastest time, reflecting the intensely competitive nature of the grid.

Driving as a wildcard in only her second ever FIA event, the Indian with Kashmiri roots battled hard with drivers as old as 14 despite being among the youngest on the grid.

Atiqa has got race wins and pole positions under her belt in a fast rising career but considering the challenge at hand in the FIA European Championship, which is

dubbed as ‘Formula 1’ of the karting world, she was pleased with her performance in Sweden.

“I’m super happy with my performance here. We achieved all our targets and we have a good technical understanding of these FIA events. I’ve improved my driving as well and I feel with some more experience I can fight towards the front of the grid. I feel ready for a full championship next year,” she said. Atiqa’s father Asif Mir, India’s first national karting champion, felt she exceeded expectations with her performance against drivers with a lot more experience. “Atiqa showed a lot of maturity far beyond her age. She was up against all star karters of the world including Formula 1 junior development drivers. Her speed in qualifying against them was very encouraging with only a tenth of a second separating her from the fastest time. She still has a lot to learn and driving amongst the best drivers in the world gives her an opportunity to learn from them.

Virat’s intensity inspires others to stretch limits when fielding with him: Dilip

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Former India fielding coach T Dilip says Virat Kohli’s relentless intensity has a contagious effect on the team and pushes at least five other players to “stretch their limits” whenever they share the ground with him.

Dilip, whose nearly five-year stint with the Indian team ended after the recent tour of England, also lauded Kohli’s ability to maintain the same intensity in training and matches as one of the biggest influences on India’s fielding standards.

“When it comes to Virat Kohli, intensity is non-negotiable. You have seen him in



the powerplay, how he is as a batsman, whether at cover or short mid-wicket, with his reflexes and with his dives, is admirable,” Dilip told ‘JioStar’.

“Even in the last series, he was putting in those dives

and was sharp, always at you all the time.

“Even at this juncture of his career, he runs from long-on to long-on at either end during the death overs, and he is the first one to run out of the circle when the field is

spread, and that’s a fabulous thing to do for the team.”

Dilip, however, said Kohli’s influence extends beyond the moments when the ball comes his way.

“But what impressed me more is not just the actions, what he does when the ball is at him, but also when the ball is not near him, he wants the ball in his hands,” he said.

“With Virat Kohli, there is not much difference between him in a practice session and a match, because it’s not just Virat; it’s the five other players who have stretched their limits when they are fielding with Virat Kohli. That’s the influence he brings into the group.” Dilip’s tenure as

India’s fielding coach included the team’s triumph in the 2024 T20 World Cup in Barbados, which he described as the best moment of his stint.

“If I go back to my best moment, I think Barbados 2024, not just the trophy, but the dressing room atmosphere afterwards, the silence for a few seconds before it broke. I could sense the amount of hard work the boys had put in over those four years. And I’ll always keep that frame in my mind,” he said.

Dilip also recalled the emotions surrounding Suryakumar Yadav’s spectacular catch to dismiss David Miller in the final over

of the 2024 T20 World Cup final. “For the first few seconds, I was silent and calm physically because my mind was doing all the calculations, whether Surya had taken that ball cleanly, whether his feet were inside the boundary rope, whether he had popped the ball out in time.

“But once it was confirmed that it was a clean catch, there was a surge of emotions. But in the back of my mind, I also knew that the match had yet to be completed.” Dilip also spoke about the fielding medal introduced during his tenure, saying it helped create healthy competition among the players.

30 teams to compete in 16th junior women’s hockey championship

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

A total of 30 teams will participate across three divisions in the 16th Hockey India Junior Women National Championship 2026 to get underway in Pune from Wednesday.

The tournament will continue until August 23, with the teams competing for the national title as well as promotion and relegation across the divisions.

The championship will feature Division ‘A’, Division ‘B’ and Division ‘C’, with the three categories providing a pathway for teams to compete at their respective levels and progress through the national championship

system. The division-based format will see teams battle not only for the title but also for promotion to a higher division. The Division ‘A’, comprising 12 teams, has been divided into four pools. Pool A features Jharkhand, Punjab and Chandigarh, while Pool B consists of Haryana, Odisha and Bengal.

Pool C includes Uttar Pradesh, Maharashtra, and Manipur. Chhattisgarh, Madhya Pradesh and Himachal are in Pool D.

The Division ‘A’ league stage will begin on August 16, with each team playing against the other teams in its respective pool. The top two teams from each pool will advance to the quarterfinals, scheduled for August 20. The



semifinals will be played on August 21, followed by the 3rd-4th place match, and the final, on August 23.

The 12 teams in Division ‘A’ will be competing for the coveted national championship title, while the teams finishing 11th and 12th overall will be relegated to Division

‘B’ for the next edition.

The Division ‘B’ will feature 10 teams divided into two pools. Pool A comprises Andhra Pradesh, Assam, Delhi, Kerala and Mizoram while Pool B includes Karnataka, Uttarakhand, Tamil Nadu, Bihar, and Goa. The top two teams from this

division will earn promotion to Division ‘A’, while the bottom two teams will be relegated to Division ‘C’.

The Division ‘C’ will feature eight teams divided into two pools. Pool A consists of Arunachal, Dadra & Nagar Haveli and Daman & Diu, Rajasthan, and Tripura, while Pool B includes Puducherry, Gujarat, Jammu & Kashmir, and Telangana. The top two teams from this category will earn promotion to Division ‘B’ for the next edition.

Hockey India president Dilip Tirkey said, “With teams competing across three divisions, the tournament will provide young players with valuable competitive exposure while strengthening the domestic pathway.”

Indian fencers add seven more medals on day 2 of U-23 Commonwealth fencing

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Indian fencers continued their impressive run at the U-23 Commonwealth Fencing Championship in Lagos, Nigeria, by clinching seven medals on the second day of competition.

India had secured 17 medals, including four gold, at the event on the opening day, dominating both the men’s and women’s individual events. Competing across the senior individual events in women’s Sabre, women’s Epee, and men’s Foil, India added one gold, two silver, and four bronze



medals to its growing tally on Monday night. The Indian squad staged a stellar display in the senior women’s Epee event, asserting strong control over the podium. Tanishka Khatri won the gold medal while teammate Khushi Dabhade

secured silver. Prachi Lohan added to the tally by sharing the bronze with Australia’s Harrison Asley. In the senior women’s Sabre individual category, India delivered another impressive performance by bagging three podium spots.

Nations Cup was great success, now determined to win WC: Salima Tete

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Indian women’s hockey captain Salima Tete believes the team’s recent Nations Cup triumph has given the side the confidence to compete for the top prize in the FIH Women’s World Cup 2026, despite being handed a challenging pool.

India head into the World Cup on the back of winning the FIH Nations Cup in New



Zealand, and Tete believes the momentum from that success can propel the team

to another medal-winning campaign on the biggest stage, the World Cup, to be held at jointly hosted by the Netherlands and Belgium from August 15 to 30.

“This time, the FIH Hockey World Cup will be ours. We will play smart, attacking hockey and bring back a medal. I have full belief in my team. We have the ability to do it,” Tete told JioStar.

Hockey WC: Jugraj sees his reflection in Harmanpreet, calls him trump card

MONA PARTHSARATHI
■ New Delhi

Former India drag-flicker Jugraj Singh sees shades of his own aggressive game in Harmanpreet Singh, terming him “trump card” at the FIH World Cup, beginning this week. A product of the Surjit Hockey Academy like Harmanpreet, Jugraj said the India captain’s aggressive approach often reminds him of his own playing days.

“His style is exactly like mine. His playing style and

aggression remind me of myself. I see my reflection in him,” Jugraj said.

“I even tell him, ‘You are playing,’ and I feel like I am on the field.” Jugraj, whose promising international career was cut short by a car accident in 2003, rates Harmanpreet among the world’s top three drag-flickers and feels the India captain has developed into a player the team can rely on in crucial moments.

“Harmanpreet is currently one of the top three drag-flickers in the world. He has been



playing brilliantly since the Tokyo Olympics. A player who consistently performs well when the team needs him is a ‘trump card’, and I think that player will be Harmanpreet,” Jugraj told PTI in an interview. “He has also worked hard on his fitness,” he added. Jugraj, 43, was the star of India’s title-winning campaign at the 2001 Junior World Cup in Hobart and was regarded as one of the finest drag-flickers of his generation, alongside Pakistan’s Sohail Abbas and Germany’s Florian Kunz. (PTI)